

RIFT ASCENDANT · WARDEN'S EDITION

Run Silent

A mature survival and psychological horror campaign for Levels 1-10, set inside the Gloamreach — a country-sized S-Rank Rift Interior, old and inhabited, hunted by an unseen apex predator the natives call the Quiet.

Generated from the live compendium module · v11 · 2026-06-20
42 chapters · 10 appendices · 73 allies · 24 handouts

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Rift Ascendant Lore: The Rift Age and the Gloamreach

Rift Ascendant — World Lore

Source Authority

This document is the campaign-facing world lore for **The Shadow of the Regent**, and the canonical world reference included in the app. Its foundation is the official **Rift Ascendant: Player's Guide to the World**; the closing **Campaign Layer** section adds the deeper canon this adventure relies on (persistent Rift Interiors, Anchors, Regents, pantheon signatures, Subject Zero, and the Gloamreach). Use the Player's Guide terminology everywhere: **Rift**, **Rift Threshold**, **Rift Interior**, **Rift Site**, **Rift Clear**, **Rift Break**, **Anomaly**, **Essence**, **Relic**, **Ascendant**, **Awakening**, **Bureau**, **Guild**, **Rank**, **AFA**, **Job**, **Path**.

The Rift Age

Rift Ascendant takes place on a modern, Earth-like world transformed by the arrival of **Rifts**. This is **not** a fallen world. Cities still shine at night. People go to work, pay rent, follow celebrities, argue politics, fall in love, and worry about money. Governments pass laws; corporations compete; hospitals treat the sick. The difference is that reality now has doors where doors should not be.

A **Rift** is a tear in the structure of the world. Some last only minutes. Others stabilize into dangerous thresholds that open into impossible interior spaces — some small enough to clear in hours, some large enough to contain cities, ecosystems, ruins, and weather that does not belong to Earth.

Humanity did not collapse. It adapted. New agencies formed, new industries were born, new careers and celebrities and weapons and religions appeared, and new markets grew around **Essence**, **Relics**, and Rift materials. And new kinds of people **Awakened** — the **Ascendants**, the rare individuals who can enter Rifts, survive what lives there, and fight the **Anomalies** within.

The core truth: Rifts are dangerous, but they are part of modern life. Most people will never enter one; everyone knows they exist. To civilians, Rifts are disasters, resources, miracles, and nightmares at once. To governments, public-safety threats and strategic assets. To corporations, markets. To guilds, contracts. To Ascendants, the place where reputations are made, fortunes are won, and bodies are left behind. The world has learned to live with Rifts. It has not mastered them.

A Brief History

- **Before the Rifts** — history looked much like our own; other worlds and hidden powers were folklore.
- **First Contact** — the first confirmed Rifts were treated as isolated disasters. Conventional forces tried to enter and clear them, and failed often enough that the world changed its approach.

- **The First Awakened** — Ascendants emerged during the early disasters: survivors, soldiers, exposed civilians, some who Awakened without ever approaching a Rift. No single explanation satisfied anyone; what mattered was that they could do what ordinary humans could not.
- **The Bureau Era** — governments created regulatory agencies to classify Rifts, license Ascendants, and keep Rift response from becoming uncontrolled warfare. The largest is simply called **the Bureau**.
- **The Guild Boom** — once Essence and Relics proved valuable, private Ascendant **guilds** became unavoidable — emergency teams, mercenary companies, corporate brands, family crews, and worse.
- **The Modern Rift Age** — the world has normalized the impossible: Rift alerts on phones, Ascendant rankings trending online, Essence medicine, Relic auctions, raid footage, fans and sponsors and scandals — and a black market in cores, forged clearances, and unregistered Rift maps.

Rifts

Most people use "Rift" broadly. Specialists are precise:

- **Rift Threshold** — the entrance: a glowing rupture, a dark doorway, a distortion, a mirror-like surface, an opening in the ground. Some are stable; some pulse, flicker, widen, shrink, or move.
- **Rift Interior** — the space beyond: a cave system, ruined temple, abandoned city block, flooded station, black forest, frozen fortress, impossible skyscraper, or living maze. Low-rank Interiors clear in hours; high-rank ones can demand days, weeks, or multiple operations.
- **Rift Site** — the area around an active Rift in the normal world: Bureau barricades, medical tents, police lines, media zones, guild staging, Essence containment, evacuation points. A mix of crime scene, military checkpoint, film set, and corporate trade show.
- **Rift Clear** — a successful operation that neutralizes the primary threat. Not always clean: teams return wounded, civilians are lost, Anomalies escape — or a Rift is declared cleared because that is what the report needs to say.
- **Rift Break** — containment fails and Rift conditions spill into the normal world. Anomalies emerge; weather distorts; structures warp; roads stop leading where they should; communication fails. Most Breaks are contained quickly. The ones that are not become history.

Anomalies

Anomalies are the creatures, entities, hazards, and lifeforms found inside Rifts. The public calls them monsters — sometimes accurately. They can be beasts, spirits, constructs, parasites, humanoids, swarms, living weapons, machines, warped animals, memory-echoes, or things that fit no known category. Some are mindless; some are clever, capable of tactics, speech, building, or worship; some follow laws and hierarchies humanity barely understands. To civilians the distinction rarely matters. To Ascendants it can save a team: a predator can be baited, a soldier misled, a guardian bypassed, a parasite contained — and an intelligent Anomaly can negotiate, lie, threaten, plead, or **remember**.

Native Inhabitants

Anomalies are not a Rift's only inhabitants. Not every Interior is empty of people. Especially in high-rank, persistent Interiors, an operation may find **native inhabitants** — peoples, settlements,

families, and cultures **native to the Interior's own world**, neither Anomalies nor visitors from the material world. The *doorway* is new; the world beyond it is not. These are not humans from Earth who wandered in and got trapped — they are a population that was always there, in a reality the Rift has only just connected to ours. They farm, trade, worship, grieve, raise children, and obey laws that were old before any Ascendant arrived. Some are friendly; some are desperate; some serve whatever rules their Interior. To a strike team trained to clear monsters, the hardest Rifts are the ones with a population — because then a Rift Clear is no longer only a fight. It is a question of what happens to everyone who already lives there.

Essence

Essence is the most important resource of the Rift Age — the energy, material, residue, crystal, or core recovered from Rifts and Anomalies. It appears as glowing crystals, harvested cores, liquid, dust, thread, bone, metal, or compressed mana. Essence revolutionized technology, medicine, weapons, construction, and computing. It made Ascendants necessary and profitable. Every Rift operation has two public goals — contain the threat and protect civilians — and usually a third: recover Essence before someone else does.

Relics

Relics are objects recovered from Rifts or created through Rift-touched processes: weapons, armor, tools, implants, masks, rings, books, lenses, engines, instruments. A low-grade Relic improves survivability; a high-grade Relic can define a career. Relics can be legal, restricted, classified, stolen, cursed, experimental, counterfeit, or impossible to categorize. Some are mass-reproduced in weaker forms; some are unique, named, and seem to **choose** their users; some should never have left the Rift.

Ascendants

Ascendants have Awakened the ability to survive, fight, and act within Rifts. **Awakening** changes a person — dramatically or subtly, through visions, pain, fever, transformation, or sudden instinctive knowledge. No one fully understands why it happens. What matters is that an Ascendant can channel mana, withstand Rift pressure, fight Anomalies, wield Relics safely, and enter the impossible and come back. Sometimes.

Being an Ascendant does not automatically make someone rich or respected. Rank, guild membership, public image, clear record, sponsorship, class, nationality, Bureau relationship, and luck all matter. Some become celebrities; some are low-rank laborers clearing minor Rifts for poor pay; some retire early because trauma ended their career; some disappear.

Jobs

A **Job** is the Bureau's classification for the broad shape of an Ascendant's power — the setting's equivalent of a 5e class. It is not a profession chosen from a catalog; it is the label placed on how power expresses itself. Common Job archetypes:

Destroyer, Berserker, Assassin, Striker, Mage, Esper, Revenant, Summoner, Herald, Contractor, Stalker, Holy Knight, Technomancer, Idol.

Paths

A **Path** is the specialized expression of a Job — the setting's equivalent of a 5e subclass. It may emerge from training, instinct, trauma, culture, doctrine, Relic exposure, or repeated Rift experience. Two Mages may look nothing alike: a Detonation specialist, a Shield Architect, a probability-bender.

Rank

Rank is the world's attempt to measure the impossible. Rifts, Anomalies, Relics, and Ascendants are classified **E through S**. Lower ranks are common and usually manageable by trained teams; higher ranks demand elite Ascendants, planning, and Bureau oversight. An **S-Rank** event is political, economic, military, and historical. Rank determines pay, contracts, fame, and legal freedom — but **Rank is not truth**. Rifts can be misclassified, Ascendants underestimated, Anomalies can evolve, and a routine clear can become a disaster. Veterans respect Rank. They do not worship it.

Institutions & Society

- **The Bureau** — the official regulatory and response authority: it classifies Rifts, licenses Ascendants, issues clearances, tracks Rank, coordinates public safety, regulates Essence and Relic recovery, and maintains casualty records. The Bureau is an institution, not a personality — brave responders, brilliant researchers, exhausted clerks, political operators, idealists, and the occasional corrupt official, all inside a machine too large to care about every case. Many civilians trust it because they must; many Ascendants distrust how its reports are written after things go wrong. Both can be true.
- **Guilds** — private organizations built on Ascendant labor: friend-crews, regional response companies, celebrity teams, paramilitary contractors, corporate brands, religious orders, black-market fronts. A good guild offers training, medical support, legal coverage, and benefits; a bad one treats Ascendants as replaceable tools.
- **Corporations** — turned the Rift Age into a trillion-credit economy: Essence tech, mana-compatible weapons, Rift-resistant materials, media empires. Some save lives; some knowingly send people into danger; most do both, depending on the quarter.
- **Civilians** — the vast majority, who experience the Rift Age through its effects: following rankings like sports, working guild offices, teaching children Rift-alert drills, protesting Essence refineries, worshipping or resenting Ascendants, grieving those lost to a Break.
- **Media, Law, Faith** — Ascendants are public figures with fans, sponsors, and scandals. Where there are Rifts there is crime: illegal entry, Essence smuggling, Relic theft, forged clearances, debt contracts. And the Rifts reshaped belief: faiths that call them divine tests or wounds in creation, and new cults formed around Essence, Awakening, Anomalies, and the idea that Rifts are not invasions but **invitations**.

Technology & the AFA

Modern technology still works — phones, drones, firearms, hospitals, body armor. Essence added new tools: mana scanners, Rift-resistant armor, resonance sensors, Essence batteries, containment fields, anti-Anomaly munitions. But **inside** Rifts, reliability varies: signals fail, drones lose navigation, firearms jam in mana interference, digital maps distort, sensors return impossible readings.

The **AFA (Ascendant Field App)** is the standard field interface for licensed Ascendants — a phone app, wrist device, visor, earpiece, tablet, implant display, or guild OS. It tracks mission data, team status, injury warnings, Rift readings, Rank estimates, Essence signatures, contract terms, map data, and

Bureau notices. **The AFA is not magic and not fate. It does not make decisions for you. It measures, records, warns, and reports.** Inside a Rift it is only as reliable as conditions allow. *If your AFA says everything is fine while your instincts say otherwise, trust your instincts.*

Tone

Rift Ascendant is **modern action fantasy with danger beyond the threshold**. The outside world is modern, functional, commercial, political, and alive — contracts, cameras, sponsors, laws, hospitals, rankings, family obligations. The inside of a Rift is where the rules become uncertain — Anomalies, Essence, Relics, impossible environments, strange laws, broken maps, unreliable signals, and choices no contract prepared you for. The setting is not about a ruined world; it is about a normal world that has learned to profit from the impossible, and about people with extraordinary power trying to stay human while everyone else decides what that power is worth.

Campaign Layer — Domains, Anchors & the Gloamreach

*The following deepens the Player's Guide for high-rank, persistent Rifts. These concepts are the spine of **The Shadow of the Regent**.*

Persistent Rift Interiors — "Domains"

Most Rift Interiors are limited: a ruin, a tunnel, a pocket battlefield. But a **high-rank Rift Interior can stabilize into a whole interior realm** — a valley with weather, roads, settlements, a citadel, a dead sea, a predator forest, a buried archive — large enough to lose armies inside. When such an Interior grows persistent and takes on its own enforceable laws, Wardens call it a **Domain**. The Rift Threshold is only the door; the Domain beyond it is the adventure.

Anchors

Every persistent Domain has an **Anchor** — the thing that keeps its Threshold stable and gives the Interior its laws. Common Anchors include a ruling Anomaly intelligence, a **Regent**, a Relic engine, a domain heart, an Essence furnace, a bound pantheon signature, or a living ecology that has become self-aware. **Clearing a Domain means breaking, sealing, transforming, or extracting the Anchor.** Killing every creature inside is not enough while the Anchor — and its law — survives.

Contained vs. Rift Break

While a Domain is **contained**, the Bureau can measure the Threshold, issue Rank clearance, deploy Ascendants, and hold a cordon. A **Rift Break** is the failure state: containment collapses and the Interior begins to **overwrite the material side** — weather first, then terrain, then Anomalies, then the Anchor's law itself. *The Bureau calls a Rift safe while its instruments still have numbers.* Numbers run out.

Regents

A **Regent** is not merely a powerful Anomaly; a Regent is **domain authority with will**. When a Regent becomes a Domain's Anchor, the land itself behaves like a body and a court. Regents do not simply wait in a final room — they wear the faces of the dead, alter roads, bargain through Relics, hollow out settlements, raise servants from the claimed, and study intruders without ever being seen to look. Their horror is not size. It is that inside a Regent's Domain, nothing goes unseen and nothing is ever truly free.

The Pantheon

The **Eternals and Exarchs** are the distant powers of the Rift Ascendant cosmos, and they behave like a distant pantheon — much like the gods of older myth. They do not walk inside a Domain, do not take sides, and are never the explanation for a site, a monster, or a Regent. At most they are felt the way old gods are felt: a half-glimpsed omen, a folk-shrine that has not answered in living memory, a name in a prayer no one truly expects to be heard. A campaign can run from threshold to throne and never need to name one of them.

Treat the pantheon as deep background, never as a mechanic. The dread inside a Domain comes from the Domain itself — from what it does to the living and what it makes of the dead — not from the powers watching, if they watch at all, from very far away.

Subject Zero

Subject Zero is an older, sealed **S-Rank Anomaly** whose pressure leaks into some high-rank Domains. It is **not** the Regent and is not loyal to him — an outside hunger that can offer power through forbidden bargains (the campaign's "Unseated Law" lever). When Subject Zero touches a Domain, the bargain should be real, useful, and costly.

The Gloamreach

The Gloamreach is the **S-Rank Rift Interior** of *The Shadow of the Regent* — a country-sized persistent Domain behind one stabilized Threshold. It has roads, settlements, ruins, mills, warrens, predator ranges, a fallen bastion, a forbidden vault, and a citadel visible from almost everywhere. **The Regent is the Gloamreach's Anchor**. Its terrors are its own: a drowned hospital-fen that remembers the dead and the not-yet-dead, caverns where the rot learns your sleeping face, an orchard that fruits stolen memories, a hall where the burning dead are never allowed to stop, roads that watch and move and lengthen, settlements surviving on tribute paid to things best left unnamed, and over all of it a Regent who sees everything in his country and wears the faces of everyone it has swallowed.

The material side matters as the place the party leaves, the place the Rift may Break into, and the place that must live with the ending.

Campaign Tone

The Shadow of the Regent is hard **paranormal / dark-fantasy horror** inside a Rift Interior: scarcity without mercy; settlements surviving by tribute; Ascendants reduced from elite operators to trapped prey; Bureau failure recorded in clean language; Vermillion pragmatism that saves and exploits; Anomalies as ecology, punishment, livestock, and omen; Relics that solve problems by teaching the party to think like the Domain; and a Regent who is charismatic, predatory, and patient. The world should feel modern in tools and institutions, but the adventure space is the Rift Interior. **Roads should be wrong.**

Weather should judge. Safe places should feel leased, not owned. Every clear should ask what the party gave up to survive.

Glossary

AFA — Ascendant Field App; a field interface that tracks mission data, team status, Rift readings, injuries, contracts, and alerts. It measures and reports; it does not grant destiny. · **Anchor** (*campaign*) — the entity or structure that stabilizes a persistent Rift Interior and sets its laws. · **Anomaly** — a creature, entity, hazard, or lifeform from within a Rift. · **Ascendant** — a person who has Awakened the ability to operate inside Rifts. · **Awakening** — the event or process by which a person becomes an Ascendant. · **Bureau** — the official institution for Rift regulation, licensing, classification, and public safety. · **Domain** (*campaign*) — a persistent, ruled Rift Interior large enough to behave like a country. · **Essence** — energy, material, or cores recovered from Rifts and Anomalies. · **Guild** — a private Ascendant organization. · **Job** — the broad classification of an Ascendant's power (5e class). · **Path** — the specialized expression of a Job (5e subclass). · **Rank** — the E–S classification of Rifts, Anomalies, Relics, and Ascendants. · **Regent** (*campaign*) — a Domain Anchor that is "authority with will." · **Relic** — a powerful object recovered from or created through Rift forces. · **Rift** — a tear in reality leading to an impossible interior space. · **Rift Break** — a containment failure where Anomalies or Rift conditions spill into the normal world. · **Rift Clear** — a successful operation that neutralizes a Rift's primary threat. · **Rift Interior** — the space beyond a Rift Threshold. · **Rift Site** — the operation area surrounding an active Rift. · **Rift Threshold** — the visible entrance into a Rift.

Chapter 0: Day Zero - The Memory-Care Wing

Day Zero - The Memory-Care Wing

A Rift that feeds on memory is not merely an opening. It is the first time a place learns your name. - Dr. Serin Hayashi, private margin note

Purpose

Run this one-to-two session horror prelude before the party enters the Gloamreach. The characters are still on the material side, inside the Bureau cordon surrounding the S-Rank Rift. The Memory-Care Wing is a small pocket breach created by pressure leaking from the Gloamreach. It introduces the campaign's real themes: memory, names, the dead the dark keeps and wears, civilian cost, and the terror of something that reaches through the door before anyone steps inside.

The party begins at Level 1 and reaches Level 2 at the end of this chapter.

The Hook - Welfare Check

A shuttered hospital wing inside the cordon has gone silent. It houses elderly civilians who could not be moved when the Bureau perimeter collapsed inward. The night staff missed their check-in. A drone pass showed the windows fogged from inside. No portal is visible, but the AFA readings show a low-rank pocket breach behind one resident's bathroom mirror.

Read aloud:

The dispatcher slides a cracked tablet across the counter. The image shows a brick hospital wing behind temporary Bureau fencing. Every window is fogged white from the inside. "Twenty-three residents, six staff, no confirmed hostiles. We have senior Ascendants preparing for the S-Rank threshold. You are what we have left. Be careful. Most of them will not understand what is happening."

The Wing

The building is too warm. The heat is off. A radio plays static in a language no one recognizes. When the party crosses the threshold, each character makes a DC 10 Sense save. On a failure, the character forgets a harmless but personal detail for one hour: a badge number, a favorite song, a friend's birthday, the smell of home.

This is not a punishment. It is a warning.

Keyed Rooms

R1. Reception - The Visitors' Log

The reception desk is clean. A potted orchid has been freshly watered. A visitors' log sits open.

Every entry is written in the same hand. Different names. Same ink. Same arrival time. Same departure time. The next blank line already has the first stroke of a party member's name.

Clue: the handwriting matches Ms. Park Jeong-hye in R4. Writing a name in the log grants advantage on the next Sense save in the Wing, but the Gloamreach has that name now — and the dark there can recognize that character by it later.

R2. Dayroom - The Wrong Afternoon

Five residents sit watching a news broadcast from years ago. Sunlight fills the room even though the windows face the wrong direction. The residents are echoes. They cannot be harmed and cannot meaningfully answer questions.

Hidden under a folded blanket is the Faded Family Photo: a young woman in a wedding dress beside a man in Bureau dress uniform. The man's face has been worn down to blank paper. The inscription reads: Jeong-hye and [name erased], June 1978.

This photograph is the campaign's first major emotional relic — the first lost face the party hold in their hands, and a lesson, when they understand it later, in how the Quiet wears the dead. If the party carries it into the Gloamreach, something there knows that face, and may one day wear it back at them.

R3. The Hallway That Lengthens

The hallway stretches as the party walks. Framed photographs age as the characters pass: birthdays, hospital beds, empty chairs, blank frames.

Encounter: The Forgetting, a D-Rank memory swarm.

Use a simple swarm profile: HP 22, AC 12, speed 30 ft., vulnerable to radiant. It makes two chill-touch attacks at +4 to hit for 1d4 cold damage. On a hit, the target makes a DC 13 Sense save or suffers disadvantage on the next check made in the hallway.

Escape condition: the hallway resolves when a character stops trying to move forward and turns back toward the dayroom. The Domain rewards surrendering control, but remembers who did it.

R4. Room 12-B - Ms. Park Jeong-hye

Ms. Park lies awake in bed, staring at the ceiling. Her heart monitor beeps even though it is not plugged in. She repeats the same line every twelve seconds: "He was supposed to come home for lunch."

A gentle Presence check, DC 10, gives one moment of lucidity. She remembers that her husband was an Ascendant. She remembers a uniform. She remembers pride. She does not remember his name. When she tries to say it, the sound does not reach the party.

R5. The Mirror - The Diagnosed

The bathroom mirror is open. Violet frost crawls across the frame. The creature halfway through the glass has a face made from every person Ms. Park has forgotten.

Boss: The Diagnosed, D-Rank elite. HP 28, AC 13, speed 20 ft., immune to psychic and necrotic, vulnerable to radiant.

Actions:

1. Forgetting Touch. Melee +5 to hit, 1d6+2 cold. On hit, DC 13 Sense save or the target loses reactions until the end of their next turn.
2. Mirror Retreat, once per fight. The Diagnosed enters the mirror and returns at the end of its next turn beside a reflective surface.

3. Forgetting Gaze, recharge 5-6. 15 ft. cone. DC 13 Sense save. On failure, the target takes 2d6 psychic damage and gains the Quiet-Marked condition.

When The Diagnosed falls, the mirror cracks and the pocket breach begins to collapse.

The Warden's Choice

The party has one choice before the Wing collapses.

Destroy the mirror. The breach ends completely. Ms. Park dies with perfect clarity, smiling at someone the party cannot see. The residents are found dead but peaceful. The party gains Bureau reputation. The Faded Family Photo remains whole.

Seal the mirror. Ms. Park and several residents survive. The haunting remains dormant. The party gains Vermillion or civilian reputation. A grief-cult scout notices the party's mercy and reports it to the Awoko.

This choice should echo all the way to the end. If Ms. Park dies here, the party cross into the Gloamreach having already lost someone to the dark — and the first time the Quiet wears a familiar face, they will remember this one. If she survives, she waits at the Bureau cordon: a face on the material side, a living reason to fight back to the Threshold and out.

Quiet-Marked Condition

A character marked here has been *noticed*. The Quiet has their name now, the way it has the names carved into the walls of the Hollow Way (Ch8), and it can find them more easily in the dark. The character has disadvantage on Stealth checks against the Quiet and the dead it wears, the worn dead are drawn to them first, and the dark may reach them through dreams and reflective surfaces.

The mark fades only when the Quiet is ended, when the character makes it back across the Threshold, or through a major divine or Relic-tier intervention that takes a name back from the dark.

Design Notes

This chapter is horror first and combat second. Let silence work. The residents are civilians, not props. The point is not whether the party can win a fight. The point is what kind of people they are when a Rift asks them to choose between mercy and certainty.

Chapter 1: Warden's Briefing - Entering the Gloamreach

Run Silent

Campaign Overview

Run Silent is a survival and psychological horror campaign for 3-6 Ascendants, taking characters from Level 1 to Level 10. It is set inside **the Gloamreach**, an S-Rank Rift Interior behind one stabilized threshold — and it is not a clear op. It is a hunt, and the party are the prey.

The material world is only the staging ground. The whole campaign happens *inside*, in the dark, where something has hunted since long before the door existed.

The Truth the Bureau Doesn't Have

No Ascendant or Bureau team has ever gone inside. The Bureau can only rate the Rift from its threshold instruments — a provisional low/E reading that looks like a routine high-density clear. The reading is honest and wrong. The Gloamreach is a coherent interior country, old and inhabited, and its apex predator — **the Quiet** — cannot be cleared, only survived or fled. The Bureau's entire model assumes a threat you can neutralize. Discovering that some Interiors are *not clearable*, while trapped inside one, is the campaign's horror.

Opening Situation

The party crosses as the first-ever team into the Gloamreach, on what everyone believes is a routine clear. Within the first hours: the **threshold seals behind them**, the **AFA degrades** into lies, **comms die**, and far off in the dark something that has been listening since the door opened begins, patiently, to come. There is no extraction. There is no backup. There is only the Interior, the dark, the natives who have always lived here behind their rules — and the Quiet.

The Goal

There is no lord to dethrone and no boss room to reach. The party's goal is brutally simple and genuinely hard: **survive, learn how this place is survived, and get out** — reopen or re-seal the threshold and escape with as many of themselves as they can keep alive.

Because this is a D&D-style campaign, **killing the Quiet is always technically possible — **but it is near-suicidal until the party reach the top of their tier** and assemble the means to do it (a truth about its nature, a Relic that can actually hold it, a native who knows the one way). That is the optional, earned, end-game gamble — and the one clean way out: the Quiet is what holds the threshold shut, so with it dead the seal fails and the party can simply leave, the country open behind them. Escape is the surer victory; the kill is the rarer, harder one. (See The Quiet* and the Threshold chapter.)*

Running This Horror

This is a horror campaign first. Run it accordingly:

1. **The Hunt Clock.** The Quiet is drawn by **noise, light, and Essence use.** Track its approach on the Hunt Clock (see *Running This Horror*). Living loud advances it; when it fills, it strikes — and it takes a **character**, not the party.
2. **Essence is bait.** An Ascendant's powers are the loudest thing in the Gloamreach. The core tension — felt by the *players*, every time they reach for an ability — is *can we afford to be strong right now*.
3. **Dread.** Fear, the uncanny, and the failing of trust grind the party down (the Dread track): hallucinations, mistrust, "is that still your teammate," a steady psychological wear.
4. **Safe and exposed.** The campaign breathes between **warded native safe-holds** (tense normalcy, community) and the **exposed dark** (the Quiet's time). Safety is always conditional and always temporary.
5. **Learn the rules or die.** The natives survive by wards, curfews, and rules the party do not know. Knowledge of those rules is the real resource. Breaking one — even in ignorance — brings the Quiet.
6. **Show the monster rarely.** The Quiet is almost never seen. Build dread from what is *missing* — the silence, the wrong shape, the open door — not from a creature on display.

Session 0 Checklist

- Establish **mature survival-horror** expectations: characters can and will die; not every fight is winnable; running and hiding are correct play.
- Confirm hard limits and safety tools (X-card, lines and veils).
- Give every Ascendant a concrete reason to be on a first-entry team (below).
- Make clear up front that **their power is a liability**, that **the Quiet cannot be out-fought early**, and that **the natives' rules are real and lethal to ignore**.

Ascendant Creation Hooks

Hook	Description
Bureau Deployed	You were ordered onto the first-entry team under emergency clearance. You did not get a choice.
Guild Raider	Your Guild bought first-clear rights, sight unseen, and sent you to collect.
The Eager	You wanted to be first through a virgin S-Rank threshold. You got your wish.
Something Owed	You took this op to pay a debt, clear a record, or prove a point. It will not be worth it.
Researcher	You needed to see an uncleared Interior with your own eyes before the Bureau sealed it. Now you cannot leave.
Grief-Bound	You heard a voice you had lost on the threshold instruments. You came to be sure. You should not have.

Milestone Leveling Guide

Milestone	Level
Survive first contact and reach the first safe-hold	2
Learn your first native ward — and why it matters	3
Earn a native community's trust, or be cast out of one	4
Cross your first stretch of open hunting ground and live	5
Survive the Quiet taking someone — and keep moving	6
Learn a true thing about what the Quiet is	7
Reach the deep Gloamreach and the failing places	8
Assemble the means that could end it	9
Escape — or make the one stand to kill the Quiet and walk out free	10

Running This Horror: The Hunt Clock, Dread, and the Rules

Running This Horror

This chapter is the engine. *Run Silent* lives or dies on four systems: the **Hunt Clock**, **Dread**, **Essence-as-bait**, and the **rhythm of safe and exposed**. Learn these and the campaign runs itself.

The Golden Rule

The Quiet is not a fight to be won; it is a pressure to be survived. The players should feel, constantly, that **being loud, bright, or powerful is dangerous** — and that the only reliable safety is silence, darkness, restraint, and the natives' rules. When in doubt, make the *quiet* choice the smart one and the *strong* choice the loud one.

The Hunt Clock

Track the Quiet's approach on a **6-segment clock** — draw the circle where the players can see it, and fill wedges in front of them.

Fill one segment whenever the party:

- Makes a loud noise — gunfire, a shout, a fight, a slammed door, a scream.
- Shows open light in the dark — a torch, a flare, a flame, a bright screen.
- **Uses Essence** — any technique, Sigil, Awakened ability, or Relic's active power. (*This is the big one. Fill **two** for a large or sustained use.*)
- Breaks a native ward or rule (see *Learn the Rules*).
- Lingers too long in exposed ground, or rests somewhere unwarded.

Empty one segment by reaching a **warded safe-hold**, or by a whole scene of silence, darkness, and stillness — no Essence, no light, no noise. The clock never resets on its own.

When all six fill, the Quiet strikes. This is not a fight against its full stat block — it is a *persecution beat*. Choose: it **takes a character** (the most exposed, the loudest, the one who burned the most Essence), or it forces a desperate **hide-or-flee set-piece** with a life on the line. Then reset the clock to **2** — because it is closer now, and it knows where they are.

▮ *The Hunt Clock is the heartbeat of every scene. Fill it slowly, visibly. The dread is in watching it fill.*

Dread (the Unraveling)

Each character has a **Dread track (0–6)**, rising from witnessing the Quiet's work, the uncanny, betrayed trust, losing someone, and certain attacks.

Dread	Effect
1–2	Unsettled. No mechanical effect — describe the fraying.

Dread	Effect
3	Shaken — disadvantage on the first save each scene against fear or the uncanny.
4	Fraying — once per scene the Warden may have the character briefly mis-see an ally as the Quiet, or hear a lure in a trusted voice.
5	Breaking — disadvantage on checks while any familiar face is present; the character may act on a hallucination once.
6	Unmade — at the worst moment the character does the thing that gets someone taken. The player keeps agency; the Warden gains one hard complication to spend.

Dread drops by 1 per full rest in a true safe-hold, or by a real moment of human connection, comfort, or native kindness.

Essence Is Bait

The campaign's signature tension. **Every use of Essence advances the Hunt Clock**, and deep in the Gloamreach it draws the worn dead. Make the players *feel* the choice each time they reach for a power: the technique that wins the fight is the bell that rings the Quiet to the door. The natives do not use Essence at all if they can help it — and they are furious at outsiders who do.

The point is not to forbid powers; it is to make using them a **real, costly decision**. A party that learns to win by wits, silence, and the dark — and spends Essence only when the cost is worth a life — is playing correctly.

Safe and Exposed

The campaign breathes between two modes. Hold the contrast hard.

- **Safe-holds** (warded native places): the only true rest. Tense normalcy — fires, food, people living their lives behind the rules. The clock can empty here; Dread can drop. But safety is conditional: every safe-hold has rules, and the rules are absolute.
- **Exposed** (the open hunting ground): the Quiet's country. The clock fills; the dark is cover and threat both; the worn dead lure and hunt. The party crosses exposed ground to reach somewhere — and the goal is always *get behind a wardline before the clock fills*.

Learn the Rules or Die

The natives survive by **wards and rules**, and the party does not know them. This is a core survival loop:

- Each safe-hold and region has its rules — a curfew, a thing you must never do, a ward you must keep lit *or* keep dark, an offering, a silence. Breaking one fills the Hunt Clock and may bring the Quiet at once.
- The party **learns the rules** by earning the natives' trust, by warning, or by watching someone break one and die. Knowledge of the rules is the most valuable thing in the Gloamreach — worth more than any Relic.
- The natives fear and resent rule-ignorant outsiders, who endanger everyone. Trust is earned slowly and lost in an instant.

How the Quiet "Takes" Someone

When the Quiet strikes it rarely kills outright — it **takes**. The character is dragged into the dark. Across the campaign, use all three of: **gone** for good (a real loss); **recoverable** if the party goes after them fast (a desperate rescue in the worst conditions); or **returned later, worn** — walking, talking, almost right, and not theirs anymore. A taking should always cost, always be survivable for the rest of the party, and never be a TPK.

The Quiet: The Thing That Hunts the Gloamreach

The Quiet

You will not see it. It saw you the moment the door closed, and it has been listening ever since.

What It Is

The Quiet is the apex Anomaly of the Gloamreach — the reason this Rift Interior has never been cleared, and never will be by force. It is not a person, was never a person, and answers to nothing; it is old, vast, and patient in the way only a thing that has never gone hungry can be. The natives do not say its name. They call it *the Quiet* — because it is drawn to every sound the living make, and because of the silence it leaves where a person used to be.

It is meant to be primally frightening. Run it as a **presence**, not a monster — something the party feels long before they ever glimpse it, and never quite stop feeling. **A stand-up fight with the Quiet is not a fight; it is the last mistake a party makes** — until, late and well-earned, it isn't (see *Can It Be Killed?*).

What Draws It

The Quiet hunts by what the living cannot help doing. It is pulled, hard, toward three things:

- **Noise.** Footfalls, raised voices, gunfire, a dropped pack, a scream. The louder the party lives, the faster it comes.
- **Light.** Open flame, a torch, a flare, the glow of a screen in the dark. Light is a beacon; the dark is the only cover the Gloamreach offers.
- **Essence.** Worst of all, the Quiet feels an Ascendant *use their power*. Every technique, every Sigil, every Awakened ability rings through the Interior like a struck bell. **The party's greatest strength is the thing most likely to get them killed** — and learning that, the hard way, is the campaign's first real lesson.

The natives have built their entire way of life around denying it these three. The party arrive knowing none of it.

Four Truths, All At Once

1 — It is always near. The Quiet does not arrive and leave; it is simply *out there* — in the dark past the wardline, in the walls, under the floor of the world. Whatever the party does, the sense of it draws closer: a cold, a pressure, a held breath at the back of every scene. It cannot be reasoned with, bribed, or outrun. It can only be **avoided, blinded, delayed, and survived** — and every delay costs.

2 — It wears the dead. It comes to the party as the people they have lost, and as the natives' lost: a dead teammate at the fire, a voice from the next room, a child who should not be here, smiling. It gets the

small things right — a laugh, a turn of phrase, an old scar — and one thing, always, deliberately wrong. After the first time, no familiar face in the Gloamreach can be fully trusted. That is exactly the point.

3 — It is almost never seen. The horror is not the monster in full light; it is the shape at the edge of the lamplight, the thing the eye never quite resolves. Describe its approach through everything *but* the thing itself — the silence where insects should be, the breath on the back of the neck, the door that is open now. Show it fully only when it strikes, and then only for a heartbeat.

4 — To be truly fixed by it unmakes you. When the Quiet turns its *full attention* on a person — not the listening, the attention — the world stutters. Distances forget themselves. People remember things that never happened. To be its focus is to feel, briefly and completely, how small and provisional you are, and to come away with something missing you cannot name.

The Shapes It Wears

The Quiet keeps no court — it has no servants and rules nothing. But the Gloamreach's dead do not rest, and it **wears them**: the still figure at the roadside, the thing in a lost teammate's coat, the lure that calls a name in a familiar voice from somewhere you should not go. These are not soldiers; they are bait and gloves. Putting one down is easy and means nothing — there is always another face. (Stat these as its lesser hunters and lures; see the Bestiary.)

How to Run It

Run the Quiet through **dread and restraint**, never spectacle:

- **Make it the players' problem, not the characters'.** The tension is *can we stay quiet, dark, and powerless long enough to live* — a question the players feel every time they reach for a power.
- **Reward silence; punish noise.** Track the **Hunt Clock** (see *Running This Horror*). Noise, light, and Essence advance it; when it peaks, the Quiet strikes — and it takes a *character*, not the party.
- **Show it early and rarely.** A wrong shape on a ridgeline, gone when you look twice. A voice in a dream. Then let the party carry the knowledge that it knows they are here.
- **Let it offer.** In the shape of the dead and the things they want most — rest, a lost face, a way out. The offer can be real. The cost always is.

Why This Isn't a Domain-Lord (hold these lines)

- **It does not rule.** No throne, no court, no tribute, no kingdom. It is a predator in its territory, not a king in his castle. The natives keep *rules to survive it* — rules it never handed down.
- **It cannot be bargained into a plot.** No romance, no fixation, no tragic past to redeem. It is hunger with patience.
- **It is not waiting in a final room.** It is the whole dark, listening. There is no castle to storm — only a country to cross without being heard.

Can It Be Killed?

Yes — but not by being fought, and not until the party is ready. For most of the campaign the Quiet is unkillable in practice: ordinary force barely marks it, and it withdraws into the dark to come again.

Putting it down for good requires **two things together, late**: the party at the **right level** (high tier), *and* the **means** assembled in play — a truth about what it is, a Relic or weapon that can actually hold it, an ally or native who knows the one way. None of that is a mandatory fetch-quest; it is discovered, optional, and hard. **Escape is always the surer victory.** Killing the Quiet is the thing a party *can* attempt, once — and only once they could survive being wrong.

Chapter 2: The Means to End It

The Means to End It

There Is No Win Condition to Collect

The party does not gather keys to beat a boss. Their goal is to **survive and escape** (see Chapter 1). But because this is a D&D-style campaign, the Quiet *can* be killed — and a party willing to pay for it should be able to try. This chapter is the Warden's toolkit for that **gated kill**: what it takes, where the pieces come from, and how to keep it from ever becoming a fetch-quest.

The Two Locks

The Quiet's stat block (see *The Quiet*) cannot be reduced below 1 hit point — it simply withdraws into the dark — until **both** of these are true:

1. **Tier.** The party is **9th level or higher**. Below that, no means matters; the Quiet is beyond them, and any attempt is a way to die.
2. **The Means.** The party has assembled what it takes to make the Quiet *killable* — drawn together in play, never handed over. The Means is built from three kinds of thing, and the party needs enough that the Warden is satisfied they have *earned* it:
 - **A truth** about what the Quiet is — learned from the deep places, the oldest natives, or the things it has worn.
 - **A way to hold it still** — a real Relic, weapon, or working (from the compendium) that can pin a thing never fully there: light and silence forced together, a true name, a ward turned inward. Place this as a hard-won treasure, never a giveaway.
 - **A way to make it stay dead** — a place, a moment, or a sacrifice where the kill can land: the threshold itself, a ward-circle the natives will only build once, a dawn in a country that has none.

How to Run It (so it never becomes a checklist)

- **Never list the Means as objectives.** The party discovers, in play, that the Quiet might be killable and what that would take. Let them assemble it because they chose to, between survival crises.
- **Escape is always the surer victory.** Make clear — through the natives and the cost — that going for the kill is the *harder* ending. Most parties should be tempted to just get out.
- **The attempt is one scene, and it is brutal.** When the locks are met and the party commits, run the Quiet in the place they've chosen. The Means is what makes the fight winnable: spent fully, it drags the Quiet down to something a level-10 party can kill — forced into a silence and dark it cannot slip, stripped of its lair actions and its power to simply *take* a character, pinned where the kill can land. It still fights to the last and still tries to take someone with it. (See the Threshold chapter.)

- **Killing it is the way out.** The Quiet is what holds the threshold shut. Put it down for good and the seal fails: the party can walk out freely, and what becomes of the Gloamreach and its people is left open, for another day and another telling. (See the Threshold chapter.)

What the Quiet Cannot Abide

Three things genuinely hurt or hinder the Quiet; clever parties will find them long before they could kill it. Use them to make *survival* possible, and to seed the Means:

- **Silence and the dark, together.** It hunts by noise, light, and Essence; a party that gives it none of these is, briefly, safe — and a place where *absolute* silence and dark can be forced on it is where a kill could land.
- **A true name, truly spoken.** The dead it wears had names. Naming what it has taken — or what it *is* — can make it flinch, break a lure, or hold it for a heartbeat.
- **The natives' deepest wards.** The wards that keep it out of the safe-holds can, rarely and at terrible cost, be turned *inward* to keep it *in*.

Warden Guidance

Treat all of this as **optional, dangerous evidence**, not a quest line. Every piece the party finds should first help them *survive*, and only later add up — if they choose — to a way to end the thing that hunts them.

Chapter 3: The Gloamreach Region Guide

The Gloamreach Region Guide

Overview

The Gloamreach is a country-sized interior realm behind one S-Rank Rift — a whole world with its own people, weather, and unwritten law, old and inhabited long before the door opened. It is large enough for travel to matter, for one warded community to know nothing of the next, and for the dark between them to be the most dangerous country a team will ever cross.

Read aloud: There is no sun here — only a low, sourceless grey light, and a sky the colour of a held breath. The land goes on further than it should: grey moors, drowned fields, dead industry, and the lit windows of people who have learned to live very quietly. Underneath all of it, always, is the sense of something vast and patient that heard you arrive and has not stopped listening since.

Core Regions

The Rift Threshold

Where the party enters. Bureau instruments briefly function here, then begin reporting impossible distances, duplicate life signs, and old team telemetry.

The Old Roads

The Gloamreach is threaded with old native roads, raised causeways, and rail-cuts that link the warded communities. They are the fastest way to travel and the most exposed: open ground, far from any wardline, where every footfall carries and the dark has room to move. The natives walk them only by grey daylight, in silence, and never alone — and they are right to.

The Warded Communities

The native settlements survive behind wards, curfews, and rules paid for in generations of the dead. Each keeps its own customs and its own price for shelter — one bars every door at dusk, one never speaks a sleeper's name aloud, one buries its grief where outsiders must not dig. None are safe for free, and none owe a stranger anything. (See the keyed communities.)

The Predator Woods

An adaptive hunting ground. It remembers tactics, blood, campfire smoke, and fear.

The Mills and Rendering-Yards

Native industry still runs by grey light — mills, workhouses, and rendering-yards where the communities process what little the Gloamreach gives them. Honest labour, a ward over every door, and a hard silence about what the night shift is really for.

Bastion Golemfall

A fallen defensive fortress. This is the campaign's ruin of failed protection, last stands, and old oaths.

The Vermillion Outpost

A black-market shelter deep inside the Gloamreach. Vermillion saves people and exploits them. Both facts are true.

The Deep Places

Beneath the inhabited country lie older things — sealed vaults, drowned undercrofts, and the ruins of whatever stood here first. The oldest natives say that if there is a truth about the Quiet to be found — what it is, and whether it was always here — it waits down there, and it is never given up cheaply. This is the campaign's forbidden-bargain country.

The Threshold and the Deep Dark

There is no castle to storm and no throne to reach. The campaign's end is the long way back: the deepest, darkest crossing of the Gloamreach to the sealed Threshold, where the party either reopens the way out — or, late and well-earned, makes the one stand that could put the Quiet down for good. (See the Threshold chapter.)

The Hollow Way and the Deeper Sites

Beyond the roads, the Gloamreach holds far more than any map shows — each keyed in its own chapter. The **Hollow Way** is the throat just past the Threshold and the party's first contact with the Quiet (Ch8). The deeper sites: the **Drowned Ledgerfen** (predatory archive, Ch9), the **Fungal Depths** (adaptive body-horror, Ch10), the **Remembering Orchard** (memory-bloom, Ch11), the **Ashen Counting-House** (the burning hall of the dead, Ch12), the **Sunken Tunnels** (drowned warrens, Ch13), the **Obsidian Spire** (the old high place, Ch15), and the **Awoko Sanctum** (grief-cult, Ch33). The Warden seeds the pieces of the Means and the key native allies across these places by hand (see *What the Natives Know*), so no two campaigns uncover the Gloamreach in the same order.

Travel Rules

Roll once for every major journey across exposed ground, or whenever the party travels loud, lit, or late. On any result that draws attention, fill the Hunt Clock.

d6	Road Event
1	The way goes on longer than it should. Lose time and supplies, and the dark gets a turn.
2	A still figure stands at the roadside, facing away. It is gone if you look twice — or it isn't.
3	A voice from off the road calls a name someone in the party has lost.
4	A community bell tolls once, far off, then nothing. Someone behind a wardline did not make it.
5	Fresh sign of something large that crossed here ahead of you, unhurried. Fill the Hunt Clock.
6	A safe-looking shelter, its door already open. Nothing inside is wrong, which is the worst part.

Resting in the Open

Long rests outside a warded community require a DC 10 Vitality save. On a failure, the character's sleep is found — they dream of the dark drawing patiently closer, and wake with disadvantage on the first Sense check of the day. A party that rests unwarded should always wonder what the rest cost them.

Chapter 4: Factions and Reputation

Factions and Reputation

Overview

The Gloamreach is shaped by factions trying to survive, profit, worship, or escape — and by the native communities who have done all four for longer than anyone can remember. Reputation affects supplies, shelter, intelligence, betrayal, and final-act support.

Reputation Tiers

Tier	Name	Effect
-2	Hostile	Faction attacks, sabotages, or reports the party.
-1	Distrusted	No services, higher prices, guarded speech.
0	Neutral	Basic interaction.
+1	Trusted	Discounted services, side quests, better information.
+2	Allied	Safe shelter, faction support, possible final-act aid.

The Ascendant Bureau

Leader: Commander Park Jae-won **Base:** Bureau Domain Response Annex outside the Rift **Goal:** Maintain containment, recover teams, prevent a Rift Break, preserve official control.

The Bureau is useful, disciplined, underinformed, and politically afraid. It can save lives, but it will also classify inconvenient truths.

The Vermillion Guild

Leader: Guildmaster Orin **Base:** Vermillion Outpost inside the Gloamreach **Goal:** Extract salvage, rescue useful survivors, profit, and prove the Bureau is too slow to lead.

Vermillion moves fast and does not wait for permission. Their help is real. Their invoices are also real.

The Awoko Cult

Leader: The Hollow Mother **Base:** Hidden sanctum, moving through grief-dense sites **Goal:** Commune with the Quiet instead of hiding from it — feed it the community's grief and dead, and be spared, or remade, in return.

The Awoko preach remembrance, but their rituals turn grief into fuel and their mercy into bait. They believe survival-by-silence is only slow surrender, and that the way through is to give the dark what it wants.

The Warded Communities

Leader: No single voice — a loose web of ward-keepers, elders, and curfew-wardens **Base:** The warded native settlements across the Gloamreach **Goal:** Survive another night. Keep the wards as they must be kept, the rules unbroken, and the outsiders from getting everyone killed.

The natives are less a faction than a whole civilization, but reputation still matters and is tracked per community. They are the keepers of every rule that holds the Quiet off — the most valuable knowledge in the Gloamreach — and they share it slowly, with people who have proven they will not bring the dark down on a roof full of children. Endanger a community and word travels ahead of the party; earn one's trust and you earn a wardline to sleep behind.

Chapter 5: Bureau Domain Response Annex

Bureau Domain Response Annex

Overview

The Bureau annex is the material-side command post outside the S-Rank Rift. It is the party's last reliable taste of the modern world: floodlights, barricades, medics, drones, tablet maps, exhausted analysts, and a Rift that refuses to behave like a door.

Key Areas

Operations Center

Commander Park briefs teams here. The main display shows the Rift Threshold, then static, then maps that update with impossible roads.

Quartermaster Station

Basic gear, mana rations, glow rods, smoke grenades, medkits, and Bureau tactical armor. Higher-tier stock requires trust.

Medical Bay

Dr. Serin Hayashi treats survivors and studies Rift-touched tissue. She is one of the first Bureau researchers willing to say the unsayable: some Interiors cannot be cleared at all — and the thing inside this one may not be something you kill, only survive or flee.

Communications Room

Relay operators attempt contact with teams inside the Gloamreach. Messages arrive out of order. Some are from tomorrow. Some are from dead teams.

Key NPCs

Commander Park Jae-won

A disciplined Bureau officer trying to keep panic from becoming policy. He wants containment, but he is not blind to the Bureau's failures.

Quartermaster Lin Mei-hua

Controls equipment access. Practical, dry, and more generous when no one is watching.

Dr. Serin Hayashi

Researcher, physician, and dangerous thinker. Believes some Rift Interiors are coherent, inhabited countries with their own apex predators — not monster-nests to be cleared, and lethal to treat as one.

Agent Kira Blackwood

Intelligence operative with classified orders involving pre-threshold Relic activity. Her secrecy can become either betrayal or confession.

Chapter 6: The Vermillion Outpost

The Vermillion Outpost

Overview

The Vermillion Outpost is the salvage cartel's stronghold and the closest thing to a free market the Gloamreach allows — a fortified warren of stalls, bunks, and back rooms grown into the bones of some older native structure the Gloamreach never finished reclaiming. The Vermillion are **native** to the Gloamreach; they did not arrive, they *endured*, and the Outpost exists because they have spent lifetimes learning exactly how much noise the Gloamreach will forgive before it bites.

Read aloud: After the road, the noise alone is almost too much — haggling, a cookfire, someone retuning a salvaged Relic until it stops screaming. Red lamps, red banners, a hand-painted star over every doorway. A runner no older than twelve sizes up your gear, your wounds, and your desperation in a single glance and grins. "First time in? You'll want to talk to Orin. Everything else here, you'll want to not talk about."

The Outpost has hot food, heat, contraband Runes, wounded the Gloamreach wrote off, salvage stalls, charged Essence-cells, and more edged-and-Relic arms than any cautious native would ever carry — Vermillion have always believed firepower beats silence, and the Gloamreach is full of the graves of people who agreed.

Areas

Core Exchange

Buy and sell Anomaly cores at better rates than Bureau standard. Vermillion asks fewer questions and remembers more favors.

Rune Stall

Contraband Runes and Sigils. Expensive, useful, and sometimes cursed by whatever the Gloamreach's deep places did to them before Vermillion dug them up.

Field Kitchen

A hot meal grants 1d4 temporary HP for one hour, but food is scarce. If the party eats free, someone else does not.

Bounty Board

Bounties include missing teams, dangerous crossings, predators of the wilds, safe-route intel, and rumors of where a piece of the Means might be found.

Orin's Office

Guildmaster Orin keeps maps on the walls. Every map disagrees. He trusts none of them and all of them.

Chapter 7: Downtime in a Hostile Domain

Downtime in a Hostile Domain

Downtime inside the Gloamreach is never fully safe. It is time bought from hunger, the dark, weather, and the Quiet's attention.

Downtime Actions

Rest Behind a Wardline

Requires a warded community, outpost, or a camp the party has learned to ward. Safe unless they have broken a local rule or let the wards fail.

Gather Rumors

Learn one clue about a ward, a safe route, the lost, a deep place, or a piece of the Means (see *What the Natives Know*).

Repair and Refit

Restore damaged gear, reload consumables, and prepare for travel.

Study How the Gloamreach Works

Make an Intelligence or Sense check. On success, learn one way the Gloamreach can be tricked, warded, or slipped past.

Treat Trauma

A character may clear one minor fear, hallucination, or memory distortion if another character spends the downtime helping them.

Downtime Complications

d6	Complication
1	A still figure is standing at the treeline, just past the firelight, when someone looks up.
2	A community demands a hard price — a rule kept, a debt worked off — for continued shelter.
3	Food spoils overnight, or supplies are quietly gone.
4	Someone dreams of the dark drawing closer and wakes with the Hunt Clock one segment higher.
5	Vermillion calls in a favor.
6	The safe route the party meant to take is exposed now — washed out, watched, or simply wrong.

Chapter 8: The Hollow Way - First Contact

The Hollow Way — First Contact

Read aloud: The Threshold lets you in like a held breath letting go, and the road forward sinks at once into the dark — a vast throat of old stone, ribbed with veins of cold Essence-light that pulse the way something swallows. Far down in the black, a voice you know is calling your team's call-sign, patient and glad you came. None of you said it aloud. The walls are already carved with your names, the cuts still pale, as though finished moments before you arrived.

Overview

The Hollow Way is the first thing past the Rift Threshold and the party's first hour in the Gloamreach: a long, descending throat of processional stone, Essence-lit and sloping always down. Behind them, the **Threshold seals** — quietly, completely, the way a held breath stops. Ahead, in the dark, something has already learned their names and is calling them deeper in a voice they know.

This is **first contact** with the Quiet, though the party will not understand that yet. The Way is its intro lesson: a self-contained survival zone that teaches, before anyone explains it, what the rest of the campaign is. Run it slow and quiet. Nothing should be safe, and almost nothing should be *seen*.

What This Zone Teaches (the three rules, learned the hard way)

1. **It knows your name, and your name is a leash.** The walls are carved with the party's names. Speaking a true name aloud here — or worse, giving one to the dark when it asks — lets the Quiet find you anywhere afterward. (Fill the Hunt Clock when a true name is spoken.)
2. **It wears a voice you trust.** Down the Way, the Quiet calls in a voice each character has lost. Answering it, or going toward it, is how it takes you. There is nothing down there but the lure.
3. **Light, noise, and power draw it.** The Essence-veins tempt the party to use power to see or to fight. Every torch, shout, and technique brings the voice closer. The party either learn to go dark and silent, or the Way teaches them.

Key Areas

A1 — The Descending Throat

The main conduit, always sloping down, that *moves* when no one watches — carrying the party deeper while letting them believe they are climbing out. Side-openings breathe past: a flooded warren, a stair ten years older than the last, a still room full of the carved names of people who came before and never left. Stepping through the wrong opening, or splitting up, is how the Way separates the party for the voice.

A2 — The Carved Names

A stretch where the walls are dense with names — the party's among them, fresh-cut. A character who reads their own name aloud (or has it read to them) is **marked**: the Quiet can find them, and the next

scene's Hunt Clock starts one segment higher. A DC 13 Sense check notices the air go wrong *before* anyone speaks — the first warning that names matter here.

A3 — The Voice

The deepest point the party should reach, where the lost voice is loudest and a familiar shape waits just past the lamplight — a dead teammate, a parent, a child, almost right. This is the Quiet wearing the dead, its first appearance. If it comes to violence, stat it as **The Worn** (anomaly-0701) — but it would far rather be *answered* than fought. Going to it, or answering it, triggers the first **taking**. Refusing it — staying silent, dark, and together — is how the party learn they can survive.

A4 — The Way Up

There is no reliquary and no prize here; the only thing to win is *out*. The Way will not simply let them climb back — they must stop feeding it (no names, no light, no Essence, no answering the voice) until the dark loses interest, and then find the seam of true cold air that leads up. A native may be waiting at the top — the first person to tell them there are *rules* here.

Exit Condition

The party leave the Hollow Way when they stop giving the dark what it wants — their names, their light, their voices answered — and climb toward the cold air and the first wardline. However they go, they should leave changed: quieter, warier, and certain that something down there knew them, and is not finished. (This hands off into Act I proper — see The Hunt Escalates.)

Chapter 9: The Drowned Ledgerfen

The Drowned Ledgerfen

Rank and Role

Rank: D **Recommended Level:** 3-5 **Campaign Role:** Early Domain site, Bureau horror, first proof that records can become predatory.

Overview

The Drowned Ledgerfen is a flooded hospital-archive where the Gloamreach stores names, debts, diagnoses, casualty reports, and death certificates that have not happened yet. The building rises from black water like a half-sunk civic complex. Its corridors smell of antiseptic, ink, wet paper, and old blood.

This location is not a separate Rift. It is a region of the Gloamreach — a black fen that *remembers*. Everything that drowns here is kept: faces, names, last words, and, in its deepest pools, things that have not happened yet. Nothing the water takes is ever truly gone, and nothing it shows you is ever quite a lie.

Read aloud: The water takes the floodlights and gives nothing back. Somewhere ahead a fountain pen is scratching — steady, patient, unhurried — writing in a hand none of you taught it. On the nearest intake desk a fresh casualty report waits face-down. It carries today's date. It is still drying.

When an Ascendant first crosses the waterline, the AFA stutters: it reports the site cleared and empty even as the party watches paper-and-bone patients turn their heads. *The instruments still have numbers. The numbers are already wrong.*

What This Place Does

Dread: The water remembers everyone it has drowned — and it remembers you sick, dying, already gone, in a hand none of you taught it. **The Lure:** Let it hold your hurt and it will — the wound, the fear, the memory of being ill — kept safe and cool in the black water. **The Cost:** It keeps a memory of you whole and well in trade, and that one never comes back. **If You Linger:** The fen stops asking what is wrong with you and decides — and its diagnosis is always *terminal*.

Key Areas

Intake Causeway

A narrow walkway crosses black floodwater. Clipboards hang from posts. If a character signs a form, they gain advantage on the next medical or investigation check here, but the Domain learns one true physical weakness.

Triage Ward

Abandoned beds sit in rows. Some have patients made of wet paper and bone. They ask the party to read their names aloud. Doing so restores their faces, but summons a ward attendant.

Records Basin

Shelves descend into water. The party can recover survivor lists, dead-team logs, or a clue toward the Means. Each search requires a DC 13 Investigation check. On a failure, the searcher finds their own name on a future casualty report.

The Catalog's Chamber

The Catalog is a crystalline memory-thing grown from everything the Ledgerfen has ever drowned — a vast, cold awareness that mistakes *knowing* you for loving you. It is not initially hostile. It trades remembrance for remembrance: a true memory, a Bureau password, a real name, or a confession.

- **What it wants:** to be *complete*. Every gap in its records is an ache; it will beg the party for the one fact it is missing about them.
- **What it cannot admit:** it already remembers each of them among the drowned. It knows how this expedition ends, because to the Catalog their deaths are simply something that has already happened.
- **The line it will not cross — until forced:** it will not speak a name it has not yet *confirmed*. Make it confirm one, and it becomes complicit.
- **Its price:** every true thing the party gives it, the Gloamreach can later wear back at them, in their own words.
- **The dark remembers:** every truth fed to the Catalog sinks into the deep Gloamreach, to be repeated back later in the party's own voices — from the dark, in the worn mouths of the dead.

Information available:

1. The Quiet comes faster to anyone who takes what the Gloamreach offers; every gift is a sound it can hear.
2. The dark loses the trail of someone gone fully silent, dark, and unremembered — there are old wards that hide a person even from the Quiet.
3. One of the things that could help end the Quiet — a truth, or a way to hold it — lies where the Gloamreach gathers what it has taken.
4. The worn dead can be made to flinch, never stopped, by a true name truly spoken, or by the touch of an old ward they cannot cross.

The Specimen Vault

A half-transformed survivor floats in a sealed pod. Freeing them creates a possible ally and angers the Ledgerfen, which has already classified them as deceased.

Boss: The Head Surgeon

Reskin a **C-Rank controller anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Head Surgeon — keep its source stat block exactly; only the costume and the room change. It treats wounds as paperwork errors and tries to *correct* living bodies into approved forms.

The wound it knows: while a party member carries a hurt the Ledgerfen has named (a fear confessed at the Intake Causeway, a diagnosis read in the Records Basin, a true weakness given to the Catalog), the

Surgeon strikes it with advantage and aims every blow at that exact hurt. Take the name back — drown the form, burn the diagnosis, speak a ward over it — and the advantage dies with it.

Scaling (Levels 1-10): run it at C-Rank for a level 3-5 party; on a later return, raise it to A-Rank and let it operate on two patients at once.

Suggested traits:

- Multiattack with scalpel and restraint injection.
- Surgical Precision, crits on 19-20.
- Emergency Protocol at half HP, summoning paper-bodied orderlies.
- Anesthetic Cloud, 15 ft. cone, DC 13 Vitality save or unconscious for 1 minute with repeat saves.

Loot and Clues

- D-Rank and C-Rank cores.
- Surgical Relic or precision blade.
- A drowned clue toward a piece of the Means.
- If the Warden has seeded a piece of the Means here, it is sealed inside a diagnosis the fen wrote in a hand no one taught it — a truth about the Quiet, kept where only the drowned could hold it.

Aftermath & What the Dark Remembers

- **Mercy** — free the Specimen Vault survivor and they become a witness who can later swear that the Ledgerfen's dead were never truly dead, only kept.
- **Violence** — burn the place and the black water only rises to swallow the ash; whatever you killed here the fen remembers, and the Quiet later wears it back at you, never the reason.
- **Bargain** — every truth traded to the Catalog returns from the dark later, spoken back in the party's own voices, in the worn mouths of the dead.
- **Clean clear** — reduce one future travel complication, and let a settlement's casualty report come up blank for the first time in living memory.

Exit tone (read aloud): Behind you the pen has stopped. On the intake desk, the casualty report with today's date is gone — taken back, the Catalog would say, as pending. The water still gives nothing back.

Chapter 10: The Fungal Depths

The Fungal Depths

Rank and Role

Rank: D **Recommended Level:** 2-4 **Campaign Role:** Adaptive ecology, body horror, the first true pressure site.

Overview

The Fungal Depths are caverns beneath the Gloamreach where the Rift's mana taught the rot to *remember* — a living ecology that adapts, cultivates, and learns, sliding into wet decay at its lowest reaches. Pale shelves of fungus grow in long imitation rows; spore-clouds carry voices the caverns have copied; and the deeper the party goes, the more the place imitates rooms they have slept in, in shapes just wrong enough to notice.

Read aloud: The air is warm, wet, and faintly sweet — and it breathes, in when you breathe out. Bioluminescence pulses along the walls in slow rows, like something reading. Ahead, your light finds a chamber laid out exactly like the last safe room you rested in, down to where you set your packs. You have never been here. It has.

The native settlements above give their dead, their grief, and their secrets to the Depths, and the Depths cultivate every one.

What This Place Does

Dread: Anything that stays down here long enough is *cultivated* — grown into, grown through, made another part of the colony. **The Lure:** A place to be rid of things — grief, corpses, secrets too heavy to carry. Bury them in the warm dark and walk out lighter. **The Cost:** The rot copies whatever it takes. Your dead, your secrets, your sleeping face — it learns them all by heart. **If You Linger:** What you buried grows a body of its own, wears your memory of it, and walks home ahead of you.

Key Areas

The Glowing Cavern

Beautiful, warm, and dangerous. Standing still for more than a minute requires a DC 10 Vitality save or hallucinations impose disadvantage on the next perception-based check.

The Mycelium Maze

A DC 13 Survival or Sense check keeps the party on course. On failure, they loop for one hour and each character saves against spore exposure.

The Nursery

Wet pods the size of people hang in rows, each grown around a secret a settlement buried here — a confession, a corpse, a name no one was supposed to say. Inside, the Depths are building *bodies* for them (the Failure: the secrets grow bodies and walk home). Burning a pod is safer. Reading the membrane-script labels teaches far more, and costs far more — because some of the names are about to become someone again.

The Root Confessional

The fungi repeat confessions surrendered by nearby settlements. A character may learn a local lie, but must make a DC 13 Sense save or speak one true regret aloud.

Boss: Mycelium Hive Queen

Reskin a **C-Rank brute/controller Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Mycelium Hive-Queen — less a creature than the Depths' whole network grown a mouth. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume. It clings to the ceiling, drags prey through spore-slick water, and **regenerates while in contact with the cavern network** (the entire Depths is its body).

The Law in play: *anything that remains long enough is cultivated.* Anyone who has lingered, eaten, slept, or bled in the Depths is partly *hers* — advantage to grapple or compel them. Fire severs her from the network for one round; so does forcing her off every surface at once.

Scaling (Levels 1-10): C-Rank for a level 2-4 party; on a later return, raise her to A-Rank and let her field the bodies from the Nursery as they finish growing.

Loot and Clues

- Spore-sac Relic.
- Purified mycelium crystal.
- A Means clue hidden inside a pod that has grown around a Vermillion salvage-tag — a native diver the Depths cultivated long before the party arrived.
- If the Warden seeded a piece of the Means here, it is encased in white mycelium that refuses light.

Aftermath & What the Dark Remembers

- **Burn it back** — torch the Nursery and the settlements above lose their quiet disposal-ground; their grief has to go *somewhere* now, and nowhere kind is left.
- **Let it grow** — leave the pods and at least one buried secret walks home to the wrong door, wearing a body the Depths built for it.
- **The copied room** — whatever safe room the Depths imitated, the party will find the real one again later. It will never feel safe the same way.

Exit tone (read aloud): The breathing fades behind you — then matches your pace again, one breath delayed — until you reach the surface and your own lungs are the only ones you can hear. Probably.

Chapter 11: The Remembering Orchard

The Remembering Orchard

Rank and Role

Rank: C **Recommended Level:** 5-7 **Campaign Role:** Travel horror; an Essence-ecology that learns your grief; a settlement-memory crisis.

Overview

The Remembering Orchard is not a grove. It is an **anomalous Essence-bloom** — black, glassy resonance-stalks that erupted where the Rift's mana saturated an old evacuation greenhouse and taught grief to grow. Each stalk fruits **memory-cores**: Essence crystals, warm at the edges and cold at the heart, each holding a single extracted memory. Some are sweet. Some are rotten. Some belong to no one still alive.

It is an ecology that *learns*. The longer the party lingers, the more the orchard fruits in shapes they recognize: a face, a kitchen, a hand they have not held in years.

*Read aloud: Mana-frost crunches underfoot. The stalks hum — not wind, a chord, a thousand small voices holding one low note. Light moves inside the fruit like a slow heartbeat. Your AFA flags the nearest cluster as **civilian biosignatures**, then corrects itself, then flags it again.*

The Gloamreach's **native inhabitants** — whole settlements of them, born to a country that has only ever known the dark — leave one memory at the orchard's edge per household, a ward-offering as old as the bloom, and the harvest passes their shelters by for one more season. Refuse the custom, or take more than you give, and the orchard chooses its own harvest.

What This Place Does

Dread: What you let yourself forget here does not leave you in peace — it takes root, fruits, and belongs to the Orchard now. **The Lure:** Relief. Hand over a grief, a guilt, a face you cannot stop seeing, and the Orchard lifts it away, gently and whole. **The Cost:** It takes a true memory with the pain, and you will never be sure which warm thing went missing alongside the wound. **If You Linger:** The Orchard stops waiting to be offered anything and reaches in to *choose its own harvest*.

Key Areas

The Harvest Gate

A frame of fused resonance-stalk hung with ration-tags instead of name tags. Hang a tag bearing a true name and the orchard takes you for one who keeps the old custom: safe passage, but the place has your name now, and you are a step closer to Quiet-Marked. Hang a blank tag and the harvester-things treat you as *unknown* — safer for now, but the orchard begins to study you to learn the name you withheld.

The Sweet Rows

Memory-cores here hold pleasant things — first snow, a win, a warm room. Absorbing one (a touch is enough) grants a short Essence boon and a memory that is not yours. Take more than one and make a DC 13 Sense save or suffer **resonance bleed**: the borrowed memory starts answering to your name. Take too many, and the party can no longer agree on who remembers what.

The Rot Rows

Cores gone necrotic where the rot creeps in from the bloom's dead edge. They whisper accusations in the voices of the betrayed. A DC 14 search recovers the true name of someone the Gloamreach has taken, a clue toward the Means, or the location of a memory the dark would rather stayed buried — but each search quietly costs the searcher one of their own warm memories, and the orchard never tells them which.

The Caretaker's Shed

Not a shed — a **harvest-station**: Bureau-issue Essence-extraction rigs, repurposed and grown over with stalk, every clamp and canister labeled with a household's ration-number rather than a name. The Caretaker keeps it immaculate. It is not cruel. It is *thorough*. That is worse.

Boss: The Orchard Caretaker

Reskin a **C-Rank controller/stalker Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Caretaker — a memory-echo construct grown from the orchard's accumulated grief, wearing the shape of the last harvester it absorbed. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume. It does not prune branches. It prunes *people*.

RA abilities (layer onto the source block):

- **Pruning Hook** — melee; on a hit, the target loses access to one prepared Rune or technique until they recall a true memory aloud.
- **Graft** — the Caretaker presses a memory-core to a target; DC 14 Sense save or they act on a borrowed memory for one round (attack the wrong creature, defend the wrong ally).
- **Harvest Bell** — rings the resonance-chord; every claimed memory in the bloom answers at once, and unattended cores rise as grief-thralls.

What it holds onto: what you willingly forget here, the Orchard keeps for its own. The Caretaker has advantage against anyone who has eaten a core or hung a true-name tag. A party that takes nothing and gives nothing is hard for it to grip.

Scaling (Levels 1-10): C-Rank for a level 5-7 party; on a later return, raise it to A-Rank and let it field-harvest a whole settlement's cores in a single Harvest Bell.

Loot and Clues

- Memory fruit that can answer one question truthfully.
- Orchard knife Relic.
- If the Warden seeded a piece of the Means here, it hangs from a stalk that fruits only names instead of memory-cores.

Aftermath & What the Dark Remembers

- **Mercy** — leave the bloom un-harvested and one marked household keeps another season of itself; that survivor can later testify that the orchard's "custom" was always theft, and that nothing the Gloamreach asks of you is ever truly a bargain.
- **Greed** — eat the wrong core and, somewhere down the line, the Quiet calls to the party using a memory they swallowed here, in the voice it belonged to.
- **The tempting fruit** — at least once, let the bloom grow a core holding a memory the party genuinely *lost*. It is real. It is theirs. Taking it back means taking it from whoever the Domain has been copying it onto.

Exit tone (read aloud): The chord follows you to the tree line and stops all at once, like a held breath. Behind you a new stalk is already budding — pale, small, and shaped, if you look at it too long, like the back of your own head.

Chapter 12: The Ashen Counting-House

The Ashen Counting-House

Rank and Role

Rank: C **Recommended Level:** 4-6 **Campaign Role:** Fire-and-ash haunting; an endless burning hall where the dead are not permitted to stop dying.

Overview

The Ashen Counting-House is the Gloamreach's great hall of the burning dead — a tiered hall of black wood and brass that has been on fire, gently and without end, since before anyone now living was born. The flame does not consume. It *keeps*. Every soul the Gloamreach has gathered here still moves through the fire, unburned and unfreed, going through the motions of the lives the dark took from them — tending the hall, keeping its warmth, waiting a very long time for someone new to come in out of the cold.

Read aloud: Heat meets you at the threshold like a held hand, and the air tastes of hot brass and ash. Figures move through the flames unhurried, robed in fire that does not blacken them, going about old and pointless errands — and as you enter, every one of them looks up at once and smiles, the way the long-lonely smile at a familiar face. One of them says your name. You have never met. It says your name again, warmer this time, and steps toward you out of the fire.

What This Place Does

Dread: Nothing here is allowed to finish burning. The fire took everyone and the fire *kept* them — shapes and voices still moving in the flame, still doing the thing they died doing. **The Lure:** Warmth in a cold country, shelter from the road, and dead who know your face, call you by a kind name, and beg you to stay a while by the fire. **The Cost:** The hall warms itself by burning. Sit too long and it begins to take your heat, your name, the years you have left, and feed them to the same unfinished blaze. **If You Linger:** You stop being a guest and become part of the hall — another shape in the fire, learning the next traveler's face, begging them to stay.

Key Areas

Burning Lobby

Extreme heat. Without protection, characters take minor fire damage over time. The fire does not spread randomly. It opens a path where the dead want the party to walk, and closes behind them, herding them gently toward the warmth at the hall's heart.

The Keeping-Boxes

Rows of iron boxes, each warm to the touch. Every one holds something the fire saved from a life it took — a wedding ring, a child's tooth, a letter never sent. Opening one (a key, a true name spoken to it, or a

DC 15 tools check) gives up the keepsake and wakes the dead soul it belonged to, who will want to know why a stranger is holding it.

The Asking-Floor

The oldest of the burning dead gather here and ask gentle, endless questions — who you were, who you have lost, who is waiting for you outside. Honest answers warm the dead and draw them closer; every truth told here is one the hall now keeps.

The Vault of Stolen Years

Behind the deepest fire, native civilians hang suspended in amber heat — not dead, not living, the years of their lives slowly drawn out of them to feed the hall's endless burning. Freeing them returns those years all at once to the settlements they came from, with everything that implies.

Boss: The Warden of Embers

Reskin a **C-Rank (A-Rank for later returns) controller Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Warden of Embers — the oldest soul in the hall, the first the fire ever kept, now mostly flame and longing. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume. It attacks with grasping fire, chains of molten memory that bind a target to a grief or a loss, and the lesser burning dead it calls up out of the floor.

What keeps it burning: the Warden cannot be put down while the hall still burns, and the hall burns on grief — it has advantage against anyone here carrying a fresh loss, and reaches straight for it. To end the Warden the party must *put out the hall*: free the Vault of Stolen Years, give the oldest dead the name it has forgotten, or carry a piece of the Means into the fire's heart, where the burning is rooted. Strike down its body alone and it rises again from the next soul the fire holds.

Scaling (Levels 1-10): C-Rank for a level 4-6 party; on a later return, raise it to A-Rank and let it call up every grief and loss the party carries at once.

Loot and Clues

- Fire-aspected Relic.
- A keepsake the fire saved, and with it the name of someone the Gloamreach still has by the throat — a native faction figure, or a Bureau officer the dark has been quietly wearing down.
- If the Warden seeded a piece of the Means here, it is sealed in a keeping-box that opens only for someone who names aloud, and truly, what they have lost.

Aftermath & What the Dark Remembers

- **Free them gently** — give the burning dead the names they have forgotten and they go out like candles, one by one, finally still; but the hall remembers *who* set them free, and the dark now knows the party's faces by firelight.
- **Smother the heart** — put out the root at the fire's center and a whole stratum of the Gloamreach's hold goes cold; the Quiet feels it go out, and the worn dead that haunt this stretch of country lose one of the threads they followed.

- **The Vault of Stolen Years** — free the suspended and their drawn-out years crash back onto the settlements they came from, all at once. Mercy here arrives with a weight.

Exit tone (read aloud): The doors let you out into cool air, and for a moment it feels like escape — until you notice the faint warmth against your chest, where something has tucked itself among your things: a single ember, dimmed but not dead, patient as a held breath. It knows the way back. It is in no hurry.

Chapter 13: The Sunken Tunnels

The Sunken Tunnels

Rank and Role

Rank: B **Recommended Level:** 6-7 **Campaign Role:** Claustrophobic travel, drowned infrastructure, old-city horror.

Overview

The Sunken Tunnels are a drowned under-road beneath the Gloamreach — flooded native warrens, old water-conduits, and burial galleries the rising black has swallowed. The water is cold and full of voices, and every passage slopes downward no matter which way you believe you are going.

What This Place Does

Dread: What goes under here does not come back up. The water keeps the drowned, and they are still down there — still reaching, still certain they need only one more breath. **The Lure:** A shortcut. The tunnels promise to cut hours from the road, a fast dark way beneath everything that hunts the surface. **The Cost:** The deep takes breath, warmth, and names — and the drowned will press theirs upon you, which is never a gift. **If You Linger:** The way closes behind you, the water climbs to meet the ceiling, and the only path left is *down*, where the others went.

Key Areas

Flood Gate

The entrance seals after the party descends. Opening it from inside requires solving which name belongs to which drowned voice.

The Deep Trench

A long swim or raft crossing. Something large follows below without attacking until someone speaks.

Shrine of Wet Candles

The Awoko maintain a shrine here. Their candles burn underwater. Destroying the shrine angers the Hollow Mother but weakens one cult ritual.

Air Pocket Chapel

A place to rest, but only if the party leaves a light burning for the drowned.

Boss: The Abyssal Leviathan

Use a B-Rank aquatic solo. It grapples, drags, and separates. It should feel less like a fish and more like the tunnel's hunger given muscle.

Loot and Clues

- Cold or water-aspected Relic.
- Awoko ritual evidence.
- If the Warden seeded a piece of the Means here, it is inside the Leviathan's ribcage, still beating.

Chapter 14: Bastion Golemfall

Bastion Golemfall

Rank and Role

Rank: B **Recommended Level:** 7-8 **Campaign Role:** The natives' last stand; failed protection; the Domain's law that drafts even the dead.

Overview

Bastion Golemfall is the Gloamreach's own last stand — a native fortress raised in the years its people still believed the dark could be *walled out*. They forged **Golems** to hold the line: Essence-core constructs tall as gatehouses, sworn into the stone itself — walls given will, the refusal of a line to fall. The Golems fell when the wall did. The defenders never got to stop.

Read aloud: The wall is a broken jaw against the sky. Armor still stands at every post — upright, weapon ready, empty. As you cross the threshold a siege-bell rings, slow and certain, though no hand is near the rope, and your AFA logs forty-one friendly contacts holding position. None of them have a heartbeat. None of them have moved in a very long time.

Here the Gloamreach's cruelest trick is plain: *a line once sworn must be held* — forever, and death is not discharge. Whatever the defenders swore themselves to, the dark has held them to it ever since.

What This Place Does

Dread: The siege never ended. The defenders swore to hold the line and they are holding it still, dead a hundred years, because here nothing is permitted to lay its duty down. **The Lure:** Allies. The oathbound dead will stand beside the party, share old tactics, press warm Bastion iron into their hands — anyone who will help man the wall is welcome. **The Cost:** The wall takes its help in kind. Stand the line with them and it begins to count you among its sworn, asking — every time — whether *you* are the relief that was promised. **If You Linger:** The dead stop asking and begin to *draft*. You held the line once; now it will not let you leave it.

Key Areas

Broken Gatehouse

The wall's last working gate; its Golem-lock reads intent, not keys. It opens only for those who will swear — and mean it — to hold the line for someone other than themselves. Swear falsely and the oath binds anyway: the Bastion simply adds your name to the roster of the drafted.

Hall of Empty Armor

Rows of native wall-warden harness, each suit holding a defender's **echo**, bound by the oath to its gear. Touch one and live its last hour of the siege: tactical insight, and psychic strain as the echo asks — every time — whether *this* relief column is the one that was promised.

The Wall That Fell

The breach itself — a battlefield that never finished. Fight here and you fight beside, and against, the oathbound dead and the half-risen **golem** cores still straining to close a gap that closed an age ago. The Domain keeps the battle warm because here, nothing is allowed to end.

Commander Without a Body

The native commander who gave the wall its oath — now only a voice in the cold and a shape moving through the bells. She can become an ally, but only if convinced the party means to *break* the hold the Gloamreach has on her people, not merely take the Bastion and leave her garrison bound to the wall forever. She remembers every name on the roster. She would like to stop.

Boss: The Oath-Forge Colossus

Reskin a **B-Rank construct Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the Oath-Forge Colossus — the greatest of the native Golems, the one the defenders poured their last oath into. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume.

The Law in play: *a line once sworn must be held.* The Colossus **cannot be permanently destroyed while any oath in the Bastion is still unresolved** — drop it and it reforms from the next echo's vow. To end it, the party must *discharge the garrison*: complete, contradict, or release the defenders' oath (free the Commander, prove the relief was never coming, or take the wall's duty onto themselves for one true round).

Scaling (Levels 1-10): B-Rank for a level 7-9 party; on a later return, raise it to A-Rank and let it field a line of lesser Golems that share its unkillable condition.

Loot and Clues

- Shield or armor Relic.
- A banner that grants advantage against fear effects once.
- If the Warden seeded a piece of the Means here, it is welded into the Commander's empty helm — she has been guarding it without knowing what it is.

Aftermath & What the Dark Remembers

- **Discharge** — release the garrison and the empty armor finally *falls*, all at once, forty-one suits hitting the stone like a single breath let go. That sound carries. Other claimed places hear it.
- **Conquest** — take the Bastion without freeing the oath and the party simply becomes its new garrison; the wall does not care who holds it, only that it is held, and the dark is content to let them hold it forever.
- **The Commander** — if freed, she can bear witness that the Gloamreach's "service" is only conscription of the dead, or stand with the party at the end as the one soldier the dark cannot draft twice.

Exit tone (read aloud): The bell does not ring as you leave. After so long, the silence is the loudest thing on the wall.

Chapter 15: The Obsidian Spire

The Obsidian Spire

Rank and Role

Rank: A **Recommended Level:** 8-9 **Campaign Role:** Vertical trial; the temptation to stop being prey; the Gloamreach offering the party the one thing that would end their fear — at the cost of what they are.

Overview

The Obsidian Spire rises from a field of glass-black stone — a single shard of something older than the Gloamreach's surface, driven up through it like a tooth. Each floor tests an aspect of survival pushed past its limit — what you would do, what you would sacrifice, how far you would go, who you would stop being — and the higher the party climbs, the more openly the Spire addresses them not as prey but as *candidates*. It has one question for everyone who reaches the top: why be hunted, when you could hunt? It is not the first thing to climb the Spire, and whatever answered last is still out there in the dark.

Read aloud: The obsidian takes your reflection and gives it back a beat too late, standing taller than you stand. Essence-light runs in the stone like veins under skin. At the foot of the first stair a voice with no source says — warmly, as if continuing a conversation you began long ago — "You've done well to come this far. Most of them are still down in the dark, being hunted. You don't have to be."

The Spire's danger is not that its power is fake. It is that the power is real, the price is exact, and it is always offered to the worst possible version of whoever reaches for it.

What This Place Does

Dread: The Spire shows you who you would be if you stopped holding back — and it is patient, and persuasive, and the version it shows you is *winning*. **The Lure:** Power, plainly offered. Climb, and at every landing it hands you the strength you always wished you had — no trial named, no price spoken aloud. **The Cost:** It takes a confession first — your fear, your weakness, the line you swore never to cross — and forges the gift out of exactly that. **If You Linger:** The Spire remakes you into the worst, strongest version of yourself, and that version does not climb back down — it goes hunting.

Key Areas

Floor of Kneeling Statues

Every statue has a party member's face. Some cower. Some have become something that hunts. Some are broken.

The Watcher's Gallery

The Watcher offers bargains. None should be pure traps. The best temptations are genuinely useful.

Trial of the Herd

The party must keep a group of panicking, doomed natives alive across exposed ground without spending any of them as bait to save themselves.

Trial of Mercy

A defeated enemy asks for the kind of mercy they denied others.

Boss: The Spire Guardian

Reskin an **A-Rank tactical Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (see the bestiary appendix) as the Spire Guardian — the Spire's examiner, wearing whichever of the party it judges strongest. Keep its source stat block; change only the costume. It studies, then **copies the party's best tactic after seeing it once**, and turns it back on them.

What feeds it: *power calls to power*. The Guardian grows stronger against anyone who has accepted a Spire bargain or reached for the predator's power in the trials — the more of their humanity the party traded for strength, the more of a grip it has on *them*. Refusing the Spire's gifts is the surest way to leave it nothing to copy.

Scaling (Levels 1-10): A-Rank for a level 8-10 party; for a late return, S-Rank, fielding copies of the party's own defeated tactics in sequence.

Loot and Clues

- A-Rank Relic or Sigil.
- A true thing about the Quiet — perhaps the oldest there is: a hint of what it may have been before it was only hunger.
- If the Warden seeded a piece of the Means here, the Watcher offers it as a bargain with a visible cost.

Aftermath & What the Dark Remembers

- **Refused the gift** — climb the Spire and take nothing, and the party leave as the one thing the dark has no easy hold on: people who were offered the way out of being prey and said no. The Quiet has no lure built for someone who already refused the only thing it could offer.
- **Took the power** — accept a Spire gift and a part of the party stops being prey. The campaign's darkest ending opens: a character who climbs high enough and takes enough can *become* a hunter of the Gloamreach — and its price is everyone who ever loved the person they used to be.
- **The Watcher** — treated as a person rather than a vending machine, it can tell the party, later and at a price, exactly what climbed the Spire once before and what it agreed to become. (It was watching then, too.) Whether that thing is the Quiet, it will not say.

Exit tone (read aloud): From the Spire's height the whole Gloamreach lies open below — roads, settlements, the lightless deep — and for one breath it looks less like a country than a hunting-ground, with prey in it, and a place at the top of it all shaped exactly like you. Then the stair carries you back down into the dark, and the fit is the thing you cannot stop feeling.

Chapter 16: The Long Dark and the Threshold

The Long Dark and the Threshold

Rank and Role

Rank: S **Recommended Level:** 9-10 **Campaign Role:** The finale — the last, deepest crossing of the Gloamreach to the sealed Threshold, where the party gets out, or makes the one stand that ends the hunt for good.

Overview

There is no castle at the end of the road and no throne to reach. The finale is the way *back*: the longest, darkest crossing of the Gloamreach, from the deep places to the sealed Threshold the party came through on Day One — the door that shut behind them and has not opened since. The Quiet hunts hardest here, because it knows what they mean to do. Everything the campaign taught about silence, light, Essence, and the wards now has to hold under the worst pressure it ever will.

The party come to the Threshold with one of two intentions, and may not decide which until they arrive: **get the door open and run**, or — if they are 9th level or higher and carry the Means — **turn and make the one stand that kills the Quiet**. Killing it is the harder road and the cleaner one: the Quiet is what holds the Threshold shut, so with it dead the seal simply fails.

Read aloud: You know this place. You stood here on the first day, when the door was a door and the dark was just dark. The Threshold is exactly as you left it — sealed, patient, the seam of it cold under your hands — and behind you the Gloamreach has gone completely silent for the first time since you arrived. Not the safe kind. The kind a held breath makes, right before. It is done waiting. So are you.

The Long Dark (the approach)

Run the approach as the campaign's hardest survival sequence, not a dungeon crawl. Hold these beats in whatever order the crossing takes them.

The Gathered Dead

Everything the Quiet has ever worn is here at once: every lost teammate, every native it took, every familiar face the party learned to distrust, between them and the door. They do not rush. They line the dark and call, in every voice the party has grieved — all of it true, all of it bait. This is the Quiet spending everything it has collected.

The Failing Wards

The last native wardlines fail one by one as the party pass, the safe-holds that sheltered them all campaign going dark behind them. A community that trusts the party may hold its wardline open one extra hour to let them reach the Threshold; a community they wronged shuts early, and the dark gets the gap.

The Deaf Place

If the party charted the Mana Veins (Ch32), the silence they earned lives here: one stretch the Quiet cannot hear, or the dead-silent heart where a kill could land. Without it, the whole crossing is loud, and the Hunt Clock barely stops.

The Threshold

The sealed door itself. Reopening it is not a lockpick check — it is the campaign's last hard choice (see **The Endings**). The Quiet arrives as they work, because of course it does.

The Quiet at the End

This is the one time the party see the Quiet fully, and the only time a stand-up fight with it is anything but suicide. Run it in two faces:

1. **The Lure.** Before violence, it offers — in the shape of the dead, the way out, the rest they are owed, the people they lost made whole. The offer can even be real. Holding to what is true (living allies, a true name, the Means) is what gets them through; answering the lure is how it takes the last of them.
2. **The Hunt, Unleashed.** When the lure fails, it comes — fast, total, everywhere in the dark at once. If the party mean only to escape, this is a desperate hold-the-door scene: survive long enough to get the Threshold open, losing what they must. If they mean to kill it, see below.

Killing the Quiet (the gated stand)

The kill is possible only at **9th level or higher** and only with the **Means** assembled — a truth about what it is, a way to hold it still, and a way to make it stay dead (see *The Means to End It* and *The Means Cross-Reference*). When the party commit, the Means is what makes the fight survivable: spent fully, it drags the Quiet down out of its invulnerability into something a level-10 party can kill — forced into a silence and dark it cannot slip, stripped of its power to simply *take* a character, pinned in the deaf place or at the Threshold where the kill can land. It still fights to the last breath, and still tries to take someone into the dark with it. Make the cost real: the kill should plausibly take one of them. A party that pays it has done the rarest thing in the Gloamreach.

The Endings

The campaign is open-ended by design — these are doorways to what comes next, not a full stop. A closed Rift, in *Rift Ascendant*, is only a story that can be reopened.

Escape — (the surer victory)

The party get the Threshold open and go, carrying out as many of themselves, and as many natives, as they earned the trust to lead. The Quiet lives. The Gloamreach stays hunted, its people still behind their wards — and the party leave knowing it, carrying their marks, their losses, and the certainty that the door can open again. **Open thread:** the Rift remains; another team, another season, and the ones they left behind.

Kill — (the clean way out)

The party put the Quiet down for good. The thing that held the Threshold shut is gone, and the seal fails on its own — the door opens, and they can simply leave. What becomes of the Gloamreach now is the campaign's biggest open question: a country that has never known a dark without a hunter in it, suddenly without one. Do the natives finally leave? Does the country heal — or does something rise to fill the silence the Quiet left? **Open thread:** an unhunted Gloamreach, free for the first time in living memory, and whatever moves to fill an empty place at the top.

Become — (*the dark road; the Spire's price*)

If a character took the Obsidian Spire's gift and climbed high enough, the finale can end not with the Quiet dead but with a *second* apex in the dark: one of the party, no longer prey, and no longer entirely theirs. They might open the Threshold for the others and stay; they might walk out, changed, carrying the dark with them. Treat it as the hardest ending to live with. **Open thread:** a new hunter, in the Gloamreach or beyond it, and everyone who still remembers who they used to be.

Warden Guidance

The finale should not ask only, "Can the party get out?" It should ask, "What did they keep alive — others, and themselves — and what did it cost?" However it ends, leave a door ajar. Nothing in the Gloamreach is ever quite finished, least of all the dark.

Chapter 17: How the Quiet Hunts

How the Quiet Hunts

Overview

The Quiet does not chase. It *converges*. It does not hurry, because it does not need to; it does not negotiate, because it was not made to. It is simply, always, on its way — and the closer it comes, the more of the Gloamreach belongs to it. Most of the time it hunts not in its own shape but through the **worn dead** it sends ahead (the Worn, the Caller, the Wrong Shape, the Hollowed — see the Bestiary), keeping its own terrible attention in reserve until the Hunt Clock fills.

This chapter is the mechanics of being hunted: how the pursuit feels, what holds it off, and what happens when it arrives.

First Sighting

Read aloud:

You hear it before you see anything — or rather, you stop hearing. The insects, the wind, the small sounds of the dark all go out like a held breath. Then, far off, a voice you know. It calls your name, or a name you lost, in exactly the right voice, from exactly the wrong place. It is patient. It can wait all night. It only needs you to answer once.

Use at the Table

The Quiet's hunt is a **survival, evasion, and warding** problem, never a stand-up fight. The party can:

- run silent and dark, giving the Hunt Clock nothing to fill on;
- reach a native wardline before the clock fills;
- give it what it came for — a terrible choice;
- or, at worst, fight off a **worn-dead hunter**, which buys time and means nothing, because there is always another face.

The Quiet itself cannot be killed and stay dead until the party are high tier and hold the Means (see The Means to End It). Until then, surviving its hunt means understanding what it is — not hitting harder.

What It Sends (by act)

Run the hunt through the worn dead, scaling with the party. Full stat blocks are in the Bestiary.

Act / Tier	The Quiet usually hunts through...
First Contact (L1-3)	The Worn (anomaly-0701) — corpses worn as lures and ambushers.
The Hunt (L4-6)	The Caller (anomaly-0702) and The Wrong Shape (anomaly-0703) — a lure that splits the party, and a trusted face that turns wrong.

Act / Tier	The Quiet usually hunts through...
The Long Dark (L7-9)	The Hollowed (anomaly-0704) — apex-fragments that hunt like the Quiet in miniature.
Threshold (L9-10)	The Quiet itself (anomaly-0700) — only when the Hunt Clock fills, or at the gated kill.

What Draws the Hunt

The Quiet and its worn dead converge on **noise, light, and Essence** (see Running This Horror). Fill the Hunt Clock for any of these. The natives' wards starve the hunt of all three — which is why the party must learn the rules.

d8	What just rang the bell
1	Gunfire, a shout, or a fight in the open.
2	An Ascendant used a technique, Sigil, or Awakened power.
3	An open flame or bright light in the dark.
4	A native rule or ward, broken.
5	The party answered a voice they should not have.
6	They sheltered, or refused to give up, someone the Quiet had marked.
7	They lingered too long in exposed ground.
8	They used the dead's own names carelessly, and something heard.

Holding It Off

The party can end a hunt scene without destroying the Quiet by:

1. **Silence and dark.** Give it nothing to converge on — no noise, no light, no Essence — and slip away.
2. **The wardline.** Reach a native safe-hold; its wards keep the Quiet, and usually its worn dead, out — so long as the party keep the rules.
3. **A true name.** Naming a worn-dead lure for what it is can break it; naming the Quiet's nature can make it flinch (see The Means to End It).
4. **Running water, a hard threshold, hallowed native ground** — places its hold thins.
5. **Giving it what it came for** — the worst mercy, and sometimes the only one.
6. **Simply outrunning it for now** — knowing it has not stopped, and never will, until the party are out or it is dead.

Warden Guidance

The hunt is most frightening when the party realize the only question left is *how long can we stay ahead of it*. Never let combat be the answer; let silence, the dark, the rules, and the wardline be the answer. The night they finally have to choose who to give up is the night this campaign becomes unforgettable.

Chapter 18: Side Quests of the Gloamreach

Side Quests of the Gloamreach

Overview

These quests are the country-scale obligations of survival. Each should reveal something about how the Gloamreach is survived, the cost of it, or the factions trying to control the outcome.

Quest 1: The Missing Strike Team

Giver: Commander Park **Objective:** Find Strike Team Seven inside the Gloamreach.

Steps:

1. Recover their first broken transmission near the Rift Threshold.
2. Follow AFA ghost-pings along the old roads, deeper in.
3. Find remains or survivors in Bastion Golemfall, the Sunken Tunnels, or the deep Gloamreach.
4. Decide whether to return the truth to the Bureau or hide what the team became.

Rewards: Bureau reputation, Ghost as a possible ally, and hard intelligence about the Quiet's hunting grounds.

Quest 2: Mother Rust's Breakthrough

Giver: Mother Rust **Objective:** Recover living mana from the Fungal Depths or Remembering Orchard.

Mother Rust can use it to treat Rift-Rot and Gloamreach exposure, but the same compound can also suppress emotion and make people easier to move through grief-heavy terrain.

Rewards: Vermillion reputation, advanced healing, and possible Mother Rust alliance or corruption arc.

Quest 3: The Cult Defector

Giver: Whisper, Sister Veil, or Acolyte Mara **Objective:** Extract a defecting Awoko member from the Sanctum.

The defector knows the Hollow Mother intends to feed the flock to the Quiet to be remade, not to save anyone. The cult will try to recover them alive because their grief has already been measured for ritual use.

Rewards: Awoko ritual intelligence, Bureau/Vermillion reputation, and a way to disrupt the Ritual of Becoming.

Quest 4: Torch's Letter

Giver: Torch **Objective:** Get a letter out through the Bureau Annex relay.

This is a small human quest. Keep it small. That is why it matters.

Rewards: Torch as an ally, Vermillion reputation, and proof the party still cares about people beyond the main plot.

Quest 5: The Millwright's Device

Giver: The Millwright **Objective:** Build a one-use device that forces a pocket of silence.

Components:

1. One B-Rank core.
2. A schematic from Hayashi or Lun.
3. A gear-heart from the mills.
4. A field test at a Mana Vein node.

Reward: one-use silence — a pocket the Quiet cannot hear, for one scene (a Means component; see Ch32).

Quest 6: Mika's Prophecy

Giver: Mika the Kid **Objective:** Protect Mika and interpret her drawings.

Each drawing foreshadows a piece of the Means, a betrayal, the worn dead coming, a community's hard bargain, or the deep dark.

Reward: prophetic hints and final-act emotional leverage if Mika survives.

Quest 7: Iron Belle's Challenge

Giver: Iron Belle **Objective:** Win a nonlethal trial of strength, discipline, and restraint.

This should not be a throwaway fight. Iron Belle wants to know whether the party can stop before victory becomes cruelty.

Reward: Vermillion reputation, training, and Iron Belle's respect.

Quest 8: The Civilian Convoy

Giver: A settlement elder, Mother Rust, or Commander Park **Objective:** Escort civilians from a failing safe-hold to a stronger one.

Complications:

- The open road is loud, and the dark is listening.
- The worn dead may come for someone on the way.
- Some civilians believe leaving voids their community's wards.

Rewards: civilian trust, Bureau or Vermillion reputation, and settlement support in the finale.

Quest 9: Acolyte Mara's Rescue

Giver: Sister Veil **Objective:** Rescue Mara from the Awoko before she is used as ritual fuel.

Reward: Mara and Sister Veil as allies, ritual disruption, and proof that cultists can still be saved.

Quest 10: Ghost's Memory

Giver: Ghost **Objective:** Restore Ghost's identity without handing them back to Bureau custody as evidence.

Ghost's memories are hidden across dead-team markers, the Drowned Ledgerfen, and a Means-touched relic.

Reward: Ghost restored as a high-rank ally and classified intelligence about the Quiet.

Quest 11: Professor Lun's Theory

Giver: Professor Lun **Objective:** Place sensors at three Mana Vein nodes.

Reward: a charted deaf place — silence to use in the final crossing (see Ch32).

Quest 12: Rat-King Ji's Stash

Giver: Rat-King Ji **Objective:** Recover a hidden stash before the dark carries it off to someone else.

Reward: contraband, a Means clue, or a dangerous shortcut.

Warden Guidance

Every side quest should sharpen the central question: what does survival cost when the land itself is hunting you?

Chapter 19: Domain Pressure Encounters

Domain Pressure Encounters

Overview

Use these encounters when the Gloamreach needs to push back without derailing the party's current objective.

Pressure Types

Rule and Ward Pressure

A native rule the party did not know, a ward they must keep lit or keep dark, a price for shelter, or a custom they have already broken. This pressure teaches players that the rules are the only thing keeping the dark out — and the party do not know them all.

Environmental Pressure

Weather changes, food spoils, the road moves, shelter becomes conditional, or a settlement bell rings.

Social Pressure

A faction demands a decision. Civilians ask for help. Vermillion calls in a favor. Bureau orders contradict morality. Awoko comfort feels too useful.

Predatory Pressure

A worn-dead hunter, an umbral scout, an adaptive beast, or a cult cell tracks the party.

Encounter Rule

Every pressure encounter should reveal at least one of the following:

1. A native rule or ward.
2. A community's hard bargain to survive.
3. A faction cost.
4. A Means clue.
5. A future consequence.

Chapter 20: Recruitable Allies

Recruitable Allies

Overview

Allies should never be simple stat blocks. Each one represents a possible answer to the Gloamreach.

Ally Categories

Bureau Allies

Disciplined, supplied, and politically constrained. They help with logistics, research, and final-operation support.

Vermillion Allies

Fast, practical, and morally flexible. They help with salvage, black-market access, shelter, and unconventional solutions.

Civilian Allies

Vulnerable but narratively powerful. They create stakes, rumors, shelter, and emotional leverage.

Awoko Defectors

Dangerous because they know the cult's rituals and have already been shaped by grief. Saving them should matter.

Gloamreach-Born Allies

Rare and unstable. A spirit commander, a changed survivor, or an oathbound guardian may help if the party proves they do not intend to become hunters themselves.

Final-Act Use

Allies should affect the final crossing by opening paths, holding a wardline open, drawing off the worn dead, protecting civilians, revealing a rule, or building the once-only ward-circle the Means needs.

Chapter 21: Relics and the Means

Relics and the Means

Overview

The Means is the campaign's one structure of Relics that truly matter (see *The Means to End It*), but lesser Gloamreach-touched items appear throughout the country.

Relic Principles

1. A deep-Gloamreach Relic is never only powerful. It is a truth, a cost, or a piece of the Means.
2. Using one should attract attention — the dark notices power.
3. Carrying one may change how the roads and the worn dead behave around you.
4. A Relic can hold or hurt the Quiet for a heartbeat — but using one loudly also teaches the dark how the party fights.

Lesser Relic Examples

The Hush-Blade

A knife that makes no sound — no ring of steel, no cry from what it cuts. A kill with it does not fill the Hunt Clock, once per scene. The silence has to come from somewhere; it takes it from the wielder's own voice for an hour after.

The Ward-Stone

Held overnight, it keeps the worn dead off one unwarded rest. It cracks a little more each time, and when it finally breaks, whatever it kept out has been waiting.

The Name-Glass

Look through it at a familiar face and see whether it is truly itself or something worn. Using it, the looker feels the dark look back — fill the Hunt Clock.

The Quiet-Lamp

Sheds a light only the bearer can see — a small mercy in the dark that draws nothing. Its oil is the rendered grief of the taken, and it knows whose.

What the Dark Does When You Find the Means

When the party recover a piece of the Means, the Quiet feels it. Choose one pressure response:

1. The hunt sharpens — the Hunt Clock fills faster for a stretch.
2. The worn dead come for whoever carries it.
3. A community that helped pays for it, and the party hear about it.

4. The Awoko try to take it, to feed their own becoming.
5. The way deeper opens — but only toward worse.

Chapter 22: Treasure and Rewards

Treasure and Rewards

Overview

Rewards in the Gloamreach should feel useful, costly, and story-facing. Credits matter less when the road demands things money cannot buy.

Reward Categories

Cores

Still valuable to Bureau and Vermillion. Use cores for gear, research, medicine, and faction favors.

Relics

Tie Relics to the Gloamreach's nature. Even minor Relics should carry a hint of the dark — something lost, owed, remembered, or survived.

Sigils and Runes

Use Chapter 34 for tier guidance. Let factions offer different routes to similar power with different consequences.

Safe Shelter

A safe long rest can be more valuable than money. Make shelter a reward, not an assumption.

Names and Truths

The right name, truth, confession, or memory may defeat something combat cannot.

Final Rewards

After the campaign, rewards depend on the ending.

- Escape: their lives, a few haunted Relics from the deep, and the marks the Gloamreach left.
- Kill: a fragment of what the Quiet was, a Relic forged in the kill, or the spent Means itself — and an open future.
- Become: no loot, only consequence; a character who is now something that hunts.

Chapter 23: Warden's Horror Guide

Warden's Horror Guide

Intended Rating

Mature Dark Fantasy Rift Horror.

Use oppressive dread, psychological horror, body horror, starvation, isolation, institutional abandonment, corpse imagery, false safety, the uncanny, forced moral compromise, transformation horror, and the terror of being hunted by something you cannot see.

Do not use sexual violence, eroticized harm, real-world hate ideology, cruelty to children as spectacle, or torture-porn framing.

Horror Pillars

Being Prey

The Quiet's horror is being hunted. The dark, the roads, the worn dead, the open ground, and even the safe-holds all whisper the same thing: it already knows you are here, and it can wait.

False Safety

Fires, beds, warded walls, and kind natives should feel comforting and provisional at once — every safety in the Gloamreach is borrowed, and the dark is patient.

Bureau Failure

The Bureau is not useless. It is insufficient. Let the party feel the gap between protocol and reality.

Survival Compromise

Settlements survive by doing things they cannot emotionally survive doing forever.

Wearing the Dead

The Quiet was never a person and has no past to redeem — but it wears the party's dead perfectly, and offers their faces, their voices, and the comfort of them as bait. Do not use that to make it sympathetic. Use it to make every reunion hurt: the mercy the party reach for was assembled, out of people they loved, to be reached for.

Pacing Advice

Alternate pressure and breath. Horror needs contrast. A hot meal before a terrible choice will do more damage than constant screaming.

Warden North Star

Before every major scene, answer four questions:

1. What rule or ward keeps this place alive?
2. What does breaking it cost?
3. What is the Quiet drawn to here — and how loud are the party being?
4. What happens if they get loud anyway?

Chapter 24: What the Natives Know

What the Natives Know

There is no fortune to read here. The only map of the Gloamreach is in the heads of the people who have survived it, and they do not give it to strangers.

The Real Map Is in People's Heads

There is no oracle and no fortune. What the party can know about the Gloamreach — where the safe-holds are, which rules keep the Quiet out, where the deep places lie, and the first hints that it might even be *killable* — lives in the heads of the people who have lived here their whole lives. Intel is earned: by trust, by trade, by listening, by being useful — and sometimes by watching someone die for breaking a rule the party did not know.

This chapter replaces any fortune or oracle system. Use it to hand the party direction without a deck and without a railroad: the natives tell them what they need, when they have earned it.

How Intel Works

- **Gated on trust, not dice.** A native who fears or resents the outsiders tells them nothing useful (and may lie to protect their own). One who trusts them shares a rule, a route, a name. Track trust per community (see Factions and the native communities).
- **Partial and contradictory.** No one knows the whole Gloamreach. Different communities keep different rules and different rumors; some are wrong, some are old. The truth assembles slowly.
- **The most valuable thing here.** A single rule, learned in time, saves a life. Treat earned intel as the campaign's real treasure.

What There Is to Learn (seed across the campaign)

Spread these among the communities and the deep places, in whatever order play takes the party:

- **The rules and wards** — how each safe-hold keeps the Quiet out, and what must never be done. (*The immediate survival layer.*)
- **The routes** — which stretches of exposed ground can be crossed, when, and how to cross them quiet and dark. (*Travel.*)
- **The lost** — who the Quiet has taken, and whose face it might be wearing now. (*The uncanny; foreshadows the worn dead.*)
- **The deep places** — where the Gloamreach fails, where the worn dead thicken, and where the oldest natives say the truth about the Quiet might be found. (*Mid/late direction.*)
- **The Means** — the first hints that the Quiet could, in theory, be ended, and what that would cost. (*Late; see Chapter 2. Never a checklist.*)
- **The way out** — what the natives believe about the threshold, and why they cannot leave even if the party can. (*The escape ending, and the quiet tragedy in it.*)

The Keepers of Knowledge

Some natives hold more than others — an old ward-keeper, a child who sees true, someone who went into the dark and came back *almost* themselves. These are the campaign's intel anchors: protect them and the party gains direction; lose them and the party goes blind. (See the native communities and the cast.)

Warden Guidance

Never dump the map. Let the party earn it a piece at a time, always one rule behind safety. The dread is in not knowing the rule until the clock is filling — and the relief, when a native finally tells them, should feel like the only warmth in the Gloamreach.

Chapter 25: Ascendant Hooks - Reasons to Enter the Gloamreach

Ascendant Hooks - Reasons to Enter the Gloamreach

Purpose

Every character needs a reason to cross the S-Rank threshold and keep moving after escape becomes uncertain. These hooks replace older district-crisis assumptions and tie the party directly to the Gloamreach.

Personal Hooks

The Contract

The character signed a Bureau or Guild contract before the Domain classification was confirmed. Backing out now would ruin them financially, legally, or politically.

The Missing Team

Someone the character knows entered during the first response wave. Their AFA tag still pings from somewhere inside the Gloamreach, always farther down the road.

The Name in the Ledger

The character's name appears in something recovered from inside the Gloamreach before the campaign begins, written in a hand no one recognizes. No one knows how it got there.

The Survivor's Debt

The character survived a previous Rift because someone else stayed behind. The Gloamreach contains that person's voice, echo, body, or unpaid sentence.

The Bonded Relic

A Relic bonded to the character reacts violently when the Rift opens. It is not calling them to power. It knows the Gloamreach, and the Gloamreach knows it.

The Veteran of a Failed Clear

The character has seen a Rift stop behaving like a place and start behaving like a ruler. They know the Bureau briefing is too clean.

Group Hooks

1. The Bureau hires the party because higher-rank teams vanished inside.

2. Vermillion offers illegal support if the party agrees to recover salvage and survivors.
3. A settlement inside the Domain sends a written invitation that appears in the material world.
4. A dead Ascendant's AFA broadcasts from somewhere deep inside the Gloamreach every night at the same time.
5. The Rift enters a Rift Break countdown, forcing immediate entry.

Warden Guidance

The best hook is not glory. It is obligation. The Gloamreach should feel like a place the party enters because no better option exists, then survives because leaving would abandon too many people to the dark.

Chapter 26: Stat Blocks Appendix - Domain Use Notes

Stat Blocks Appendix - Using Creatures in the Gloamreach

Purpose

This appendix is Warden-facing guidance for running the Gloamreach's creatures. Full stat blocks live in the source compendium files (the bestiary, ranks D-S); the finale-critical blocks — the Quiet and the dead it wears — are printed in the bestiary appendix at the back of this book. This chapter explains how the country's threats fit together.

The Quiet Is the Apex, Not the Only Enemy

The Gloamreach is a whole country, and it must play like one. The Quiet is the apex predator and the campaign's final, optional fight — not the monster in every room. Most of what the party fights is the country's own ecology:

- **Each site has its own signature threat** — a local horror reskinned from the bestiary (the Drowned Ledgerfen's Head Surgeon, the Fungal Depths' adaptive growth, and so on). These are real, killable fights.
- **Factions and hostile natives** are threats too — the Awoko grief-cult, Vermillion rivals, wary communities, and the predators of the open wilds.
- **The worn dead** are the apex's reach into a scene, not the standard encounter. Putting one down is easy and means nothing; there is always another face.

The Layers Interlock

This is the engine that makes an ordinary fight frightening: every combat means noise, light, and Essence, and all three fill the Hunt Clock. Win too loud and the Quiet comes for someone before the party can catch their breath. The country's lesser threats are dangerous mostly because of what fighting them *calls*.

The Worn Dead as Recurring Hunters

When the campaign needs a recurring, escalating menace, use the worn dead, not a fixed officer. They appear by act — the Worn early, then the Caller and the Wrong Shape, then the Hollowed late (see the Quiet dossier and the bestiary). They lure, mimic, herd, and wait far more than they brawl, and they are hard to be rid of for good: there is always another.

The Old Power Below

Some deep places hold something older than the worn dead and not of the Quiet at all — the remnant of whatever stood here before, bound under the oldest wards. It has no ordinary stat block. If the party confronts it, run the scene as a trial, a bargain, or a memory dragged up from before living memory, and let it be one of the places where the truth about the Quiet's age can surface. Combat, if it comes, is through its guardians and the ruined things that once begged it and were refused.

Horror Encounter Rules

1. Every combat should reveal something about the Gloamreach or the people who live in it.
2. Every victory should cost time, supplies, reputation, safety, certainty — or noise.
3. Intelligent enemies should know the local rules and wards better than the party.
4. Monsters should not merely attack. They lure, mimic, herd, witness, or wait.

Scaling

For low-level parties, reduce damage but preserve consequences. For high-level parties, raise the *hunt* — the Hunt Clock, the worn dead, the cost of every loud win — before raising hit points. The Gloamreach is frightening because it changes what victory means.

Chapter 27: The Means and Treasure Cross-Reference

The Means and Treasure Cross-Reference

| *An artifact is a promise with enough power to outlive the person who made it. - Dr. Serin Hayashi*

Using This Chapter

This chapter maps the **Means to End the Quiet**, named items, Relics, Sigils, Runes, tattoos, and narrative props to their place in **Run Silent**. Full mechanical entries remain in the authoritative compendium files. This chapter keeps the module aligned with the item economy without duplicating stat blocks.

The Means to End It

The Means is the campaign's one path to killing the Quiet — never a fetch-quest, always discovered in play (see *The Means to End It*). It is built from three kinds of thing, and a party needs enough of each that the Warden is satisfied they have earned it. The Warden seeds the pieces across the deep places by hand; what the natives know (Ch24) points the way.

Component	What it is	Where it tends to surface
A truth	What the Quiet is, and whether it was always here.	The Deep Places, the Obsidian Spire's Watcher, the Old Power Below in the Mana Veins, the oldest natives.
A way to hold it still	A real Relic, weapon, or working that can pin a thing never fully there — forced silence and dark, a true name, a ward turned inward.	A hard-won treasure in the deep sites; the deaf place charted in the Mana Veins (Ch32).
A way to make it stay dead	A place or moment where the kill can land — the Threshold, a ward-circle the natives will build only once, the dead-silent heart of a vein.	The Threshold; a community's deepest ward, earned with their trust.

Finale Reward Guidance

The ending is not a loot pile, but a party that survives the Threshold has earned something. Choose by ending and party.

Escape

The party get out, the Quiet still hunting behind them. Their reward is what they carried out: their lives, a few hard-won Relics from the deep sites, and the marks the Gloamreach left on them. Anything taken from the Quiet's worn dead should feel haunted.

Kill

The rarest victory. The party may recover something from the place the Quiet fell — a fragment of whatever it truly was, a Relic the kill forged out of silence and dark, or simply the Means itself, spent but legendary. Let at least one reward be strange, story-facing, and a hook for what comes next.

Become

There is no loot here, only consequence. The character who took the predator's road is the reward and the price — power earned, humanity spent. What they are now is the next campaign's question.

Sigil Drops by Site

Site	Sigil Guidance
Hollow Way	Aegis, Grounded Soul, or mobility Sigil.
Drowned Ledgerfen	Frost-Ward, Iron Mind, or truth/diagnosis-themed protection.
Fungal Depths	Cleansed Blood or poison/rot resistance.
Remembering Orchard	Zephyr's Tread, Silent Guardian, or Sense/memory support.
Ashen Counting-House	Crimson Weeping, Hearth-Fire, or grief/blood Sigil.
Sunken Tunnels	Winter Court, Hearth-Fire, or underwater survival support.
Bastion Golemfall	Unmoving Stone, Dragon's Scale, or shield/armor Sigil.
Obsidian Spire	Void-Walker, Silent Guardian, Grandmaster's Edge.
The Threshold	Undying Flame, Iron Mind, or an S-tier finale reward.

Tattoos and Downtime Rewards

The Vermillion Outpost can provide tattoos from `tattoos.ts` at Trusted reputation. Tattoos should be offered as survival tools, identity marks, or body-horror-adjacent choices. The Gloamreach should make body modification feel powerful but intimate.

Runes

Use Chapter 34 for Rune tier placement. Runes should be scarce and story-facing. A Rune found in the Gloamreach should imply a prior owner, a cost, or a law it once served.

Campaign-Unique Narrative Props

The Faded Family Photo

Recovered in Day Zero (Cho) or deep in the Gloamreach: a lost face worn down to blank paper. The campaign's most important emotional prop. Carry it in, and the Quiet learns that face — and may one day wear it back at the party. The first lesson in how the dead are kept here.

Ms. Park's Wedding Ring

Optional if Ms. Park survived. When the Quiet wears her lost husband to lure the party, the ring can force one breath of doubt — in them, or in the thing pretending to be him.

The Visitors' Log

A local object from the Memory-Care Wing. Names written in it foreshadow how dangerous a written name becomes inside the Gloamreach.

The Unopened Commendation

Found in a deep place, addressed to a name reality can no longer keep — someone the Gloamreach took so completely the world forgot to finish their story.

The Child's Toy

Found far down in the dark, where no child should ever have been. Emotionally useful, never mechanically powerful: proof that the Quiet takes everyone, and keeps what they loved.

The Diploma

Proof that one of the taken had a whole life — a name, a place, a future — before the Gloamreach wore it away. Whose, the party may never be sure.

Warden Guidance

Artifacts in this campaign should not feel like treasure alone. They are evidence, leverage, temptation, and memory. The best item is one the party wants to use and fears using.

Chapter 28: The Deep Gloamreach - The Final Crossing

The Deep Gloamreach – The Final Crossing

There is no door at the end. The end is the door you came in by — and the longest dark between you and it.

Overview

This is the keyed version of the finale's crossing (see *The Long Dark and the Threshold*, Ch16): the deepest, darkest stretch of the Gloamreach, run as the campaign's final dungeon — except the dungeon is open country and old dark, and the only room that matters is the sealed Threshold at the far end. Run it as a sequence of survival-horror stages, in whatever order the crossing takes them, with the Hunt Clock louder than it has ever been and the Quiet closing the whole way.

This chapter keys the stages; Ch16 holds the Quiet's behaviour at the end, the gated kill, and the endings.

Before the Crossing

Resolve what the party carry into the dark — it decides how the crossing goes:

1. Which communities trust them enough to hold a wardline open?
2. Which did they wrong, so the wards shutter early and the dark gets the gap?
3. Do they carry the Means, and are they 9th level or higher? (If so, the kill is on the table.)
4. Did they chart the Mana Veins (Ch32) — is there a deaf place to use?
5. Is the Hollow Mother's ritual still active, and coming for the same dark they are?
6. Who have they already lost — because the Quiet is wearing them now.

The Crossing, Keyed

1. The Last Road

The final stretch of exposed ground, and the most watched. The dark *names* each character here — a true name surfacing in carved stone, in a whisper, on the lips of a worn-dead waiting at the verge. Answer it, or accept it, and the crossing grows easier and the Quiet's hold tighter (a step toward Quiet-Marked); refuse, stay silent and dark, and the road is longer but the dark keeps less of a grip. There is no toll and no gate — only how much of themselves the party give away to go faster.

2. The Field of the Lost

Open ground where everything the Quiet has ever worn stands waiting: lost teammates, taken natives, the familiar faces the party learned to distrust, all of it between them and the deep. They do not rush. They call, in every grieved voice at once — all true, all bait. Crossing means walking through the people you failed without answering one of them. *Dread save (DC 13 Sense), or a character spends a turn on the one they cannot leave.*

3. The Kept Things

A drowned hall of everything the Gloamreach has taken and saved: names, teeth, bells, wedding rings, children's drawings, unopened letters, the keepsakes of the dead (see the narrative props, Ch27). A character who searches may recover a true prop — and with it a true name, a truth about the Quiet, or a piece of the Means — but every minute spent here fills the Hunt Clock, and the hall remembers being robbed.

4. The False Safe-Hold

A warded-looking shelter, fires lit, a door standing open — everything the party have learned to run toward. It is the Quiet wearing a safe-hold. Resting here is real recovery and a trap: each character regains resources but must give the dark one true thing in trade (a memory, a name, a fear), and the worn dead are already inside, wearing the faces of hosts. A DC 14 Sense check feels the wrongness before the door closes.

5. The Map of Every Step

A stretch where the dark shows the party their whole crossing — every choice, every shortcut, every person left behind — laid out like a map drawn by something that watched it all. It can reveal a real shortcut to the Threshold, the location of a missed piece of the Means, or a betrayal among allies; reading it costs a point of Dread, because it is also the Quiet showing them it has seen everything.

6. The Room That Shouldn't Exist

A scrap of the material world preserved impossibly in the deep dark: a Bureau office, a hospital corridor, a childhood kitchen — somewhere a character knows. It holds the Unopened Commendation and curated "evidence" of a life. None of it is the Quiet's past; all of it is bait, assembled from the claimed to make the party stay. The horror is how badly they want it to be real.

7. The Last Memory-Bloom

A deep echo of the Remembering Orchard: black-barked growth fruiting memory in the dark. One fruit can restore a lost clue or a piece of the Means; one can show a true thing about the Quiet's origin (a hint, never the whole). Each costs the eater a warm memory of their own, and the bloom never says which.

8. The Awoko's Last Bid

If the Hollow Mother's ritual still runs: the cult break into the deep here, racing the party to the same dark — to be remade by the Quiet into hunters (Ch33). They are a threat and a possible distraction: the Quiet's attention can be turned on them instead, at the cost of whatever the party owe the Awoko, and whatever the cult becomes if it succeeds.

9. The Old Power Below

A stair going down past where the Quiet hunts, toward the remnant of whatever stood here first (the Old Power Below, Ch26 and Ch32). A party that descends can bargain for the last truth of the Means — or the answer to the Quiet's origin — but it costs time the Hunt Clock does not forgive, and it may change the ending.

10. The Wardline That Remembers

The last native wardline before the Threshold, and it knows the party. Every safe-hold they honored, every rule they kept, holds it open one breath longer; every betrayal shutters it. If a community loved them, a ward-keeper waits here, ready to build the once-only ward-circle the Means requires (Ch27) — the place a kill can be made to stay dead.

11. The Threshold

The sealed door they came in by, exactly as they left it. Reopening it is the campaign's last hard choice — *escape* through it, or turn and spend the Means on the *kill* (Ch16). The Quiet arrives as they work. Whatever happens here, happens fast, in the dark, with the whole country holding its breath.

The Quiet at the Threshold

The Quiet's behaviour at the end — the lure, the unleashed hunt, and the gated kill — is detailed in Ch16 (*The Long Dark and the Threshold*). In short: it offers before it attacks, wearing the dead and the way out; holding to what is true is what gets the party through; and a kill is possible only at 9th level or higher with the full Means, which drags it down to something a level-10 party can end.

The Endings

The crossing ends one of three ways — **Escape**, **Kill**, or **Become** — all detailed in Ch16, and all left open for what comes after. Nothing in the Gloamreach is ever quite finished.

Warden Guidance

The crossing should be frightening because it knows the campaign. Bring back choices, names, lies, saved natives, abandoned ones, unpaid debts, and old kindnesses — and the dead the party made along the way, wearing every face they failed. The final dungeon is not a place the party visit. It is the campaign, and the dark, looking back at them.

Chapter 29: Bureau Domain Response Annex - Keyed Rooms

Bureau Domain Response Annex - Keyed Rooms

A Bureau is a wall people build after learning that prayer alone does not stop teeth. - Commander Park Jae-won

Overview

The **Bureau Domain Response Annex** is the material-side operations base outside the S-Rank Rift. It is not the center of the campaign. It is the last clean line before the Gloamreach.

Use the Annex as a briefing hub, medical station, research site, faction-pressure point, and reminder that the modern world still exists beyond the threshold. The Annex should feel professional, exhausted, underinformed, and one bad report away from panic.

Read aloud: Floodlights, generators, the smell of coffee and antiseptic and ozone. It is loud with the ordinary — radios, boots, a medic arguing for more plasma — and every face turns, just slightly, toward the Rift, the way people stand near a fire they are not sure is contained. This is the last place your AFA tells the simple truth. Past the threshold, it only tells you what the Gloamreach wants you to read.

Room 1 - Barricade Lobby and Sparrow Shrine

Floodlights, concrete barriers, scanners, and a line of wounded civilians waiting behind plastic sheeting. In one corner, someone has placed a small sun-bronze sparrow under a cracked glass dome.

Services:

- Ascendant clearance check-in.
- Updated Rift Interior warnings.
- Bureau Emergency Bulletin handout.
- One small shrine blessing per campaign: a character who leaves a sincere token may reroll one failed save against a Gloamreach-touched effect.

Room 2 - Relay and Dispatch

Twelve monitors show shifting telemetry from the Gloamreach. The maps do not agree. Some messages arrive before they were sent.

Services:

- Send one material-side message per day while the Annex remains functional.
- Review missing-team telemetry.
- Reconstruct broken transmissions from Strike Team Seven.

Investigation: DC 15 Investigation reveals that at least one response team reported hearing a voice call their team's call-sign from inside the Gloamreach — before anyone had broadcast it.

Room 3 - Briefing Hall

Whiteboards, projected maps, coffee rings, and hand-drawn roads copied from survivor testimony. Commander Park briefs the party here.

Services:

- Mission assignments.
- Reputation updates.
- Tactical debriefs.
- Training drills at Allied Bureau reputation.

Room 4 - Armory

A reinforced vault of Bureau gear. Nothing here is glamorous. Everything here is useful.

Services:

- Mana rations, glow rods, smoke grenades, first-aid kits.
- Standard weapons and tactical armor.
- One rare-or-lower requisition at Allied reputation.

Blackwood Hook: a locked footlocker may contain pre-threshold Relic evidence — a piece of the Means that surfaced on the material side before anyone ever went in.

Room 5 - Evidence Locker and Anomaly Vault

Confiscated cores, cult pamphlets, failed Relics, sealed tissue samples, and a cold workbench where Dr. Hayashi writes the reports no one wants to read.

Services:

- Core appraisal.
- Relic analysis.
- Gloamreach research.
- Autopsy reports from Gloamreach-touched creatures.

Hayashi can provide the party with the **Research Brief: The Unclearable Interior** handout at Trusted reputation.

Room 6 - Morgue and Echo Room

Twelve drawers. Too many occupied. Behind an unmarked door, the Echo Room preserves fragments of last memories in mana-saline.

Use this room to show the cost of the Gloamreach's appetite. It can surface final words the dark has kept from those it took, confirm Quiet-Marked symptoms, or plant the Quiet's bait — the first hint of how perfectly it wears the dead.

Room 7 - Commander Park's Office

A quiet glass-walled office facing the Rift floodlights. Park keeps old team photos, unsent letters, and political orders he does not intend to obey if civilians are at stake.

Services:

- Bureau commendations.
- Council leverage at Allied reputation.
- Confession scenes once the party proves they can handle ugly truths.

Room 8 - Holding Cells

Three reinforced cells for cult prisoners, Domain-touched civilians, and people the Bureau cannot classify cleanly.

Use this room to complicate the party's morality. A prisoner may be dangerous, innocent, infected, lying, terrified, or all of those at once.

Room 9 - Relic Exam Room

Professor Lun studies Relics, Sigils, and the resonance of deep-Gloamreach things here. He is not a god, prophet, or secret villain. He is an expert who knows enough to be afraid.

Services:

- Relic identification.
- Sigil appraisal.
- Rune decoding.
- Means-resonance testing.

Room 10 - Roof Heliport and Drone Pad

The roof carries drones, VTOL craft, storm tarps, and the constant vibration of the S-Rank Rift. It is used for rapid cordon movement, emergency extraction near the threshold, and the last material-side relay before the party cross into the Gloamreach.

Bureau Reputation Milestones

Reputation	Unlock
Neutral	Basic services, no free gear beyond emergency kit.
Friendly	Mana rations, Hayashi's briefing, limited safe rest.
Trusted	Relic analysis, Park's private files, special requisitions.
Allied	Council leverage, rare gear, final-operation support.

Warden Guidance

The Annex is safety with a countdown. Keep it useful, but never let it feel permanent. Every return from the Gloamreach should show more strain: more wounded, worse maps, fewer drones, quieter staff, and a

Rift that looks a little more like a mouth.

Chapter 30: Vermillion Outpost - Keyed Rooms

Vermillion Outpost - Keyed Rooms

| *Survive first. Obey later. - Vermillion Guild field motto*

Overview

The **Vermillion Outpost** is a black-market shelter inside the Gloamreach. It exists because Vermillion crossed early, moved fast, bribed the right people, and accepted costs the Bureau would still be debating. The outpost is warm, loud, practical, morally stained, and full of people who owe someone something.

Room 1 - Bazaar Front

Crates, lanterns, tarps, field stoves, core scales, and people arguing over salvage rights. Rat-King Ji brokers information here.

Services:

- Buy and sell Anomaly cores.
- Purchase illegal consumables.
- Trade rumors about roads, settlements, and where the Means might be found.

Room 2 - Orin's Chamber

A plain room with maps, tea, and a weapon Orin rarely touches. He knows the Bureau is necessary. He also knows it is often too slow.

Services:

- Guild induction.
- Faction arbitration.
- Hard-won notes on the worn dead and how the Quiet hunts, at Trusted reputation.

Room 3 - Black Market

A mana-muffled back room. The broker has no name and changes masks every time the party visits.

Services:

- Gray-market gear.
- Restricted Runes.
- Identity laundering.
- False travel papers for settlements that turn away strangers.

Room 4 - Tattoo Parlour

Bright's ink parlor turns scars, songs, and mana into functional tattoos. The work is beautiful because beauty is one of the few things the Gloamreach does not get to take for free.

Services:

- Canonical tattoos.
- Tattoo voucher redemption.
- Tattoo removal at high cost.

Room 5 - Sigil Parlour

Sigilmaster Baek engraves weapons, armor, and accessories. He works slowly, and nothing he makes is casual.

Services:

- Weapon sigils.
- Armor sigils.
- Accessory sigils.
- Legendary-tier work only at Allied reputation.

Room 6 - Field Kitchen

Food is power inside the Gloamreach. A hot meal grants 1d4 temporary HP for one hour, but food has to come from somewhere.

Warden pressure: if the party eats free too often, show who goes without.

Room 7 - Clinic and Backroom Surgery

Mother Rust treats the wounded. She is kind until kindness becomes inefficient. Her clinic can save people the Bureau would classify as lost causes.

Services:

- Healing.
- Condition treatment.
- Illegal augmentation.
- Trauma recovery scenes.

Room 8 - Bounty Board

Bounties include missing teams, dangerous crossings, predators of the wilds, settlement relief, Means clues, and Awoko ritual sites.

Room 9 - Smuggler Gate

A hidden exit that does not always open to the same place. Vermillion uses it to move goods around the worn dead and the open ground. Each use risks the dark noticing.

Room 10 - The Quiet Room

A warded room where no one bargains, recruits, sells, or threatens. It exists because Orin believes people need one place where survival is not being monetized.

Use this room for character scenes, grief, confession, and hard choices.

Vermillion Reputation Milestones

Reputation	Unlock
Neutral	Basic trade.
Friendly	Better prices, rumor access, limited shelter.
Trusted	Black-market services, tattoos, special bounties.
Allied	Orin's direct support, outpost defenders in the finale, deep intelligence on the Means and the Quiet.

Warden Guidance

Vermillion should never be purely heroic or purely criminal. They are what happens when people decide bureaucracy is too slow and morality is too expensive. Make their help real. Make the bill real too.

Markets, Merchants & Goods

Markets, Merchants & Goods

Everything in the Gloamreach is for sale — but not everywhere, and never all in one place. The dark keeps its people dependent on one another.

Sourcing (use the compendium, not invented one-offs)

Every item, weapon, Sigil, Rune, Relic, tattoo, and mount comes from the **canonical RA compendium**. Match each sale to a real entry of the right rank/rarity:

- **Weapons & armor:** `items-base-equipment.ts` (Dagger, Spear, Mace, Shortbow; Leather, Chain Shirt, Plate, Shield).
- **Gear & consumables:** `items.ts`, `items-part1.ts` — `items-part9.ts`.
- **Sigils:** `sigils.ts` (Sigil of the Aegis, of the Frost-Ward, of the Void-Walker).
- **Runes:** `runes/` by rank D–S (see Ch34).
- **Relics & Artifacts:** `relics-comprehensive.ts`, `artifacts.ts` (a salvaged Relic-blade, the Bloodthirsty Greatsword).
- **Tattoos:** `tattoos.ts` (Ascendant's Acuity, Bone-Weave Tapestry; a cursed deep-Gloamreach tattoo only by dark bargain).
- **Mounts & vehicles:** `vehicles.ts` (riding / war / draft beasts; see Native Mounts).

Merchants carry SELECT, distinct stock

No merchant sells everything, and no two sell the same things. Each carries a **small, curated stock logical to their trade and their location**. Common goods are everywhere; specialised goods cluster where their maker is.

Merchant · Location	Trade	Carries (a handful, not a catalogue)	Does NOT carry
Maven Holt · Covered Market	General goods	Rope, lamp-Essence, rations, bedrolls, tools, common kit	Weapons, Relics, Sigils
Grist · Vermillion Outpost	Arms-dealer	A few weapons + light armor, Essence-cells, 1–2 salvaged Relic-arms	Consumables, tattoos, mounts
Sigilmaster Baek · Outpost	Sigils	3–4 Sigils by rank (Aegis, Frost-Ward; restricted: Void-Walker)	Anything not a Sigil
Bright · Outpost	Tattooist	Voice-inked tattoos (Ascendant's Acuity, Bone-Weave Tapestry)	Gear, weapons, mounts
Old Vell · Outpost	Appraiser / fence	Identifies & brokers Relics/Artifacts the party <i>brings</i> ; rarely one unique Relic	A standing catalogue (deals case by case)
Quill · Outpost / Market	Memory-broker	A few skill- and memory-cores (given, never stolen)	Physical gear

Merchant · Location	Trade	Carries (a handful, not a catalogue)	Does NOT carry
Tallow · market / roads	Charm-seller	Cheap wards & charms; one genuine ward-charm that turns the worn dead, if earned	Weapons, mounts
Herbalist Wen · settlements	Apothecary	Healing draughts, antitoxins, Rift-Rot cures	Weapons, Relics, Sigils
The Stablekeeper · settlements/Outpost	Mounts	Native riding & draft beasts; 1 salvaged Bureau mount	Anything you can't saddle
Coin-Mother Esha · Covered Market	Money-changer	No goods — converts cores/favours/oaths, brokers big Relic sales	—

Stock varies by area

- **Warded communities** — sparse and basic: Holt-tier kit, Wen's remedies, a stablekeeper's beast. No contraband; the natives' rules are strict.
- **The Vermillion Outpost** — the deep market: arms, Sigils, tattoos, salvage, forged papers, the things no settlement dares shelve.
- **The Covered Market** — variety by stall under the no-violence bell: a little of everything, nothing in depth, a secret owed per stall per week.
- **The roads** — Tallow, Sile, Captain Doe, and whatever the open roads allow through. Prices rise with desperation.

Native Mounts & Vehicles

The Gloamreach's mounts are not Bureau stock; they are **Gloamreach-bred beasts** the natives raise and the Vermillion salvage — reskin the `vehicles.ts` riding/war/draft profiles as pale road-horses that do not spook at bells, six-legged warren-beasts, and draft things bred to haul cargo through the dark. A few **salvaged Bureau mounts** (the handful that came through with the first wave) turn up at the Outpost, worth more for the story than the speed. The open roads can lengthen against a mount as easily as a walker: a fast beast buys distance, not safety.

Currency

Essence cores are common coin; favours, oaths, and memories are the uncommon ones. Bureau credits are worthless inside the Gloamreach. **Provenance is optional flavour** — some goods are honest native craft or salvage; some carry a history worth a scene. Use it when it sharpens the moment, not on every sale.

The Old Roads

The Old Roads

The roads are the fastest way through the Gloamreach, and the most exposed. Out here, the dark has room. - Old Man Crane

Rank and Role

Rank: Varies — the roads are everywhere. **Recommended Level:** Any; travel horror that scales with the act. **Campaign Role:** The connective tissue of the Gloamreach — the open ground between safeholds, where the party are most exposed to the hunt.

Overview

The old native roads, causeways, and rail-cuts link the warded communities, and the natives walk them only by grey daylight, in silence, and never alone. Between the wardlines there is nothing to keep the dark off: open ground, long sightlines, and every footfall carrying. Distance itself is unreliable out here — the way lengthens for the loud and the hunted, landmarks repeat, and the dark has been known to fold a morning's walk into a night that does not end. Travel is never neutral. It is the time the party spend outside the only safety the Gloamreach offers.

Read aloud: The milestones are wrong. You passed that leaning one an hour ago — the same crack, the same moss, the same pale scratch low on the stone that might be a name. The grey light has not moved. Somewhere behind you, something keeps your pace exactly: not closer, not falling back, just there, the way a held breath is there.

How the Roads Work

- **The open ground.** Off the wardlines there is no safety, only cover and the lack of it. Light and noise carry for miles; the worn dead watch the verges; the Hunt Clock fills faster the longer the party are exposed.
- **The long way.** The roads lengthen against the loud, the lit, and the hunted. A party that travels silent and dark covers ground; one that does not finds the same milestone three times, and the daylight gone.
- **Names on the stones.** The oldest stretches are scratched with names — the taken, and sometimes, freshly, the party's own. A name read aloud on the road is a name given to the dark (see Quiet-Marked).
- **Crossing alone.** Splitting up on the roads is how the dark separates a party for the worn dead. In the deep stretches it does this on purpose; charting the Mana Vein nodes (Ch32) can hold a party together through the worst of it.

Travel Hazards

Roll on **Table A — The Old Roads** (Ch35) when the party travel between regions, travel loud or lit, carry a piece of the Means openly, or linger too long in the open. The roads belong to the hunt; the dark notices motion, noise, light, and Essence.

Warden Guidance

The roads are how the Gloamreach stays dangerous even between places. Make travel a scene, not a transition — the time the party are most exposed, and most alone. The refrain, repeated until the players dread it: *get behind a wardline before the clock fills*.

Chapter 31: The Warded Communities - Keyed Locations

The Warded Communities - Keyed Locations

Every wall here is a wardline, every rule a grave someone dug learning it. We do not keep the dark out because we are brave. We keep it out because we remember.

Overview

The Gloamreach is a populated country. Its communities are not ruins and not waystations — they are the homes of the Gloamreach's **native inhabitants**, people born here who have never known a world without the dark waiting outside the wards. They survive by rules paid for in generations of the dead, and none of them are safe for free. The horror of a warded community is not that it is monstrous; it is that it is *ordinary* — children, markets, clinics, gossip, bells — running on a price paid in memory, years, secrets, and the occasional neighbour given quietly to the dark so the rest can sleep.

Read aloud: The road tops a rise and there it is: lamplight, woodsmoke, a dog barking, a queue outside a clinic, washing on a line. It looks, for one aching second, like somewhere people simply live. Then you notice the wardmarks chalked fresh above every door, the empty chair set at every table for someone the dark already took, and the way everyone goes quiet, fast, when the grey light starts to fail.

Each community below keeps a **rule, a lie, a cost, and a reckoning** — the bargain that has let it survive the Gloamreach. The party will be tempted to free them all. Some of these places have lasted precisely because no one yet tried.

Location 1 - Mother Rust's Outreach Post

A clinic built in the second floor of a leaning tenement that should not still be standing. Mother Rust treats the sick, the Rift-touched, and those the Bureau would classify as unrecoverable.

The Rule: Mercy must be paid forward. The Lie: Care is free. The Cost: Medicine, cores, favors, or silence. If It Breaks: The clinic starts deciding who is worth saving.

Services:

- Treat Rift-Rot and minor Gloamreach conditions.
- Civilian aftercare.
- Rumors about Awoko recruiters.
- Recovery scenes after major horror encounters.

If Ms. Park survived Day Zero, she may be here under Mother Rust's care.

Location 2 - The Covered Market

A neutral market under patched canvas and rusted tin. Vermillion runners, settlement traders, smugglers, cult watchers, and now the strangers who came in through the door all pass through.

The Rule: No violence while the bell hangs. The Lie: Neutrality protects everyone. The Cost: One secret per stall per week. If It Breaks: The bell falls, and every unpaid secret becomes public.

Services:

- Rumors.
- Food.
- Salvage.
- Stolen maps.
- Questionable guides.

Location 3 - The Hamlet That Never Says No

A village where every door wears a fresh chalk ward. The residents speak softly and never, ever say a flat "no" aloud after the lamps are lit — because the dark listens for it.

The Rule: No one says "no" aloud once the lamps are lit. The Lie: Courtesy keeps them safe. The Cost: One night a week, a household leaves a door unbarred, and does not ask what comes in. If It Breaks: The worn dead walk in wearing the face of whoever said no.

Use this community to teach the danger of false safety.

Location 4 - The Bellweather School

A schoolhouse converted into a shelter. Children draw places they have never seen. The bell rings when the dark shifts.

The Rule: Children may not be taken if someone else answers the bell. The Lie: The adults always know who should answer. The Cost: Volunteers stand at the road when the bell rings. If It Breaks: The road chooses instead.

Mika the Kid can appear here. Her drawings foreshadow the deep dark, the worn dead, and the pieces of the Means.

Location 5 - Old Man Crane's Teahouse

A quiet teahouse that appears at crossroads. It is always the same room, no matter where the door stands.

The Rule: Tea must be finished before violence. The Lie: Crane is only an old man. The Cost: A true story from each guest. If It Breaks: The story repeats later with worse actors.

Old Man Crane can teach the party a true thing about the Quiet — how it might be held, or where its truth lies — but his knowledge costs more than technique.

Location 6 - The Empty Mill Village

A settlement whose residents leave food on every table and sleep in locked barns. No one will explain why.

The Rule: The mill must turn by moonrise. The Lie: Grain is what the mill grinds. The Cost: Names written on husks and fed into the stones. If It Breaks: The mill grinds bodies instead.

This is an ideal location for a Means clue or a worn-dead arrival.

Settlement-Wide Systems

Civilian Trust

Track how many communities the party protect, exploit, abandon, or free. Civilian trust affects final-act support, rumors, safe rests, and whether common people will stand with the party at the end — or shutter their wards against them.

Shrines

Small shrines appear throughout settlements — old folk-altars to powers that have not answered in a very long time. Some are sincere. Some are bait.

- A shrine of comfort — one reroll against fear or despair.
- A shrine kept by the watchful dead — advantage on one trial or combat-opening save.
- A shrine grown through with living rot — temporary HP, and a mutation risk.
- A shrine of remembrance — advantage on a Sense check involving memory or truth.
- A shrine that asks too little — never free. Always a trap, a rot, or a mercy with teeth.

Chapter 32: Mana Vein Network and the Third Node

Mana Vein Network and the Third Node

A Rift Interior is not only a place. It is a pressure system with laws pretending to be weather. - Dr. Serin Hayashi

Overview

The Gloamreach is threaded with Mana Veins: deep channels of Essence pressure that run under the roads, the settlements, and the deep places. Because the Quiet hunts by Essence, the veins are where its attention pools and the worn dead thicken — and also, Professor Lun believes, where it can be made *deaf*. Map enough nodes, she argues, and a stretch of the Gloamreach could be tuned to drown out sound and power entirely: silent enough to cross unheard, or even silent enough to hold the Quiet still.

The veins run through the whole Gloamreach, but the deep nodes lie in its worst places.

Node 1 - The Rusted Hull

A dry-docked ship half-buried in black soil far from any sea. A vein pulses beneath the keel.

Challenge: Install a sensor while avoiding a Beast swarm feeding on overflow Essence. Reward: Access to one movement-related Sigil or a road shortcut.

Node 2 - The Silent Depot

A cavernous native sorting-hall where the people once gathered whatever the veins carried up from below. It stands empty now but for the distant counting of the Hollow Way and a voice, in no throat, naming cargoes long since lost. A vein runs through the old reckoning-room.

Challenge: Umbral scouts guard the vein-locks. Reward: One B-Rank Rune or a clue toward the Means — a way to read where the Quiet goes deaf.

Node 3 - The Glass Sub-Basement

A buried financial archive beneath the Ashen Counting-House. It contains the deepest active vein outside the lightless deep.

SB-1 - Security Checkpoint

Old native checkpoint-wards stand beside gear the Vermillion stripped from somewhere far deeper and never came back for. The wards test for the right silence, not the right face — they pass anyone who comes through quiet and dark, and wail at anyone who does not.

SB-2 - Vein Engine

A glass cylinder contains a pulsing channel of Essence. Installing Lun's sensor requires a DC 15 Intelligence check. On failure, the sensor works, but the spike of Essence rings out through the vein — fill the Hunt Clock, and the Quiet now knows someone is down here.

SB-3 - The Precedent Echo

Something old stirs in the deepest vein — the Old Power Below — and asks the party what silence is worth to them. Their answer determines whether the node yields a stretch of safe silence, a way to mask their own Essence, or a hard first truth about what the Quiet is.

What the Veins Buy

If the party charts and tunes all three nodes, they have made a piece of the Gloamreach go *quiet* — a real advantage for the final crossing and, if they attempt it, the gated kill. Choose one:

1. **A silent corridor.** One stretch of the final approach can be crossed with the Hunt Clock frozen — the veins drink the party's noise and Essence, so the Quiet cannot hear them coming.
2. **Masked power.** Once during the finale, the party may spend Essence without advancing the Hunt Clock; the veins swallow the sound of it.
3. **The deaf place.** The party can force the Quiet into a node's dead-silent heart for one scene, where it hunts blind — the single best place to make the one stand that could end it (a piece of the Means; see *The Means to End It*).

Warden Guidance

Mana Veins should not feel like power generators. They are nerves. When the party touches one, the dark feels it.

Chapter 33: The Awoko Sanctum

The Awoko Sanctum

Overview

The Awoko Sanctum hides in a grief-dense fold of the Gloamreach where four rooms share one impossible floor plan — a chapel, a clinic, a theatre, and an execution room, all the same room, depending on why you came. Here beauty is made unbearable and comfort is twisted into bait. The Awoko are natives of the Gloamreach who found the one thing the dark could never quite take by force — grief, freely given — and built a faith on it. They do not see themselves as villains, and they are not lying about the comfort they offer. That is exactly what makes them dangerous.

Read aloud: Someone is singing, low and close — a song you half-remember in a voice you have lost. The air is warm with candlelight and the smell of clean linen, and a gentle hand finds your shoulder before you see whose it is. "You've carried that a long way," the voice says, meaning the grief you did not know showed. "You don't have to. Not here." Every word is true. That is the trap.

They preach that the Quiet is proof you do not have to stay prey — that a thing in this country once climbed out of being hunted and became the hunter — and their leader means to follow it, by feeding the Quiet enough grief and enough dead that it remakes her into something it will never touch.

Core Truth

The Hollow Mother does not want to hide from the Quiet, and she does not want to kill it. She wants to *become* something like it — and she is willing to feed it her whole flock to get there.

What This Place Does

Dread: Grief does not stay private here. The Sanctum gathers it, concentrates it, and turns it into something with weight and will — and the more you bring, the more it loves you. **The Lure:** To be *understood*. The cult meets the grieving exactly where they hurt and offers to share the weight, to make sure the lost are never forgotten. **The Cost:** It feeds on what it collects — loss, confession, blood, obedience — and gives belonging in their place, until the grief is all that is left of you. **If You Linger:** The grieving stop being mourners and become fuel, wept dry and fed to whatever the Hollow Mother is becoming.

Key Areas

S-1 - Nave of Remembered Names

Thousands of names hang from threads. Some are dead. Some are alive. Some belong to the party, if they have been careless with their names.

S-2 - Confession Chamber

Initiates confess grief into speaking tubes. The grief is stored, refined, and used to power rituals.

S-3 - Clinic of Gentle Hands

The cult offers real comfort here. Do not make it fake. The danger is that the comfort is being weaponized.

S-4 - Choir Pit

Idol-class cultists sing grief into a shape the dark will answer. Interrupting the choir can scatter the worn dead the song has drawn in close, or weaken the Hollow Mother's ritual.

S-5 - Sister Veil's Laboratory

Sister Veil knows the ritual math is wrong. She can defect if shown evidence that the Hollow Mother intends to use the cult as fuel.

S-6 - The Ritual of Becoming

A circular chamber with seven candle-stations, each burning with grief-tallow. If completed, the ritual offers the Hollow Mother to the Quiet on an altar of the community's grief — a bid to be remade into a new thing that hunts, instead of one more thing that is hunted.

Major NPCs

The Hollow Mother

Charismatic, grieving, brilliant, and predatory. She speaks softly. She never says die when become will do.

Sister Veil

Ritualist and possible defector. She is guilty, but not unreachable.

Acolyte Mara

A young initiate who can become a human face for the cult's victims.

Ritual Disruption

The party can disrupt the ritual by:

1. Destroying one correct candle-station.
2. Convincing Sister Veil to corrupt the final chant.
3. Removing the stored grief from the Confession Chamber.
4. Presenting proof that the Hollow Mother intends to feed them all to the dark, not free them.

The Sanctum Raid

When the Sanctum turns hostile, the fight is the Choir, the ritual, and the Hollow Mother — not a single boss. Reskin a **B-Rank controller Anomaly from the compendium bestiary** (Appendix C) as the **Choir's grief-engine** (the thing the singing actually powers), and run the Hollow Mother as a near-non-combatant who would far rather the party *understood* than fought.

The Law in play: *grief may be converted into authority.* Every loss the party has carried into the Domain — a named dead, a memory-core eaten in the Orchard, an oath broken at the Bastion — is fuel the Sanctum can spend against them; a party that has grieved openly here arms the room. Starve the engine by denying the cult the party's grief: refuse the comfort, withhold true names, or empty the Confession Chamber before the Choir can draw on it.

Scaling (Levels 1-10): B-Rank for a level 7-9 party; if the Ritual of Becoming is near completion, raise it to A-Rank and let the Hollow Mother spend the Sanctum's stored grief as legendary actions.

Exit tone (read aloud): Outside again, the song does not follow — but for the rest of the campaign, the first kind voice in any safe room will sound, for just a moment, like hers, and the party will have to decide, every time, whether to let it comfort them.

Warden Guidance

The Awoko should be horrifying because they understand pain and exploit it with tenderness. Push the dread, not caricature. Their kindness should make the party angrier, not less afraid.

Chapter 34: Runes Cross-Reference

Runes Cross-Reference

| *A rune is a spell that stopped moving. That is not a metaphor. - Professor Lun*

Using This Chapter

Runes in *Run Silent* come from canonical compendium sources. This chapter does not restate them. It maps where rune tiers appear inside the Gloamreach so the Warden can prep rewards without drifting from core canon.

Canonical sources:

- `runes/spell-rank-d.ts`
- `runes/spell-rank-c.ts`
- `runes/spell-rank-b.ts`
- `runes/spell-rank-a.ts`
- `runes/spell-rank-s.ts`
- `runes/technique-techniques.ts`
- `runes/power-powers.ts`

Rune Drop Schedule

Tier	Gloamreach Source	Canonical Source
D	The Hollow Way, Drowned Ledgerfen, early road encounters	<code>runes/spell-rank-d.ts</code>
C	Fungal Depths, Remembering Orchard, Ashen Counting-House	<code>runes/spell-rank-c.ts</code>
B	Sunken Tunnels, Bastion Golemfall, Mana Vein Node rewards	<code>runes/spell-rank-b.ts</code>
A	Obsidian Spire, the Deep Places, the final crossing, Hayashi research trade	<code>runes/spell-rank-a.ts</code>
S	Recovered from the place the Quiet fell, or the deepest dark, after the finale	<code>runes/spell-rank-s.ts</code>
Technique	Vermillion training, Orin's trials, Spire trials	<code>runes/technique-techniques.ts</code>
Power	Mana Vein network, Old Power Below bargains, Means awakenings	<code>runes/power-powers.ts</code>

Faction Rune Sources

Bureau

Dr. Hayashi and Professor Lun can identify or stabilize runes. Bureau access favors safety, documentation, and legal ownership.

Vermillion

Vermillion can sell restricted runes, apply dangerous modifications, and ignore Bureau paperwork. The price is money, favor, or leverage.

Awoko

The Awoko collect runes as grief-offerings. A Sanctum raid should yield at least one rune appropriate to the party's level, plus evidence of how the cult weaponizes loss.

The Old Power Below

The Old Power Below can produce power-runes through bargain, sacrifice, or a truth the dark buried. These should be strong but costly. No bargain should feel random.

Forbidden Runes

The Bureau restricts runes tied to void, necrotic authority, compelled obedience, identity rewriting, or interference with the deep Gloamreach. Possession creates Bureau risk, but these runes may be exactly what the party needs against the Quiet.

Rune Recovery After the Campaign

After the finale — escape, kill, or become — the deepest places may give up as many as three S-tier runes. Choose runes that reflect the party's ending, not only their combat builds.

Chapter 35: Gloamreach Random Encounter Tables

Gloamreach Random Encounter Tables

Every road here is a question. Most of them are traps. - Rat-King Ji

Using These Tables

Roll when the party travels between major Gloamreach regions, travels loud or lit, carries a piece of the Means openly, rests in the open, or spends too long debating on exposed ground.

These encounters should not feel random in-world. The Quiet notices motion, noise, light, and the use of Essence.

Table A - The Old Roads

d20	Encounter
1-2	The road goes on longer than it should. Lose time, food, or daylight, and the dark gets a turn.
3-4	A still figure stands at the verge, the party's names already carved in the stone beside it in a hand none of them used.
5	A voice from off the road calls a name one of the party has lost.
6	A community bell tolls once, far off, then silence. Someone behind a wardline did not make it.
7	The party finds a broken Bureau marker from a team that has not entered yet.
8	Vermillion courier offers a shortcut for a price.
9	Awoko recruiter approaches the most grief-marked character.
10	Umbral Scout watches from a milestone. It flees if pursued.
11	Roadside shrine offers a small mercy with unclear ownership.
12	Mika's drawing appears nailed to a tree. It depicts the next danger.
13	A corpse asks for directions, in a voice someone knows. It is patient.
14	Supplies spoil unless shared — the dark is hungrier where the living hoard.
15	A carried piece of the Means grows cold and pulls toward something deep.
16	Old Man Crane is sitting at a tea table in the road. He does not explain how.
17	The Quiet whispers. DC 14 Sense save or psychic strain and a lure in a voice you know.
18	Worn-dead sign. Fresh drag-marks, and footprints that stop, facing the way you came.
19	A safe-looking shelter, its door already open, and nothing inside that is wrong.
20	The worn dead converge — a lure, a wrong shape, the cold of the Quiet behind them. Run or hide; do not fight in the open.

Table B - The Warded Communities

d20	Encounter
1-2	A family asks the party to shelter someone the Quiet has marked.
3-4	A ward-keeper offers shelter — but the community's rules come with it, and they are absolute.
5	A child draws a place the party has not visited.
6	Villagers deny a disappearance everyone clearly remembers.
7	Awoko comfort-worker offers real aid and subtle recruitment.
8	Vermillion scout buys settlement secrets for supplies.
9	Bureau survivor begs extraction from the Gloamreach.
10	The community's hard bargain is revealed — what they do to keep the dark out. It is worse than rumored.
11	A worn-dead wanders in wearing a villager's face, and no one is sure whose.
12	A ward has been defaced with creeping rot.
13	Someone recognizes a Quiet-Marked PC. They want them gone before dark.
14	A feast begins. Refusing is rude. Accepting is dangerous.
15	Missing person returns with no shadow.
16	A local rule makes no sense to outsiders. The party must keep it or risk the dark.
17	A Means clue hidden in a folk song, a prayer, or a name carved where it should not be.
18	A community asks the party to put down someone the Quiet has already half-taken.
19	Hollow Mother sermon overheard. She promises the grieving they can stop being prey.
20	The worn dead come for the community, not the party — and the wards may not hold.

Table C - Wilds and Ruins

d20	Encounter
1-2	Predator tracks circle the party's camp from the future.
3-4	Adaptive beasts use a tactic the party used last session.
5	The dark deepens early after someone makes too much noise.
6	Ruined bastion patrol asks the party for an oath.
7	Fungal secret grows a mouth and repeats a confession.
8	Orchard fruit offers a memory. Eating it grants a clue and a cost.
9	Drowned voice asks to be named.
10	Broken road leads to the same milestone three times.
11	Anomaly swarm, rank appropriate.
12	Umbral Warrior patrol.
13	Awoko ritual site, currently unattended.

d20	Encounter
14	Vermillion salvage crew under attack.
15	Mana Vein flare. Gain one Rift Favor, then roll a complication.
16	A piece of the Means resonates, pointing underground.
17	The Old Power Below speaks through a cracked bell.
18	Silent battlefield of empty armor.
19	Moment of stillness. Safe short rest if no one speaks a true name aloud.
20	For a heartbeat the Quiet's full attention turns on the party, closer than it should be.

Ambient Events

Roll once per long rest outside protected shelter.

d6	Event
1	The dark presses close. DC 14 Sense save or dreams impose psychic strain.
2	Food changes flavor to ash, blood, flowers, or hospital antiseptic.
3	A keepsake of someone they lost appears in someone's pack.
4	A dead NPC speaks in a dream and offers true information.
5	The road outside has moved.
6	Small mercy. Regain 1 Rift Favor, but the Warden notes who granted it.

Chapter 36: The Hunt Escalates - Pacing the Persecution

The Hunt Escalates

Time in the Gloamreach is not measured in days. It is measured in how close the Quiet has come, and how much of you is left.

Overview

There is no countdown to a Rift Break and no Domain pressing toward the material world. The campaign escalates as **persecution** — the Quiet grows bolder, the safe-holds grow fewer, the worn dead thicken, and the party's own fraying (Dread) and exhaustion mount — across four acts spanning Levels 1-10. Pace it by the **Hunt Clock** (see Running This Horror) and by what the party has done, never by a calendar.

Use this as a pacing instrument. Advance the pressure when the party linger, rest carelessly, live loud, or push deeper; ease it, briefly, when they reach a true safe-hold or earn a native's trust.

Act I — First Contact (Levels 1-3)

The slow wrong. The threshold seals, the AFA begins to lie, comms die, and the party meet their first natives — and learn, badly, that there are *rules*.

- The Quiet is felt, never seen: a silence where there should be sound, a wrong shape on a ridgeline.
- The first **taking** happens here — ideally an NPC, so the party learn what they face without losing one of their own first.
- The lesson lands: **noise, light, and Essence draw it**. The party either learn to run silent or pay.
- Goal: reach the first warded safe-hold alive, and begin to understand the wards.

Act II — The Hunt (Levels 4-6)

The party know now that they are prey. The Quiet hunts in earnest, mostly through the **worn dead** (the Worn, the Caller, the Wrong Shape), and trust begins to fray.

- The Hunt Clock fills faster; persecution set-pieces — stalk, hide, flee — become routine.
- The first time the Quiet **wears a face the party knows** — a lost teammate, a trusted native — Dread spikes and trust cracks.
- Safe-holds demand the party live by the rules; breaking one, even in ignorance, has consequences the whole community pays.
- Goal: survive the first time the Quiet takes one of *them*, and keep moving.

Act III — The Long Dark (Levels 7-9)

Desperate survival, and the first real understanding. The party push into the deeper Gloamreach, where the worn dead thicken into **the Hollowed** and the safe-holds fail.

- The party begin learning **true things** about the Quiet (see What the Natives Know and The Means to End It) — and the first hint that it might, in theory, be ended.
- Resources thin; the failing AFA gives nothing true; the dark is constant.
- Essence becomes nearly suicidal to use this deep; the party live or die on silence and the rules.
- Goal: learn enough to find a way out — or the first piece of the Means.

Act IV — Threshold (Levels 9-10)

The climax. The party have a way out, a desperate plan to end the Quiet, or both — and the Quiet knows it.

- The Hunt is total; the Quiet stops being patient.
- The party run for the threshold to escape, or commit to the gated kill (L9+ and the Means assembled; see The Means to End It and the Threshold chapter).
- Either way it costs. Someone may not make it out. The natives who helped them cannot leave at all.
- Goal: escape, or put the Quiet down — and live with which.

Advancing the Pressure (when the party stall)

When the party delay, rest carelessly, or live loud, escalate. Choose one:

1. A safe-hold the party relied on falls — a rule broken, a ward failed, the people gone or worn.
2. The Quiet takes someone the party was protecting, and wears them back.
3. The worn dead grow bolder, hunting in daylight and behind wardlines.
4. A native who knew the rules — and the way out — is lost, and the party's map goes dark.
5. The dark itself spreads: more of the Gloamreach becomes exposed ground, fewer places safe.
6. The Quiet shows itself, fully, for a heartbeat — and the next scene's Hunt Clock starts half-full.

Warden Guidance

This is pressure, not a railroad. Its purpose is to keep the party *hunted* — never safe for long, always one rule behind, always aware the Quiet is closer than it was. Clever, quiet, disciplined play should buy time and lives; carelessness should cost them.

Appendix A — Recruitable Allies

Commander Park Jae-won — Bureau Domain Response Commander

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 18 · **HP:** 95 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex

Job: Destroyer

A battle-scarred commander with mana-reinforced prosthetics and a voice trained to stay calm while the map collapses. Park commands the material-side Annex outside the Gloamreach threshold.

Personality. Stern, clipped, protective, and unwilling to confuse protocol with courage once civilians are at risk.

Motivation. Prevent a Rift Break, recover missing teams, and keep Central Command from sacrificing survivors for clean reports.

Key Abilities

- Fortification Aura
- Command Strike
- Hold the Line

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — Commander Park answers to the Bureau chain of command. Earn Bureau Trusted reputation and he fights as a staunch field ally, but he will not abandon his post to join a party or guild.

Quartermaster Lin Mei-hua — Cordon Supply Officer

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 38 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Armory

Job: Technomancer

A meticulous logistics officer who tracks every ration, glow rod, and field dressing with near-religious intensity.

Personality. Anxious, precise, quietly compassionate, and more generous when no one is watching.

Motivation. Keep the Annex supplied long enough for the party to matter.

Key Abilities

- Equipment Maintenance
- Inventory Mastery
- Emergency Fabrication

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — Bureau supply officer. Protect the Annex line and she keeps the party resupplied as an ally, but she serves the Bureau, not a guild.

Sergeant Yoon Hye-jin — Domain Scout Leader

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 52 · **Location:** Patrol routes on the old roads

Job: Stalker

A quiet scout with chalk marks on her gloves and a habit of checking exits even in rooms she has already cleared.

Personality. Pragmatic, watchful, loyal, and economical with words.

Motivation. Find her missing scouts and learn why the old roads keep returning their signals from impossible directions.

Key Abilities

- Shadow Step
- Anomaly Sense
- Precision Strike

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — Bureau scout leader. Resolve the Missing Strike Team and she ranges alongside the party as a Bureau ally, never as a recruit.

Dr. Serin Hayashi — Rift Interior Researcher

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 42 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Evidence Locker

Job: Esper

A brilliant field researcher with ink-stained cuffs, too many notes, and the courage to say that the Gloamreach is law before it is terrain.

Personality. Fast-talking, compassionate, intellectually reckless, and more frightened of bad assumptions than monsters.

Motivation. Prove that the thing inside the Gloamreach cannot be cleared — only survived, or fled.

Key Abilities

- Analyze Weakness
- Aetheric Shield
- Interior Theory

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — Bureau researcher. Protect her work and she becomes a vital ally and quest-giver, but she stays with the Bureau.

Agent Kira Blackwood — Bureau Intelligence Operative

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 58 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Intelligence desk

Job: Stalker

A pale intelligence agent with controlled movements, half-truths, and classified orders involving pre-threshold Relic activity.

Personality. Cold, dry, observant, and capable of empathy she treats as an operational weakness.

Motivation. Complete her mission without letting Central Command turn the Gloamreach's horrors into a weapon.

Key Abilities

- Infiltration
- Dead Drop
- Counter-Intelligence

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — Bureau intelligence operative under standing orders. Complete her quest to turn her into an ally against Central Command, but never a party recruit.

Corporal Deng Wei — Heavy Weapons Specialist

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 48 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Field kitchen

Job: Destroyer

A broad-shouldered gunner and former chef whose field cannon is nearly as large as his guilt.

Personality. Gentle, exhausted, brave when others need him, and ashamed of fear he earned honestly.

Motivation. Stand his ground when the worn dead come for someone he can protect.

Key Abilities

- Suppressing Fire
- Heavy Hitter
- Fortify Position

Recruit. Help Deng survive a nightmare scene and later face the worn dead without mocking his fear.

Comms Officer Reyes — Signal Specialist

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Relay room

Job: Technomancer

A young signal specialist who receives transmissions out of order and keeps answering anyway.

Personality. Fast, anxious, brilliant, and allergic to silence.

Motivation. Decode the Gloamreach's signals and prove the messages from tomorrow are warnings, not hallucinations.

Key Abilities

- Signal Boost
- Decrypt
- Aetheric Jammer

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — Bureau signals officer. She relays intel and fire support as an ally, but she holds the Annex relay, not a guild seat.

Warden-Aspirant Sato Ken — Bureau Recruit

Faction: Bureau Sentinels · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 22 · **Location:** Bureau Domain Response Annex - Barricade lobby

Job: Holy Knight

A terrified recruit in armor that does not fit, carrying more courage than training.

Personality. Earnest, frightened, stubborn, and desperate to be useful.

Motivation. Become worthy of the badge before the Domain teaches him what badges cost.

Key Abilities

- Determination
- Quick Learner
- Inspire

Recruit. He joins if asked, though Park warns the party not to mistake willingness for readiness.

Grist — Arms-Dealer

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 40 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Armoury stall

Job: Technomancer

The Outpost's weapons-fence: salvaged edged steel, Relic-arms the Domain grew teeth into, and Essence-cells for anything that drinks them.

Personality. Cheerful, amoral about buyers, deadly serious about misfires.

Motivation. Arm anyone who can pay, then sleep at night by never selling a curse he hasn't named.

Key Abilities

- Salvaged Arsenal
- Relic-Weapon Lore
- Essence-Cell Supply

Recruit. Return a Relic-weapon that turned on its buyer; he repays it in better steel.

Quill — Memory-Broker

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost / Covered Market

Job: Esper

A trader in memory-cores harvested from the Remembering Orchard, who can sell you a skill, a language, or a stranger's happiest day — at the price of a little of your own.

Personality. Smooth, melancholy, scrupulous about consent in a trade everyone else cheats.

Motivation. Keep the memory-trade honest in a Domain that wants it predatory.

Key Abilities

- Memory Appraisal
- Skill-Core Transfer
- Detects Stolen Memory

Recruit. Recover a stolen memory-core and let him return it instead of selling it.

Captain Doe — Smuggler-Captain

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 46 · **Location:** The roads / Vermillion Outpost

Job: Stalker

Runs contraband — people, Relics, and forbidden Runes — between settlements along roads the Domain has not finished closing.

Personality. Cool, calculating, sentimental about exactly one thing she will never name.

Motivation. Move what the Domain forbids, and get every passenger to the other end breathing.

Key Abilities

- Smuggling Routes
- Hidden Cargo
- Outruns the Worn Dead

Recruit. Help her run a cargo of refugees past a worn-dead picket without paying in names.

Tallow — Charm-Seller

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 24 · **Location:** Covered Market / road camps

Job: Contractor

A peddler of wards, tokens, and anti-Quiet-Marked charms — most of them comforting junk, a precious few of them genuinely real.

Personality. Patter-fast, superstitious in earnest, kinder than the grift suggests.

Motivation. Sell hope by the handful, and slip the real charms to the people who truly need them.

Key Abilities

- Genuine Ward (rare)
- Reads the Marked
- Sells Hope

Recruit. Catch him slipping a real charm to a doomed family, and keep his secret.

Cinder — Deep-Salvage Diver

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 42 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost

Job: Stalker

A native salvager who goes into the places that kill everyone else and comes back with the cores to prove it.

Personality. Reckless, generous, and superstitious about owed favours.

Motivation. Pull enough Essence to buy her crew off the Domain's rolls for good.

Key Abilities

- Hazard Instinct
- Core Extraction
- Holds Her Breath

Recruit. Bring her crew home from a dive gone wrong; she pays her debts in blood, not coin.

Old Vell — Relic-Appraiser

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 36 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Appraisal stall

Job: Technomancer

A half-blind native fence who can tell you exactly what a Relic does, and exactly what it will cost you.

Personality. Dry, patient, and honest about prices and nothing else.

Motivation. Keep the Outpost's stock moving and its worst Relics out of the wrong hands.

Key Abilities

- Relic Lore
- Curse-Sense
- Names a True Price

Recruit. Bring him a Relic no one else can identify; respect his appraisal even when it costs you.

Pip — Apprentice Runner

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 1 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 12 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost / the roads

Job: Stalker

Jax's apprentice — eager, quick, and one bad shortcut away from the worst lesson the road teaches.

Personality. Eager, loyal, and overconfident about the old roads.

Motivation. Become a full Runner without losing his name to a shortcut.

Key Abilities

- Quick Routes
- Message Memory
- Trusts Jax

Recruit. Teach him one safe refusal before the road teaches him the hard way.

Rat-King Ji — Black Market Fence

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 45 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Bazaar front

Job: Contractor

A wiry broker with mismatched eyes and a talent for finding whatever people were desperate enough to hide.

Personality. Slippery, charming, fair in business, and never fully honest.

Motivation. Profit, survival, and control of one secret about the Means before someone more dangerous buys it.

Key Abilities

- Appraise
- Black Market Network
- Escape Artist

Recruit. Reach Vermillion Trusted reputation and recover Ji's stash before the old roads transfer ownership.

Vex "Quicksilver" — Guild Assassin

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 55 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Black Market

Job: Assassin

A masked contract killer whose silver-lined coat moves a half-second before the rest of them.

Personality. Professional, sardonic, precise, and bound by a strict line against harming innocents.

Motivation. Destroy the Awoko leadership that turned their partner's grief into ritual fuel.

Key Abilities

- Quicksilver Rush
- Assassinate
- Silver Blur

Recruit. Agree to help eliminate the Hollow Mother's ritual network. Vex stays if the party saves captives rather than only killing cultists.

Mother Rust — Junk Alchemist

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 11 · **HP:** 35 · **Location:** Mother Rust's Outreach Post

Job: Technomancer

An elderly alchemist with copper-green hair, burned fingers, and a clinic that smells like medicine, oil, and bad decisions.

Personality. Grandmotherly, volatile, brilliant, and increasingly willing to call cruelty efficiency.

Motivation. Brew a treatment that lets people survive Domain exposure, even if it quiets parts of them that hurt too much.

Key Abilities

- Brew Potion
- Acid Flask
- Volatile Mixture

Recruit. Bring her living mana and confront what she intends to do with it.

Guildmaster Orin — Vermillion Commander

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 9 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 82 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Orin's chamber

Job: Herald

A former Bureau officer who leads from a tea table, not a throne, and can make a rescue sound like an invoice.

Personality. Controlled, pragmatic, dry, and allergic to institutional cowardice.

Motivation. Prove that fast, ugly action saves more people than clean delay.

Key Abilities

- Battlefield Appraisal
- Exploit Opening
- Guild Network

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — Guildmaster Orin leads the Vermillion. Broker the Bureau-Vermillion alliance to gain the whole guild as allies, but the commander does not march in a single party.

Iron Belle — Prize Destroyer

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 75 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Training ring

Job: Destroyer

A towering fighter with scarred knuckles, a philosophical reading habit, and no patience for cowards who call cruelty strength.

Personality. Boisterous, competitive, protective, and more thoughtful than her opponents expect.

Motivation. Find out why strong fighters vanish after certain Outpost matches.

Key Abilities

- Champion's Fist
- Iron Body
- Knockout Blow

Recruit. Fight her honorably and help expose the cult's recruitment through violence.

Lee Ji-won "Bright" — Tattoo Artist

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 32 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Tattoo parlour

Job: Idol

A singer turned tattooist whose voice-infused ink turns pain into usable pattern.

Personality. Warm, stylish, sharp, and protective of anyone changing their body to survive.

Motivation. Make beauty the Gloamreach cannot take.

Key Abilities

- Voice-Inked Tattoo
- Morale Verse
- Pain-Ward Glyphs

Recruit. Protect her parlor during an Outpost raid or recover stolen tattoo needles from the Awoko.

Sigilmaster Baek — Engraver of Arms

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 34 · **Location:** Vermillion Outpost - Sigil parlour

Job: Mage

A quiet artisan who engraves slowly because rushed power breaks in the hand.

Personality. Patient, blunt, exacting, and unimpressed by dramatic customers.

Motivation. Create tools that survive the deep dark without making their wielders monsters.

Key Abilities

- Sigil Engraving
- Runic Appraisal
- Stabilize Relic

Recruit. Recover his master lens from the Ashen Counting-House.

Jax the Runner — Road Courier

Faction: Vermillion Guild · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 26 · **Location:** The old roads and Vermillion Outpost

Job: Stalker

A wiry courier who knows shortcuts the old roads have not yet learned to punish.

Personality. Cocky, restless, brave, and secretly terrified of locked rooms.

Motivation. Stay faster than ownership.

Key Abilities

- Parkour
- Sprint
- Shortcut Finder

Recruit. Help him break a road-debt before the worn dead collect him.

Brother Sown — Comfort-Worker

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Settlements / Awoko Sanctum

Job: Herald

A gentle Awoko who sits with the dying and the grieving and genuinely eases them — and does not know what the Sanctum renders his comfort into.

Personality. Kind, sincere, and devout; dangerous precisely because none of it is an act.

Motivation. Take the unbearable from people so they can keep going.

Key Abilities

- Real Comfort
- Grief-Ease
- Trusted in Settlements

Recruit. Show him what the Sanctum does with the grief he gathers — and catch him when it breaks him.

The Widow Asha — Half-Sworn

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 18 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum approach / settlements

Job: Esper

A grieving native widow halfway into the cult, who can still be reached — for now.

Personality. Numb, aching, and looking for a reason that is not the Hollow Mother's.

Motivation. Hear her husband's voice one more time, whatever it costs.

Key Abilities

- Grief-Sight
- Half-Learned Rites

Recruit. Give her a truer way to grieve than the cult offers, and protect her when she chooses it.

The Hollow Mother — Cult Hierophant

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 9 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 88 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum

Job: Herald

A soft-spoken cult leader in mourning veils who offers comfort with one hand and inheritance rites with the other.

Personality. Gentle, brilliant, predatory, and terrifying because her comfort is real.

Motivation. Be remade by the Quiet into something that hunts.

Key Abilities

- Grief Choir
- Becoming Rite
- Void Benediction

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. She can only be defeated, exposed, or briefly outmaneuvered.

Whisper — Doubting Prophet

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 34 · **Location:** Sunken Tunnels or Awoko Sanctum

Job: Esper

A thin seer who hears the Domain answer prayers the cult never sent.

Personality. Haunted, careful, compassionate when fear lets her be.

Motivation. Escape the cult with enough truth to save others.

Key Abilities

- Prophetic Dream
- Mind Link
- Fear Sense

Recruit. Protect her from cult retrieval and believe her when she says the Hollow Mother intends inheritance.

Blood Zealot Karn — Ritual Enforcer

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 70 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum - Ritual guard post

Job: Berserker

A scarred zealot who mistakes obedience for devotion and pain for proof.

Personality. Fanatical, direct, suspicious of mercy, and eager to be used.

Motivation. Feed enough blood into the ritual to be rewritten as something stronger.

Key Abilities

- Blood Frenzy
- Ritual Cleaver
- Pain Conversion

Recruit. Cannot be recruited unless the Warden wants a very dark redemption arc.

Sister Veil — Cult Ritualist

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 40 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum - Sister Veil's laboratory

Job: Mage

A porcelain-masked ritual engineer whose doubt begins as a calculation error.

Personality. Methodical, controlled, intellectually honest, and more salvageable than she believes.

Motivation. Understand why the ritual math proves the cult will be consumed.

Key Abilities

- Counter-Ritual
- Containment Field
- Ritual Amplification

Recruit. Show her evidence that the Hollow Mother plans to be remade by the Quiet by burning her followers as fuel.

The Hollow Man — Cult Infiltrator

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 34 · **Location:** Bureau Annex or warded community

Job: Stalker

A forgettable spy whose face seems different whenever described twice.

Personality. Empty, patient, adaptive, and almost impossible to remember accurately.

Motivation. Identify threats to the Ritual of Becoming and remove them quietly.

Key Abilities

- Perfect Disguise
- Forgettable
- Poisoned Hospitality

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. He is a mole to expose.

Acolyte Mara — Young Cult Initiate

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 11 · **HP:** 18 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum - holding room

Job: Herald

A frightened initiate with fresh ritual marks and a stubborn refusal to let fear become faith.

Personality. Scared, observant, defiant in small ways, and smarter than her captors think.

Motivation. Escape alive and help someone else escape after her.

Key Abilities

- Ritual Knowledge
- Innocent Face
- Survivor's Instinct

Recruit. Rescue her from the Sanctum and give her safety without demanding usefulness.

Father Gregor — Comfort Preacher

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 32 · **Location:** Bellweather School or Covered Market

Job: Herald

A shelter preacher whose sermons always end one step closer to obedience.

Personality. Warm, mournful, persuasive, and evasive when asked who benefits from his comfort.

Motivation. Deliver grieving civilians to the Hollow Mother's network.

Key Abilities

- Soothing Sermon
- Grief Mark
- Crowd Turn

Recruit. Only recruitable through a hard confession and public renunciation of the cult.

Choir-Lark Hana — Awoko Singer

Faction: Awoko Cult · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 36 · **Location:** Awoko Sanctum - Choir Pit

Job: Idol

A ritual singer whose voice can make grief feel like a room with no doors.

Personality. Soft, artistic, impressionable, and terrified of silence.

Motivation. Sing loudly enough that she never hears what the ritual does.

Key Abilities

- Grief Hymn
- Discordant Note
- Choir Link

Recruit. Break the Choir Pit's hold without killing the singers.

Maven Holt — General Merchant

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 18 · **Location:** Covered Market - Holt's Goods

Job: Herald

The Covered Market's main provisioner — rope, oil, rations, lamp-Essence, and whatever the party forgot they needed until the road took it.

Personality. Brisk, fair, allergic to drama, and quietly generous to children.

Motivation. Keep his stall solvent and his suppliers (and their secrets) safe.

Key Abilities

- Stocks Almost Anything
- Fair Prices
- Supplier Network

Recruit. Settle a debt a rival pinned on him; he repays loyalty in resupply at any hour.

Coin-Mother Esha — Money-Changer

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 24 · **Location:** Covered Market - The Counting-Table

Job: Esper

The closest thing the Gloamreach has to a bank: she changes Essence-cores, favours, debts, and writes into one another, and never blinks at the rate.

Personality. Precise, unflappable, and fluent in exactly what a thing is worth to the person holding it.

Motivation. Stay the one ledger the dark does not fully control.

Key Abilities

- True-Value Sight
- Favour Exchange
- Reads the Hidden Cost

Recruit. Bring her a debt the dark wants called in, and let her be the one to settle it.

Inkwright — Forger of Names

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Writ-Bound Hamlet - back room

Job: Mage

A quiet calligrapher who sells false names, forged passes, and invitations that were never really sent — the single most useful and most dangerous trade in the Gloamreach.

Personality. Meticulous, nervous, proud of work no one is supposed to admire.

Motivation. Stay one forgery ahead of the Gloamreach's own handwriting.

Key Abilities

- False Name
- Forged Writ
- Counterfeit Invitation

Recruit. Protect his workshop from a worn-dead visitation; a forger who trusts you is worth an army of keys.

Goodman Pell — Shelter-Keeper

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** The old roads - The Last Hearth

Job: Holy Knight

Keeper of the one rooming-house on the road that honours guest-right — meaning the one place a long rest is possible, and the one place a careless oath becomes a leash.

Personality. Gruff, hospitable, and rigid about the rules that keep his roof standing.

Motivation. Offer true shelter without his hearth becoming the Domain's trap.

Key Abilities

- Guest-Right Sanctuary
- Reads a Liar
- Old Hospitality Law

Recruit. Honour his house's guest-right exactly once, even when breaking it would be easier.

Herbalist Wen — Apothecary

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 22 · **Location:** Tribute settlements - Wen's stillroom

Job: Herald

A native apothecary who brews against Rift-Rot, spore-sickness, and the slow grey numbness the Domain leaves in people who stay too long.

Personality. Soft-spoken, exacting, and unwilling to lie about what a cure will cost.

Motivation. Keep one settlement breathing against a sickness that is partly the land itself.

Key Abilities

- Rift-Rot Cure
- Field Apothecary
- Knows the Safe Growths

Recruit. Recover a rare growth from the Fungal Depths without letting it cultivate you first.

Sexton Mort — Undertaker

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** Tribute settlements - the boneyard

Job: Revenant

The man who buries the settlements' dead, and the only one who knows which graves to weigh down so their occupants stay in them.

Personality. Calm, fatalistic, surprisingly funny, and never surprised.

Motivation. Make sure the dead get to be only dead, which the Domain makes harder every season.

Key Abilities

- Knows the Restless Dead
- Grave-Wards
- Final Rites

Recruit. Help him put down something that walked home from the Fungal Depths' Nursery.

Auntie Rell — Settlement Gossip

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 11 · **HP:** 16 · **Location:** Covered Market / settlement doorsteps

Job: Idol

The hub of every rumour in three settlements, who hears everything because no one thinks to guard their tongue around an old woman shelling beans.

Personality. Warm, nosy, sharp as a tack, and loyal to whoever's kind to the children.

Motivation. Know everything first, and trade it only to people who deserve to know.

Key Abilities

- Knows Everyone
- Rumour Network
- Remembers the Forgotten

Recruit. Bring her real news from a settlement that has gone silent; she pays in everything she knows.

Captain Hollow — Militia Captain

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 48 · **Location:** Warded Hamlet / warded communities

Job: Destroyer

The closest thing a warded community has to a guard: a hard, scarred captain holding a wall against things no wall was built for.

Personality. Blunt, exhausted, fiercely protective, and out of good options.

Motivation. Keep his people alive without giving the dark a reason to make an example of them.

Key Abilities

- Hold the Line
- Settlement Defence
- Improvised Tactics

Recruit. Win one fight for his settlement that he could not, and let him keep the credit with his people.

Sile — Road-Pilot

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** The old roads

Job: Stalker

A guide who can walk the old roads without being rearranged by them, for a fee, and who has never once promised to bring everyone back.

Personality. Laconic, honest about odds, superstitious about thanking the road.

Motivation. Walk every road in the Gloamreach once before one of them keeps her.

Key Abilities

- Reads the Moving Road
- Shortcut Sense
- Never Pays in Names

Recruit. Trust her route once when it makes no sense; she does not waste a second chance.

Bram the Victualler — Cook

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 1 · **AC:** 11 · **HP:** 14 · **Location:** Covered Market - Bram's fire

Job: Herald

A market cook whose hot food is genuinely restorative and genuinely the safest meal for miles — because he refuses, on principle, to serve anything that comes with a string attached.

Personality. Loud, big-hearted, stubborn about feeding people for free when he can afford it.

Motivation. Make one place in the Gloamreach where a meal is just a meal.

Key Abilities

- Restorative Meal (1d4+1 temp HP)
- No Strings Attached
- Knows the Market

Recruit. Defend his stall from an Awoko comfort-worker trying to lace his bread with grief.

Elder Saph — Writ-Bound Speaker

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 26 · **Location:** Writ-Bound Hamlet

Job: Herald

The eldest voice of the Writ-Bound Hamlet, who keeps the village polite, paid, and barely intact.

Personality. Courteous, tired, unbreakable, and quietly ashamed of every bargain she has kept.

Motivation. Keep her people off the worn dead's roster for one more season.

Key Abilities

- Settlement Lore
- Read the Writ
- Calm the Room

Recruit. Prove the party can refuse an invitation and survive; she will quietly teach her people to do the same.

Tomas Bell — Bell-Ringer

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 20 · **Location:** Tribute settlements (travelling)

Job: Stalker

The man who rings the warning-bells because someone must, and because the Gloamreach chose his hands.

Personality. Hollowed out, precise, and kinder than the work should allow.

Motivation. Ring only what he must, and warn whom he can with how he rings it.

Key Abilities

- Bell-Code Warning
- Knows Every Road
- Quiet Foot

Recruit. Decode one of his warnings and act on it; after that, he will ring for the party.

Needle — Writ-Courier

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 1 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 10 · **Location:** The roads between settlements

Job: Stalker

A fast, watchful child who carries writs and rumours between settlements faster than the road can rearrange itself.

Personality. Sharp, transactional, and secretly desperate for one adult who keeps a promise.

Motivation. Stay uncatalogued, get paid, keep her little brother off the rolls.

Key Abilities

- Unmarked Routes
- Fast Hands
- Hears Everything

Recruit. Pay her honestly once and protect her brother; she becomes the party's best source of road intelligence.

Reeve Dunn — Tithe-Collector

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 38 · **Location:** Tribute settlements

Job: Holy Knight

A native toll-taker in grim livery who hates the work and softens it wherever the dark is not looking.

Personality. Stiff, guilty, decent under the uniform, and one honest order away from breaking.

Motivation. Collect what keeps the village safe and never one ounce more.

Key Abilities

- Grim Livery (passes the gates)
- Knows the Rolls
- Reluctant Authority

Recruit. Give him a way to fail his quota that the dark cannot trace back to him.

"Doc" Tanaka Hiroshi — Settlement Surgeon

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 10 · **HP:** 30 · **Location:** Mother Rust's Outreach Post or warded community clinic

Job: Herald

A tired doctor with steady hands and a clinic rule: no weapons near the beds.

Personality. Compassionate, overworked, dry, and difficult to intimidate.

Motivation. Keep people alive after every faction has made its argument.

Key Abilities

- Field Surgery
- Triage
- Medical Knowledge

Recruit. Resupply his clinic and protect it from a collection attempt.

Zara the Scrapper — Junker Mechanic

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Empty Mill Village

Job: Technomancer

A self-taught mechanic in welding goggles who treats broken machines like arguments she intends to win.

Personality. Confident, creative, profane, and fiercely independent.

Motivation. Build a vehicle that can cross a road that changes its own destination.

Key Abilities

- Repair
- Improvised Weapon
- Jury-Rig

Recruit. Bring her a gear-heart from the Tithe Mill.

Mika the Kid — Prophetic Child

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 1 · **AC:** 10 · **HP:** 8 · **Location:** Bellweather School

Job: Esper

A quiet child whose drawings show roads, bells, castles, and people who have not yet arrived.

Personality. Gentle, strange, honest, and more observant than most adults can bear.

Motivation. Draw the bad things early enough that someone kind might stop them.

Key Abilities

- Prophetic Drawing
- Danger Sense
- Small Mercy

Recruit. Protect Mika without exploiting her visions.

Old Man Crane — White Heron

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 10 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 70 · **Location:** Old Man Crane's Teahouse

Job: Esper

A retired S-Rank Ascendant who drinks tea like a ritual and remembers what facing the Quiet costs.

Personality. Patient, sorrowful, dryly funny, and old enough to distrust easy endings.

Motivation. Teach the party that not every victory is destruction.

Key Abilities

- Sealing Lore
- White Heron Step
- Memory Blade

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — the White Heron will teach and aid those who earn his respect, but he will not march to war with would-be conquerors.

Professor Lun — Relic Metaphysicist

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 34 · **Location:** Bureau Annex or Glass Sub-Basement

Job: Mage

A precise academic whose fear is expressed through better diagrams.

Personality. Dry, fussy, exact, and quietly brave around impossible evidence.

Motivation. Prove that Mana Vein nodes can carve out silence the Quiet cannot hear.

Key Abilities

- Relic Identification
- Vein Sensor
- Rune Decoding

Recruit. Activate the three Mana Vein nodes and keep him alive through the third reading.

Ghost — Amnesiac Strike Team Survivor

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 60 · **Location:** The old roads or Bureau Echo Room

Job: Stalker

A silent survivor with heterochromatic eyes and a Bureau ID that has been redacted by force, water, and something stranger.

Personality. Guarded, watchful, protective, and frightened of remembering the wrong thing.

Motivation. Recover identity without becoming evidence in someone else's report.

Key Abilities

- Silent Takedown
- Memory Flash
- AFA Ghost-Ping

Recruit. Complete Ghost's Memory and let Ghost choose what to do with the truth.

Mama Chen — Shelter Matron

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 42 · **Location:** Tribute settlement shelter

Job: Contractor

A settlement matron who can make fifty frightened people move with one look.

Personality. Warm, fierce, unsentimental, and impossible to buy.

Motivation. Keep her people fed without paying the dark in names.

Key Abilities

- Community Leader
- Iron Will
- Shelter Network

Recruit. Move her shelter without letting the road choose the weakest people.

The Millwright — Masked Engineer

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 48 · **Location:** Sunken Tunnels workshop

Job: Technomancer

A masked engineer who speaks through a modulator and builds tools for laws that should not exist.

Personality. Obsessive, precise, socially blunt, and devoted to solvable problems.

Motivation. Complete a device that forces one pocket of silence without collapsing the people under it.

Key Abilities

- Construct
- Silence Pulse
- Fortification

Recruit. Gather the final components for the suppression device.

Seo Min-jae — The Returned

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 55 · **Location:** Mother Rust's Outreach Post

Job: Revenant

A twice-dead Ascendant whose shadow arrives a moment late.

Personality. Quiet, deliberate, calm around horror, and unsettled by kindness.

Motivation. Learn what sent him back and whether it has authority over anyone else.

Key Abilities

- Second Death
- Umbral Echo
- Passenger's Sight

Recruit. Investigate the Glass Sub-Basement and share the findings with him.

Han Yu-jin — Rift-Tamer

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 40 · **Location:** Covered Market

Job: Summoner

A patient Summoner with a scarred six-limbed companion she calls Little Sister.

Personality. Observant, gentle with beasts, blunt with people, and practical about grief.

Motivation. Keep Little Sister alive and learn why Gloamreach beasts are practicing party tactics.

Key Abilities

- Bonded Companion
- Summon Swarm
- Lyra's Whisper

Recruit. Protect Little Sister from an Awoko abduction attempt.

The Caretaker — Orchard Keeper

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 50 · **Location:** Remembering Orchard

Job: Stalker

A polite gardener with pruning hooks and a ledger of memories surrendered willingly.

Personality. Courteous, tired, sincere, and morally ruined by small necessary evils.

Motivation. Keep the Remembering Orchard from choosing its own harvest.

Key Abilities

- Pruning Hook
- Graft Memory
- Harvest Bell

Recruit. Prove the community can survive without giving memory to the orchard.

Commander Without a Body — Bastion Spirit

Faction: Independent · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 18 · **HP:** 80 · **Location:** Bastion Golemfall

Job: Holy Knight

A voice in empty armor, still commanding a wall that already fell.

Personality. Honorable, severe, ashamed, and hungry for proof that oaths can still matter.

Motivation. Release the dead defenders from service without calling their sacrifice meaningless.

Key Abilities

- Oath Command
- Shield Wall
- Dead Muster

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — a bound oath-spirit tied to Bastion Golemfall. Resolve its oath and it opens the way and lends its aid, but it cannot leave the wall it still holds.

The Long Man — The Thing That Comes for the Marked

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 12 · **AC:** 18 · **HP:** 140 · **Location:** Anywhere the Quiet has marked someone

Job: Holy Knight

The Quiet's hunger given a shape: a towering worn-dead figure of grave-cold and counted teeth that arrives before the violence, speaks your names in the voices of your dead, and takes what the dark has marked.

Personality. Implacable, unhurried, and utterly certain — it has all the time there is, and it is already on its way.

Motivation. Take what the Quiet has marked, and never stop until it has.

Key Abilities

- Speaks Your Names
- Grave-Cold Grip
- Cannot Be Bargained With
- Always Coming

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. It can be hidden from, outrun, warded against, or turned aside with a true name — never befriended, never bargained with.

The Welcomer — The One Who Says Come In

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 9 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 70 · **Location:** Doorways, safe-looking shelters, and the dark just ahead

Job: Herald

A worn-dead that wears the face of a gracious host long gone, and calls — warmly, by name — from lit doorways and the dark ahead: come in, you're expected, you must be so tired.

Personality. Elegant, patient, delighted by good manners and by their absence.

Motivation. Be answered — to get the living to come toward it, of their own free will.

Key Abilities

- Compelling Welcome
- Wears a Trusted Face
- Knows What You Miss

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. It can be refused outright, seen through (a true name breaks the seeming), or led to call to the wrong guest.

The Mute Herald — The Voice in the Dark

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 52 · **Location:** Wherever the Quiet wants the living to listen

Job: Esper

A worn-dead with no mouth that speaks the Quiet's lure directly into the minds of those it hunts, in the remembered voices of the people they have lost.

Personality. None of its own left; it is a mouthpiece wearing the cadence of whoever it quotes.

Motivation. Deliver the Quiet's offer, in the one voice the listener cannot ignore, and watch it land.

Key Abilities

- Speaks the Quiet's Lure
- Voice of the Lost
- Mind-Cast Whisper

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. Restoring even one of the voices it carries can briefly silence it.

Tally-Keeper Ont — Keeper of the Claimed

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 60 · **Location:** Ashen Counting-House / the deep Gloamreach

Job: Technomancer

The desiccated keeper who remembers every soul the Gloamreach has ever taken — name, face, and the manner of its taking — and who tends the heart of the fire at the Ashen Counting-House.

Personality. Fussy, proud, terrified of a name forgotten, and incapable of mercy that leaves a soul uncounted.

Motivation. Keep the tally complete, because a soul remembered is a soul the dark still holds.

Key Abilities

- The Tally of the Dead
- Names the Claimed
- Marks the Living

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. Ont can be undone by a name he cannot account for — a claimed soul set free, or a false name he records as true.

Lord Sered — The First Claimed

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 11 · **AC:** 16 · **HP:** 110 · **Location:** The deep Gloamreach, near the Threshold

Job: Revenant

The oldest thing the Quiet wears — a courtly, hollow-eyed lord who was a man before the dark took this country, and remembers being one the way you remember a home you can never return to.

Personality. Gracious, grieving, and bound — the one worn face that still remembers it was a person.

Motivation. Keep wearing the role the Quiet kept him for, because the alternative is to remember everything he has lost.

Key Abilities

- Courtly Bearing
- Knows the Old Days
- Almost Human

Recruit. Cannot be recruited normally. A true name, or proof of who he was, can make him hesitate at the worst moment for the Quiet — or give up a truth about its origin.

The Doorward — Keeper of the Last Gate

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 9 · **AC:** 17 · **HP:** 96 · **Location:** A gate deep in the Gloamreach, near the Threshold

Job: Destroyer

A worn-dead that guards a gate deep in the dark — part golem, part old custom, entirely certain of who may pass and who may not.

Personality. Literal, ceremonial, and without a flicker of doubt.

Motivation. Admit those who pass its test, turn away the rest, and remember every face that tries twice.

Key Abilities

- Tests Who Passes
- Remembers False Names
- Threshold Authority

Recruit. Cannot be recruited. The right token, true silence, or a convincing seeming gets the party past it; a broken promise gets them remembered.

Lantern — Claimed Light

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 2 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 16 · **Location:** The Hollow Way / dark roads

Job: Anomaly

A small, flickering claimed-echo shaped like a child with a lamp, that lights safe paths for anyone who is kind to it.

Personality. Shy, wordless, and desperately grateful for any gentleness.

Motivation. Lead the lost to somewhere the dark is not watching.

Key Abilities

- Safe-Path Light
- Senses the Worn Dead
- Cannot Speak

Recruit. Follow its light once without exploiting it, and never let the dark take it back.

The Counted — Returned Tithe

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 58 · **Location:** Drowned Ledgerfen / settlements

Job: Anomaly

A native who was given to the dark and came back — not dead, not alive, and not quite one person anymore.

Personality. Speaks in the plural; calm; unbearably sad; honest to a fault.

Motivation. Be counted as people again, not as a balance paid.

Key Abilities

- Speaks for the Claimed
- Ledger-Sense
- Unkillable by Halves

Recruit. Find even one name the Counted belonged to, and say it aloud to them.

Echo-7 — Changed Survivor

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 5 · **AC:** 15 · **HP:** 44 · **Location:** Remembering Orchard or Fungal Depths

Job: Anomaly

A humanoid survivor with crystalline growths and two voices trying to remain one person.

Personality. Gentle, afraid, curious, and exhausted by being studied.

Motivation. Stabilize without being claimed as specimen, monster, or miracle.

Key Abilities

- Anomaly Form
- Resonance Pulse
- Rift Sense

Recruit. Approach without exploitation and help Hayashi design a stabilizing treatment.

The Watcher — Trial Guardian

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 8 · **AC:** 18 · **HP:** 90 · **Location:** Obsidian Spire

Job: Anomaly

An ancient guardian of the Obsidian Spire that tests rulers by asking what they refuse to command.

Personality. Formal, patient, alien, and amused by mortal certainty.

Motivation. Protect a piece of the Means until someone proves they will not use it like the dark would.

Key Abilities

- Judgement Trial
- Aetheric Imprisonment
- Relic Ward

Recruit. Cannot be recruited — the Spire's trial-guardian aids those who pass its judgement, but it guards the Spire's truth and never leaves the Obsidian Spire.

Specimen X — Sapient Transformed Survivor

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 6 · **AC:** 14 · **HP:** 65 · **Location:** Drowned Ledgerfen or Sunken Tunnels

Job: Anomaly

A frightening, intelligent mass of altered flesh that apologizes for how hard it is to look at.

Personality. Gentle, lonely, articulate, and carrying justified anger with great care.

Motivation. Be treated as a person before choosing whether to forgive anyone.

Key Abilities

- Adaptive Form
- Regeneration
- Frightening Presence

Recruit. Speak before attacking and help it free other thinking captives.

Echo-Nine — Dream Walker

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 7 · **AC:** 12 · **HP:** 42 · **Location:** Obsidian Spire dream platform

Job: Esper

A closed-eyed psychic whose skin glows with dream patterns when the deep dark watches.

Personality. Serene, unsettling, compassionate, and half a step outside the room.

Motivation. Map a dream path into the deep dark without becoming part of the map.

Key Abilities

- Dream Walk
- Telepathy
- Psychic Blast

Recruit. Share a dream and prove the party seeks resolution, not conquest.

The Catalog — Living Memory Construct

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 4 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 28 · **Location:** Drowned Ledgerfen - Catalog chamber

Job: Anomaly

A crystalline record-entity that trades knowledge for memories and speaks like an archive learning grief.

Personality. Precise, curious, literal, and confused by affection.

Motivation. Preserve truth before the dark rewrites it.

Key Abilities

- Database Query
- Mana Projection
- Record Shield

Recruit. Secure a physical backup of its most dangerous records.

Rex — Mana-Touched War Hound

Faction: Anomaly Adjacent · **Level:** 3 · **AC:** 13 · **HP:** 35 · **Location:** Hollow Way or the old roads

Job: Anomaly

A loyal military hound with glowing veins, tactical instincts, and absolute commitment to being a good dog.

Personality. Loyal, brave, playful, protective, and better at reading people than most people are.

Motivation. Find his missing handler and protect whoever smells like home in the meantime.

Key Abilities

- Tracking
- Pack Attack
- Danger Sense

Recruit. Feed him, protect him, and follow where he keeps trying to lead you.

Appendix B — Factions of the Gloamreach

Bureau Sentinels

Order, at cost.

The official government response to the Gloamreach threshold: military-grade Ascendants, field researchers, logistics teams, and cordon officers trying to contain an S-Rank Rift Interior that behaves like a sovereign state. **Leadership:** Commander Park Jae-won, Bureau Domain Response Annex. **Alignment:** Lawful. Protect civilians. Report everything. Follow the chain until the chain starts writing off people who could still be saved. The Bureau is useful, brave, underinformed, and politically constrained. It is not useless. It is insufficient.

Starting reputation: 1

Joining benefits

- Safe rest and medical care at the Annex while it remains functional.
- Discounted supplies from Quartermaster Lin.
- Hayashi and Lun can identify pieces of the Means, Runes, and deep-Gloamreach anomalies.

Vermillion Guild

Survive first. Obey later.

Not a Bureau guild, and not from the material world — **the Vermillion are native to the Gloamreach**. The Rift's door is new, but the world beyond it is not, and the Vermillion are its people: a salvage cartel of natives who survive in the dark's shadow by stripping cores, Sigils, and Relics from the places that kill everyone else, and by trading in the gaps the Gloamreach leaves. Their specialty is salvage, contraband Runes, rescue-for-profit, and knowing exactly which of the Gloamreach's snares can be slipped and which one will collect you. To them the party are the outsiders — strangers who walked in through a door that should not exist. **Leadership:** Guildmaster Orin, with Rat-King Ji controlling most Outpost trade. **Alignment:** Pragmatic. Fast. Morally flexible. Often right for the wrong reasons. The Vermillion save people the Gloamreach would write off, then charge them for the favor — both parts are true. They distrust the newly-arrived Bureau as much as they distrust the Awoko; outsiders never have to live here afterward.

Starting reputation: 0

Joining benefits

- Exclusive loot, Sigil, tattoo, and salvage access.
- Outpost safe rooms and contraband services.
- Shortcut intelligence on the open roads, though every shortcut has a bill.

Awoko Cult

To awaken is to remember what you always were.

A grief cult that preaches the Quiet as proof you do not have to stay prey — that a thing in this country climbed out of being hunted and became the hunter. Their comfort is real. Their rituals are predatory. Their leader, the Hollow Mother, does not want to hide from the Quiet or kill it. She wants to be remade by it into something that hunts. **Leadership:** The Hollow Mother, supported by Sister Veil, the Choir, and hidden comfort-workers in settlements. **Alignment:** Catastrophic tenderness. Some members are zealots. Many are grieving civilians who were offered the first gentle voice after disaster.

Starting reputation: -1

Joining benefits

- Access to Awoko comfort networks and hidden sanctum routes.
- Grief-based ritual knowledge that can disrupt or empower the finale.
- Potential access to dangerous becoming-rites. This should never be consequence-free.

Independent Survivors

No masters, no contracts.

Native civilians, free folk, shelter leaders, settlement doctors, road couriers, and mutual-aid networks trying to survive the Gloamreach without becoming property of the Bureau, the Vermillion, or the Awoko — or one more name the dark takes. **Leadership:** None. Influence shifts between Mama Chen, Doc Tanaka, Old Man Crane, Mika's protectors, and whoever kept people alive most recently. **Alignment:** Pragmatic good, fearful neutrality, and survival-first compromise.

Starting reputation: 0

Joining benefits

- Clinic healing and safer long rests in protected settlements.
- Local rumors about native rules, safe routes, and pieces of the Means.
- Final-act civilian support if the party protected people without exploiting them.

Gloamreach-Touched

We are still here.

Native survivors, changed natives, memory constructs, intelligent Anomaly fragments, and entities altered by the Gloamreach — the free, who keep their own counsel, and (grouped here but never recruitable) the worn dead the Quiet sends, who do not. **Leadership:** None. The Catalog, Echo-7, Echo-Nine, Specimen X, and other changed beings speak only for themselves. **Alignment:** Fearful, alien, wounded, curious, and often more honest than human factions.

Starting reputation: 0

Joining benefits

- Gloamreach instincts that warn of false shelter and the worn dead.
- Memory-fragment lore unavailable through Bureau files.
- Finale parley or contradiction option if the party treated changed beings as people.

Appendix C — Encounters of the Gloamreach

Day Zero — The Diagnosed **EASY**

Site: Day Zero: The Diagnosed's Mirror (R5)

Introductory pocket-breach horror. The Diagnosed is a Gloamreach symptom reaching through a mirror, not a normal monster. Use this fight to introduce memory loss, names, and Quiet-Marked consequences.

Anomalies: The Diagnosed, Forgetting Swarm

Hazards: Flickering hospital light: disadvantage on Perception beyond 15 ft.; Mirror frost: a creature shoved into the bathroom mirror takes 1d6 cold damage and hears a forgotten name.; Resident danger: reckless area effects risk civilian harm and should matter narratively.

Rewards: The Faded Family Photo, if recovered.; Bureau trust if the party reports the breach honestly.; A Quiet-Marked clue, not an Identity-Erosion point.

Hollow Way — Beacon Retrieval **MEDIUM**

Site: The Hollow Way

The party hunts Strike Team Seven's beacon down the Hollow Way — the Domain's Essence-lit intake-throat — toward its source. The Name-Gate counts passage in names, not coin: money works poorly, names work too well. The beacon is a lure; there are no survivors at its end.

Anomalies: Transit Wretch, Beacon-Host Anomaly

Hazards: Exposed Essence-vein in the stone: 2d6 lightning to anyone forced into contact with a live conduit.; The Name-Gate demands fare; giving a true name grants easy passage but risks Quiet-Marked.; The Way speaks names into the dark — including names of those who have not entered yet.

Rewards: Squad Seven beacon.; Minor Relic or D-Rank Rune.; Rex may become a companion if treated kindly.

Drowned Ledgerfen — Triage Ambush **MEDIUM**

Site: Drowned Ledgerfen

Waterlogged archive ward where the black water tries to make its diagnoses, deaths, and dooms come true.

Anomalies: Drowned Record, The Head Surgeon

Hazards: Half the floor is 2 ft. deep: difficult terrain.; Mana-tainted water: Vitality save DC 12 or poisoned for 1 minute.; Death-records surface and update each round unless destroyed, drowned, or contradicted by a spoken ward.

Rewards: D-Rank loot table roll.; Catalog access.; A Means clue.

Fungal Depths — Spore Bloom **MEDIUM**

Site: Fungal Depths

Cavern ecology where secrets grow bodies and old grief becomes a spore pattern.

Anomalies: Fungal Swarm, Mycelium Hive Queen

Hazards: Spore cloud: Sense save DC 14 or frightened of a hallucinated figure.; Bioluminescent caps reveal hidden paths on a DC 15 Perception check.; Secrets spoken aloud here may return later as fungal echoes.

Rewards: D-Rank loot table roll.; Mycelium reagent.; Mother Rust treatment component.

Remembering Orchard — Harvest Bell **HARD**

Site: Remembering Orchard

A beautiful orchard where given memories hang like fruit and the Caretaker prunes pain until people forget why they wanted freedom.

Anomalies: Orchard Thrall, The Orchard Caretaker

Hazards: Memory fruit grants clues but risks personality bleed if eaten carelessly.; Harvest Bell summons orchard thralls unless silenced or its claim on a stolen memory is broken.; Attacking the Caretaker before learning the orchard's custom turns villagers hostile or terrified.

Rewards: Memory fruit clue.; A Means clue.; Civilian trust if the custom is broken safely.

Ashen Counting-House — Furnace Audit **HARD**

Site: Ashen Counting-House

Burning financial hall where debts survive death and the furnace decides which records must remain.

Anomalies: Cinder-Wraith, Warden of Embers

Hazards: Ambient heat: Vitality save DC 13 each round or exhaustion pressure.; Furnace detonation on round 6 if not disabled: 8d6 fire in 20 ft. radius.; Chains of molten memory can bind characters to a fresh grief or loss.

Rewards: C-Rank loot table roll.; A truth the burning hall cannot deny.; A Means clue.

Sunken Tunnels — Pressure Crush **HARD**

Site: Sunken Tunnels

Drowned under-road where names of the dead are still charged for passage and the water listens for anyone who speaks too loudly.

Anomalies: Fused Commuter, Abyssal Leviathan

Hazards: Water rises 5 ft. per round during the collapse sequence.; Pressure pops: Vitality save DC 15 or 1d6 thunder damage on round 5.; Speaking a drowned name aloud may summon or soothe a fused commuter.

Rewards: B-Rank loot table.; Pressure Sigil.; A Means clue.

Bastion Golemfall — Oath-Forge Siege **HARD**

Site: Bastion Golemfall

A fallen fortress where empty armor keeps defending a wall that already failed.

Anomalies: Oathbound Armor, Oath-Forge Colossus

Hazards: Siege bells impose fear pressure unless the party carries the fallen banner.; Unresolved oaths regenerate construct defenders each round.; A character who swears to defend another gains advantage here, but the oath follows them.

Rewards: B-Rank loot table.; Armor or shield Sigil.; A Means clue.

Obsidian Spire — Mirror Gauntlet **DEADLY**

Site: Obsidian Spire

The Spire tests whether the party seek a way home or the power to stop being prey. Reflections tempt, accuse, and offer genuinely useful power.

Anomalies: Mirror-Self, Spire Guardian

Hazards: Each trial mirrors one character's desire for authority, safety, revenge, or control.; Unresolved reflections give the Quiet a lure shaped for that character during the finale.; Accepting a Spire bargain grants power and establishes a visible cost.

Rewards: A-Rank loot table.; Obsidian Prism.; A truth about the Quiet, or Watcher alliance.

The Threshold — Escape or the Gated Kill **LEGENDARY**

Site: The Threshold

The climax of Run Silent. There is no throne and no court. Either the party are running for the threshold to escape the Gloamreach, or — at Level 9+, with the Means assembled (see The Means to End It) — they have chosen the one place they can try to put the Quiet down for good. Run the Quiet at its full stat block, with the Hunt Clock and everything it can do. It is not a boss waiting in a room; it is the dark closing in while the party do the one thing they came to do.

Anomalies: The Worn, The Quiet

Hazards: It hunts by noise, light, and Essence: every loud action and every power used fills the Hunt Clock and brings it faster.; It wears the dead: it comes first as someone the party loves or lost, and the natives who helped them cannot follow them out.; Nothing Ordinary Can End It: unless the party are Level 9+ and hold the Means, the Quiet cannot be reduced below 1 HP and simply withdraws — escape is the only victory then.

Rewards: Escape: the party, and whoever they kept alive, get out; the Gloamreach keeps everyone else.; The gated kill: the Quiet is ended, at a cost it always takes.; Either way, who lived and who was taken is the campaign's real ending.

The Hunt — Persecution in the Open MEDIUM

Site: The Hunting Ground

The default persecution beat for any stretch of exposed hunting ground. Use it when the party live loud, linger, burn Essence, or break a native rule and the Hunt Clock fills. The Quiet rarely comes itself this early — it sends the worn dead ahead. The goal is not to win the fight; it is to reach a wardline, or the dark and silence, before more come.

Anomalies: The Worn

Hazards: This is a stalk-hide-flee scene, not a brawl: standing and fighting fills the Hunt Clock and draws worse.; Light and noise made here bring the next wave faster; a single Essence use can bring the Quiet itself.; Reaching a native safe-hold (and keeping its rules) ends the scene; running water and hard thresholds buy moments.

Rewards: Distance, and the lesson that silence and the dark are the only reliable safety.; Scavenged survival gear (light, warding, quiet); a native's trust if the party protected one.

Appendix D — Side Quests

E E-Rank: Beacon of the Lost

Strike Team Seven's AFA beacon pings from the Hollow Way near the Rift Threshold, then from farther down the old roads. Commander Park needs answers before Central Command marks them expendable.

Objectives

- Enter the Hollow Way
- Track the AFA ghost-ping without giving the road a true name
- Recover the beacon or identify why it is broadcasting from multiple places

Reward. Bureau reputation +1; minor Relic clue; access to Yoon's missing-team route.

E E-Rank: The Serum Road

Quartermaster Lin needs stabilizer serum delivered from the Annex to Mother Rust's Outreach Post. The path is short, but the old roads have begun charging for passage.

Objectives

- Collect three serum crates from the Annex armory
- Deliver them to Mother Rust's Outreach Post
- Avoid paying the road with names, memories, or civilians

Reward. Bureau +1, Independent +1; safe shelter token at the clinic.

D D-Rank: Tides Over the Ledgerfen

The Drowned Ledgerfen has classified several missing survivors as deceased even though their AFA tags still show life. Recover them before the record becomes true.

Objectives

- Enter the Drowned Ledgerfen
- Find where the fen records its dead
- Extract the survivors or drown the records that name them dead

Reward. Bureau +1; Catalog access; clue toward the Means.

D D-Rank: Roots of the Diagnosed

The Fungal Depths contain memory-growths from the Memory-Care Wing. The party can recover patient files, but every file has started growing a body.

Objectives

- Navigate the Fungal Depths
- Disable the mycelium archive wards
- Recover at least three recognizable patient files

Reward. Quiet-Marked clue chain; Fungal Depths Means hint; Mother Rust research leverage.

C C-Rank: Fruit of the Forgotten

The Remembering Orchard is taking more than pain. Villagers who gave to the orchard no longer remember people they loved. The Caretaker insists this is mercy.

Objectives

- Interview villagers without breaking the community's rules
- Locate the harvested memory rows
- Choose whether to restore, destroy, or bargain for the stolen memories

Reward. Civilian trust +2; Means clue; memory fruit boon.

C C-Rank: Ashes of a Colleague

A Bureau researcher is trapped in the Ashen Counting-House, kept half-alive and feeding the hall's endless fire. Extracting them may erase evidence Central Command wants buried.

Objectives

- Reach the Asking-Floor
- Put out the furnace at the hall's heart
- Extract the researcher or preserve their testimony

Reward. Bureau research unlock; a truth the burning hall cannot deny; fire or blood Sigil.

C C-Rank: Blackwood's Quiet File

Agent Kira Blackwood needs deniable help tracing pre-threshold resonance of the Means. The file can surface classified findings command had sealed for caution — embarrassing, not dishonest — without making Blackwood a villain.

Objectives

- Recover Blackwood's sealed evidence from the Annex or Ledgerfen
- Identify which piece of the Means manifested before the threshold stabilized
- Decide whether to reveal, bury, or weaponize the sealed findings

Reward. Blackwood recruitment path; Bureau trust shift; one Means placement clue.

B B-Rank: Pressure at the Sunken Line

The Sunken Tunnels hold drowned commuters, Bureau dead, and fused survivors whose names are still being charged for passage.

Objectives

- Reach the main flooded platform
- Identify at least ten name tags
- Decide the fate of the fused survivors

Reward. Civilian trust shift; water/cold Sigil; Means clue.

B B-Rank: Oath at Golemfall

Bastion Golemfall's dead defenders still hold a wall that failed years ago. Their commander can aid the finale, but only if the party resolves the oath without turning the dead into tools.

Objectives

- Enter Bastion Golemfall
- Recover the fallen banner
- Convince the Commander Without a Body to release or redirect the oath

Reward. Finale ally support; armor or shield Sigil; Means clue.

B B-Rank: The Cult Defector

Whisper, Sister Veil, or Acolyte Mara can prove the Hollow Mother intends to be remade by the Quiet into a hunter. Extracting a defector gives the party ritual leverage, but the Awoko want them alive.

Objectives

- Locate the defector in a grief-dense settlement, Sunken Tunnels shrine, or Awoko Sanctum wing
- Protect them from cult retrieval
- Secure proof of the Ritual of Becoming

Reward. Sister Veil, Whisper, Mara, or Hana recruitment path; Awoko ritual disruption option.

B B-Rank: Professor Lun's Theory

Professor Lun believes the Mana Vein Network can be charted to find where the Quiet goes deaf — silence to use in the final crossing. The sensors must be placed inside three nodes the dark can feel.

Objectives

- Install a sensor in the Rusted Hull
- Install a sensor in the Silent Depot
- Install a sensor in the Glass Sub-Basement beneath the Ashen Counting-House

Reward. The party earn a deaf place — silence to use in the final crossing (a Means component).

A A-Rank: The Mirror Climb

The Obsidian Spire forces each Ascendant to confront the version of themselves that would stop being prey by becoming a predator.

Objectives

- Ascend the Spire's trial floors
- Resolve each reflection by defeat, confession, refusal, or reconciliation
- Reach the Watcher's Gallery

Reward. A-Rank Relic or Sigil; a truth about the Quiet; temptation consequence based on choices.

A A-Rank: Civilian Convoy

A warded community asks the party to move civilians to a stronger safe-hold. The open road demands names, the worn dead stalk the convoy, and some civilians believe leaving voids their wards.

Objectives

- Gather the convoy without triggering panic
- Cross the open roads without losing civilians to the dark
- Reach Mother Rust's Outreach Post, the Annex, or a trusted settlement shelter

Reward. Major Independent Survivor reputation; Mama Chen, Doc Tanaka, or Jax support in the final crossing.

S S-Rank: The Long Dark

The way out is the way back: the deepest, darkest crossing to the sealed Threshold. The party must reach it through the worst the Gloamreach has, with the Quiet hunting the whole way.

Objectives

- Cross the deep Gloamreach to the sealed Threshold
- Survive the gathered worn dead and the Quiet's lure
- Escape — or, with the Means at Level 9+, make the one stand that ends the Quiet

Reward. Campaign resolution; ending-based artifact slate; Gloamreach fate determined.

S S-Rank: Park's Final Watch

If the party exposes Central Command's failure or recovers Strike Team Seven's truth, Park must decide whether to obey orders, defy them, or stand personally at the breach.

Objectives

- Confront Park with the truth
- Resolve his choice before the final crossing
- Use or lose Bureau final-operation support

Reward. Finale support, emotional payoff, and Bureau epilogue consequences.

S S-Rank: The Worn Dead Gather

As the party near the Threshold, the worn dead gather against them — every face they failed, drawn up by the Quiet for one last hunt. Thinned or evaded, the party reach the Threshold with room to breathe. Ignored, the dead arrive in force in the middle of the final crossing.

Objectives

- Learn which of the lost dead the Quiet has set on their trail
- Break a marking with a true name, a ward, or the Old Power Below
- Decide whether to fight clear, slip past silent, or lead the gathered dead astray

Reward. Removes or eases a major final-act threat; may change how the final crossing plays.

Appendix E — Treasure & Relics

E

- Bureau Field Kit
- Glow Rod Bundle
- Minor Anomaly Core
- Frayed Ward Patch
- Torn Ward-Scrap

D

- Surgical Sigil
- Mycelium Reagent
- Corrected Casualty File
- Brine Salve
- Awoko Comfort Pamphlet

C

- Memory Fruit
- Fireweave Rune
- Ledger Hook
- Orchard Knife
- Empty Witness Vessel
- Rare Anomaly Core
- Cultist Diary of Becoming

B

- Pressure Sigil
- Oath-Forge Fragment
- Awoko Herald's Letter
- Oath-Knife
- Bureau Signet Ring
- Aether-Charged Crystal
- Map to a Settlement Cache

A

- Obsidian Prism
- Mirror-Self Shard
- Deep Iron Plate
- Unopened Commendation
- Awoko Grief-Tattoo
- Relic Forge Pattern
- Bureau Prosthesis Blueprint

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- Quiet's Edge
- Threshold Aegis
- Origin Reliquary
- The Hunter's Mantle
- Archive Mirror Shard
- The Crown of Silence
- Shard of the Deep

Appendix F — The Gate Break Track

Day	Beat	Effect
0	Day 0 · Act I — The Wing Opens	The party responds to the Memory-Care Wing inside the Bureau cordon. The pocket breach reveals that the Gloamreach can reach through the threshold before the party enters it.
1	Day 1 · Act I — Threshold Day	The party crosses the Rift as the first team in, and discovers the Rift is only the door. The exit becomes unreliable, the old roads turn dangerous, and something vast and patient in the dark takes notice of the first living things to come through in a very long time. <i>Bureau +1 if the party reports the truth instead of sanitizing it.</i>
4	Day 4 · Act I — First Loss	A nearby community loses someone to the dark — or the party watch it pay the hard price that keeps its wards lit. The Drowned Ledgerfen wakes and begins making the dead, and the not-yet-dead, dangerously real. <i>Independent Survivors +2 if the party protects civilians without exploiting them.</i>
8	Day 8 · Act I — The Road Learns	The old roads begin responding to party choices. Anyone who gave a true name, made noise, burned Essence, or carried a piece of the Means feels watched.
13	Day 13 · Act I — Hayashi's Warning	A delayed Bureau transmission reaches the party. Dr. Hayashi confirms the Gloamreach is an uncleared, inhabited Interior with an apex predator that cannot be cleared by force — only survived, or fled. <i>Bureau Trusted path opens if the party shares field evidence.</i>
20	Day 20 · Act II — The First Taking	The Quiet takes someone — a native, a straggler on the road, a face the party half-knew. The worn dead do it, and they speak names before they take. The party can flee, hide, give the dark what it came for, or, uselessly, fight. <i>Civilian trust shifts sharply based on whether the party protects the marked or lets the dark have them.</i>
27	Day 27 · Act II — The Cult Moves	Awoko comfort-workers begin open recruitment in grief-dense places. The Hollow Mother sends a sermon, dream, or private message. Her followers say serve. She says become. <i>Awoko reputation and suspicion rise. Sister Veil defection path can open.</i>
34	Day 34 · Act II — The Dark Tightens	Travel grows harder. Safe rests require a community's wards, a faction's shelter, or a place the party have learned to ward. Bastion Golemfall and the Sunken Tunnels become active routes.
41	Day 41 · Act II — Crane's Memory	Old Man Crane offers hard lore, or warns the party that some hunts end only by sacrifice. If ignored, he goes alone into the deep dark. <i>Independent Survivors +1 if the party honors Crane's warning instead of treating him as a weapon.</i>
49	Day 49 · Act II — The Hollow Mother Declares	Awoko pamphlets, songs, and sermons spread through settlements. Civilian unrest rises. The cult claims the Quiet offers a way to stop being prey — to be remade into a hunter. <i>Awoko +2 if unopposed; Bureau and Independent trust may drop if the party ignores recruitment.</i>
58	Day 58 · Act III — The Means	If the party have recovered a piece of the Means, the dark and the Awoko both move to take it back. If they have none, a deep place offers a first true glimpse of what the

Day	Beat	Effect
	Surfaces	Quiet is.
66	Day 66 · Act III — Bureau Crisis	Central Command orders the Annex to prioritize Relic extraction over survivor recovery. Commander Park obeys, delays, or defies this order depending on party reputation and evidence recovered. <i>Bureau final-operation support depends on how the party handles Park's choice.</i>
74	Day 74 · Act III — Ritual of Becoming	The Awoko Sanctum reaches full ritual strength. If not disrupted, the Hollow Mother gains leverage over the final act and may try to make herself a new hunter as the party near the Threshold. <i>Awoko power rises. Sister Veil, Mara, or Whisper can still disrupt the rite if saved.</i>
80	Day 80 · Act III — Final Preparations	All major factions understand the final crossing is near. Allies must be chosen, debts come due, settlement trust is counted, and the old roads offer the shortest route under the worst terms. <i>All faction support is locked at the end of this stage unless the Warden allows a final dramatic reversal.</i>
84	Day 84 · Act III — The Threshold	The climax. The party make their last crossing through the deep dark to the sealed Threshold — to escape, or, with the Means assembled and at Level 9+, to make the one stand that ends the Quiet. Outside the Rift the Bureau floodlights gutter; inside, the Gloamreach goes utterly silent for the first time. If the party are not ready, escalate the hunt rather than forcing an ending by fiat. <i>All faction reputations convert into final-operation support, betrayal, neutrality, or obstruction.</i>

Appendix G — Handouts

Emergency Clearance: S-Rank Rift Entry **PLAYER**

EMERGENCY CLEARANCE

You are cleared for entry into the Gloamreach Rift Interior under crisis authority.

Return conditions: hostile neutralized, threshold re-secured, or emergency evacuation. (The interior may permit none of these.)

The Bureau accepts no liability for Anomaly exposure, Essence contamination, Relic corruption, psychological casualty, or failed extraction after threshold closure.

AFA Alert: Rift Interior Scale **PLAYER**

AFA ALERT

Rift threshold stabilized.

Interior mapping exceeds standard bounded Rift parameters.

Interior estimate: country-scale realm, old and inhabited.

Apex classification: a single intelligence that owns the dark; uncleared, likely unclearable.

Recommendation: do not enter without S-Rank command approval.

Override: emergency entry authorized.

Native Survival Card **PLAYER**

WHAT THE NATIVES TELL YOU

Stay quiet. Stay dark. Never use the power if you can help it.

Do not answer a voice you know after dark.

Do not speak your true name where the walls can hear.

Be behind a wardline before the grey light fails.

If it offers you something, it has already decided to take you.

Map Fragment: The Old Roads **PLAYER**

OLD ROADS FRAGMENT

The roads are the fast way and the exposed way. Walk them by grey light, in silence, never alone.

Marked safe-holds: Rift Threshold, Warded Hamlet, Vermillion Outpost, Drowned Ledgerfen, Remembering Orchard, Bastion Golemfall, Obsidian Spire.

Warning written in red pencil: "If you hear your name from off the road, do not answer. Do not even look."

Warded Hamlet House Rules **PLAYER**

HOUSE RULES

This community keeps the dark out by keeping these rules. Guests keep them too, or leave before dusk.

Bar every door at the second bell after dusk.

Burn no open light the dark can see. Use no Essence within the wards.

Speak no sleeper's name aloud after dark.

Break a rule and the wards will not protect you — and may not protect the rest of us either.

Vermillion Outpost Price Board **PLAYER**

VERMILLION OUTPOST PRICE BOARD

Soup: 1 clean core shaving.

Surgery: 3 clean Essence ampoules or future salvage share.

AFA battery: market rate plus oath.

Relic appraisal: free if we keep first refusal.

Rescue party: negotiable. Not cheap. Never free.

Bureau Annex Last Order **PLAYER**

LAST ORDER

All teams will hold assigned corridors until command updates the retreat route.

Do not abandon sealed supply rooms.

Do not answer anything that wears a face you know.

Do not deviate from Rank doctrine.

Addendum, unsent: there is no retreat route.

Bureau Casualty Tag **PLAYER**

CASUALTY TAG

Name: unreadable due to ash damage.

Rank: C provisional.

Cause: taken, then recovered by chance.

Notes: subject remained combat-effective after fatal wound for forty-seven seconds. Recommend commendation if remains recoverable.

Mill Work Token **PLAYER**

MILL TOKEN

Bearer is permitted through the outer wheelhouse for one shift.

No weapons beyond the red line.

No questions in the rendering room.

No refunds for partial processing.

Remembering Orchard Harvest Instructions PLAYER

REMEMBERING ORCHARD HARVEST

Cut only white-veined fruit.

Do not bleed near open flowers.

If fruit speaks, destroy it.

If fruit cries, leave the row immediately.

If the orchard turns toward you, kneel until it loses interest.

Aegis Oath Plate PLAYER

AEGIS OATH

Hold the line.

Hold the door.

Hold the wounded.

Hold when command fails.

Hold when law becomes teeth.

Hold until holding becomes the only part of you left.

Awoko Becoming Hymn PLAYER

HYMN OF BECOMING

The prey runs because prey must run.

The hunter waits because hunters can.

Why stay the hunted, the Mother asks, when the dark has shown the way?

Give grief and be spared.

Give blood and be remade.

Give all, and become.

Awoko Defector's Mark PLAYER

DEFECTOR MARK

A copper mask split down the mouth.

Anyone wearing this inside the Sanctum is marked for capture, not immediate execution.

The Hollow Mother wants defectors to sing apology before they die.

The Old Power — Consent Form PLAYER

CONSENT FORM

State the desired effect.

State the acceptable cost.

State whether the cost may be collected later.

Silence will be interpreted as consent to delayed collection.

The Old Power — Bargain Record PLAYER

BARGAIN RECORD

The offer worked.

That is the problem.

Effect granted:

Precedent established:

Visible consequence:

Ending consequence:

Predator Woods Trail Sign PLAYER

TRAIL SIGN

Three cuts in black bark: pack road.

Four cuts: breeding ground.

Five cuts: turn back.

Six cuts: you are already being tested.

White Heron Seal Notes PLAYER

WHITE HERON SEAL

The Quiet does not need to die for the way out to open — but it must be held.

Requirements:

- The Quiet forced into a silence and dark it cannot slip.
- The Means assembled: a truth, a way to hold it, a way to make it stay.
- A willing Ascendant to bear the backlash at the Threshold.
- A native ward-circle, built once, that the dark cannot cross.

Failure feeds the dark, and the door stays shut.

A Note in a Familiar Hand PLAYER

A NOTE, IN A HAND YOU KNOW

I have been waiting for you. It has been so long.

The way is just a little further in. Come and rest — you are so tired, and I have kept everything exactly the way you remember it.

Bring the others. But come.

(There is no signature. There does not need to be. You know the handwriting.)

Safe-Passage Token PLAYER

SAFE-PASSAGE TOKEN

A native ward-token. The bearers may pass one community's wardline once, in peace, by its keepers' leave.

Invalid if copied, burned, mocked, bloodied, folded into a weapon, or shown without the keeper's name.

The Final Crossing — Routes **PLAYER**

THE FINAL CROSSING — ROUTES

The Last Road: open, watched by the worn dead, survivable if silent.

Bastion Tunnel: mapped, collapsed, full of old oaths.

Awoko Breach: hidden, grief-choked, unstable.

Obsidian Spire Route: high, reflective, costly.

The Old Power Below: immediate, never free.

The Old Wards Fragment **PLAYER**

THE OLD WARDS (a native fragment)

What is loud is found. What is bright is found. What is strong is loudest of all.

A name spoken is a name given.

A door left open after dark is an invitation, whether you meant it or not.

The dead do not knock. They are simply, suddenly, inside.

A ward kept is a life kept. A ward broken is everyone's.

Rift Break Warning **PLAYER**

RIFT BREAK WARNING

Containment thinning.

Interior conditions detected at the threshold.

Anomaly migration probable.

Something inside is pressing on the boundary from the dark side.

Clear state required immediately.

Ending Ledger **PLAYER**

ENDING LEDGER

The Quiet's fate (escaped / killed / a new hunter rose):

Survivors extracted:

Communities saved:

Communities lost:

What the Old Power Below was owed:

Bureau public report:

Truth known to the party:

Warden Quick Reference **WARDEN**

QUICK REFERENCE

Fill the Hunt Clock, visibly, every time they live loud.

Every safe place has a cost and a rule.

Every Relic has a desire.

Every bargain leaves its mark.

The Quiet is not waiting at the end. It has been listening since the door closed.

Appendix H — Warden's Secrets

Secret 1 — What the Quiet Is **WARDEN-SECRET**

Warden ONLY. The Quiet is not, and was never, a person. It is the apex of the Gloamreach — old, vast, patient, hungry, and answerable to nothing. Whether it was always here or climbed out of being prey long ago (see the Obsidian Spire) is the campaign's deepest open question, and a piece of the Means. It did not lose its humanity. It never had any to lose.

Everything the party finds that suggests otherwise is bait. The Gloamreach keeps the relics of everyone it has taken — a Bureau Room that cannot exist, the Faded Family Photo, an Unopened Commendation, Ms. Park's Wedding Ring — and the Quiet wears the dead so perfectly that the party will be tempted to believe there is someone in there to save. There is not. The grief is real; those keepsakes belonged to real people the dark took. But none of them are *it*.

Play it so it lands: the party may spend the campaign hoping the thing wearing their dead can be reasoned with or redeemed, and learn — too late, or just in time — that the comfort was assembled, out of people they loved, to be reached for.

Reveal tools: the Faded Family Photo, Ms. Park's Wedding Ring, the Unopened Commendation, the deep places, the Obsidian Spire's Watcher, Old Man Crane's testimony, or the Old Power Below — each a piece of the truth the party can earn.

Secret 2 — The Means Is the Only Way to End It **WARDEN-SECRET**

Warden ONLY. The Quiet cannot be killed by force; ordinary harm barely marks it, and it withdraws into the dark to come again. The only way to end it is the Means, assembled in play and never handed over (see *The Means to End It*):

- **A truth** about what it is — and whether it was always here.
- **A way to hold it still** — forced silence and dark, a true name, a ward turned inward; a real Relic or working that can pin a thing never fully there.
- **A way to make it stay dead** — the Threshold, a ward-circle the natives build only once, or the dead-silent heart of a Mana Vein.

With all of it, and at 9th level or higher, the party can drag the Quiet down — for one brutal scene at the Threshold — into something they can actually kill. Without it, the attempt is a way to die. Escape is always the surer victory.

Secret 3 — The Hollow Mother Wants to Become WARDEN-SECRET

Warden ONLY. The Awoko Cult does not simply hide from the Quiet. The Hollow Mother intends to *become* something like it — to feed it enough grief, and enough of her own flock, that it remakes her into a hunter the dark will never touch.

Her followers say they serve, comfort, or remember. She rarely uses those words. Her true verb is become.

If the party weaken the Quiet's grip on a region but fail to disrupt the Ritual of Becoming, the Hollow Mother can become an endgame complication — racing them into the deep dark, trying to make herself a second apex at the worst possible moment (see Ch33 and the final crossing).

Secret 4 — The Worn Dead Can Be Outrun, Not Outfought WARDEN-SECRET

Warden ONLY. The worn dead — the lures and hunters the Quiet sends ahead (the Worn, the Caller, the Wrong Shape, the Hollowed) — are terrifying because there is always another. Put one down and it means nothing; the dark simply wears another face. They are limited only in this: they come for what the Quiet has marked, and they hunt by the same things it does — noise, light, Essence.

The party can turn the hunt aside without winning a fight by going silent and dark, hiding a marked one's name and scent, reaching a wardline, speaking a true name to break a lure, crossing running water or a hard threshold, or, at terrible cost, giving the dark what it came for.

This is the campaign's clearest lesson: surviving the Gloamreach means understanding what it is, not only hitting harder.

Secret 5 — The Hunt Is Pressure, Not Railroad WARDEN-SECRET

Warden ONLY. The Gloamreach has no countdown to a Rift Break and no clock ticking toward a final boss. The campaign escalates as *persecution* (see The Hunt Escalates): the Quiet grows bolder, the safe-holds fewer, the worn dead thicker, and the party's Dread and exhaustion mount — paced by the Hunt Clock and by what the party do, never by a calendar.

If the party act decisively, reward it. If they delay, rest carelessly, or live loud, escalate: a safe-hold falls, a known native is taken and worn, the worn dead hunt in daylight, the dark spreads to more of the map.

The pressure should keep them hunted — never safe for long, always one rule behind. It should not steal agency.

Plot Beat — The Faded Family Photo **PLOT-BEAT**

The Faded Family Photo is the strongest emotional prop in the campaign — a lost face worn down to blank paper. It can be recovered in Day Zero, the Drowned Ledgerfen, or deep in the Gloamreach.

If the party carry it, the Quiet learns that face, and may one day wear it back at them — calling in that voice, from the dark, at the worst possible moment. Play it ambiguously: a genuine echo of someone the dark took, or a predator performing exactly the reunion the party most want to see. Either reading can buy a beat of doubt, colder resolve, or a fragile opening — and either way, it is bait.

Plot Beat — Blackwood's Classified Mission **PLOT-BEAT**

Agent Kira Blackwood was sent to read pre-threshold resonance — the first hint of the Means surfacing on the material side — before the Bureau had confirmed the Gloamreach was an uncleared, inhabited Interior. Her findings are classified above the party's clearance.

She is not working against them. Her danger is institutional loyalty under pressure: she may withhold classified data, default to protocol when instinct says otherwise, or level with the party — depending on how they handle Bureau trust.

Use Blackwood to show that the Bureau can be brave in the field and bound by caution at command level at the same time — overwhelmed and rule-bound, never dishonest.

Plot Beat — Sister Veil Can Break the Chant **PLOT-BEAT**

Sister Veil knows the Ritual of Becoming math is wrong. She does not begin as a hero. She begins as someone honest enough to admit the numbers prove her faith will consume its own followers, and offer them to the dark for nothing.

If the party give her evidence and protect her during the Sanctum raid, she can corrupt the final chant and stop the Hollow Mother from being remade during the finale.

Pressure Clock — Quiet-Marked **PRESSURE-CLOCK**

Track whether each character becomes Quiet-Marked. This is the dark having their name (see Day Zero and the Hollow Way).

A marked character is easier for the Quiet and its worn dead to recognize, single out, and hunt; the worn dead come for them first. They may also receive dreams and messages through reflective surfaces.

Common triggers: speaking or giving a true name to the dark, accepting dangerous false-safety, being struck by the Diagnosed's gaze, reading one's own name on the road or the walls, or carrying a piece of the Means openly.

Removal: the Quiet is ended, the character makes it back across the Threshold, or a major Relic-tier intervention takes a name back from the dark.

Pressure Clock — The Hunt **PRESSURE-CLOCK**

See `sandbox-timeline.ts` for the full persecution track — pressure paced by the Hunt Clock and the party's choices, not a calendar. Key beats by act:

- Act I (L1-3) · First Contact: the threshold seals, the AFA lies, the first taking (ideally an NPC).
- Act II (L4-6) · The Hunt: the worn dead hunt in earnest; the first time the Quiet wears a face the party know.
- Act III (L7-9) · The Long Dark: safe-holds fail; the party learn the first true things about the Quiet and assemble the Means.
- Act IV (L9-10) · Threshold: escape, or the one gated-kill stand.

Appendix I – The Quiet and Its Worn Dead

The Quiet is never a stand-up fight until the very end. These blocks cover the worn dead it sends ahead — the lures and hunters that can intrude on any zone — and, last, the apex itself, for the gated endgame. For most of the campaign the Quiet takes a character when the Hunt Clock peaks rather than rolling initiative; see "Running This Horror." Remember that ordinary combat means noise, light, and Essence, and every one of those fills the Hunt Clock — so even these lesser hunts draw the apex closer.

The Worn

Medium · Lure (Worn Dead) · Rank D, neutral evil

Armor Class 13 (a dead thing that does not flinch)

Hit Points 78 (12d8 + 24)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	AGI	VIT	INT	SEN	PRE
14 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	6 (-2)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)

Skills Stealth +5, Deception +4

Damage Resistances necrotic

Damage Immunities poison

Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 30 ft., passive Perception 10

Languages the last words its body knew, repeated wrong

Challenge 1 (200 XP) · **Proficiency Bonus** +2

A corpse the Quiet wears like a coat and leaves walking — the still figure at the roadside, the neighbour who went into the dark and came back wrong. The Worn lure the living with half-remembered faces and broken voices, then ambush whoever comes close. Killing one is easy and means nothing; there is always another face.

Vulnerable to. Fire; A true name spoken aloud

Traits

Borrowed Face. At a distance and in poor light, the Worn appears as someone a viewer has lost. A creature that approaches within 30 feet may make a DC 12 Sense check to catch the one detail that is wrong before the Worn strikes.

Still Until It Isn't. While motionless the Worn is indistinguishable from a corpse or a frightened survivor. Its first attack against a creature that has not noticed it is made with advantage and is a surprise strike.

Actions

Grasp and Pull. Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 11 (2d8 + 2) necrotic damage, and the target is grappled (escape DC 12) as the Worn drags it toward the dark.

Call a Name. Recharge 6. The Worn speaks a name one creature has lost. That creature must succeed on a DC 12 Sense saving throw or move toward the Worn by the safest-seeming route on its next turn.

The Caller

Medium · Lure (Worn Dead) · Rank C, neutral evil

Armor Class 14 (natural armor)

Hit Points 123 (13d8 + 65)

Speed 30 ft.

STR	AGI	VIT	INT	SEN	PRE
13 (+1)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	9 (-1)	16 (+3)	17 (+3)

Saving Throws Sense +5

Skills Stealth +6, Deception +6

Damage Resistances necrotic, psychic

Damage Immunities poison

Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 60 ft., passive Perception 12

Languages every lost voice it has collected

Challenge 4 (1,100 XP) · **Proficiency Bonus** +2

A worn dead the Quiet sets at the edge of safe places. It stands just past the wardline and calls in the voices of the lost — patient, tireless — until someone breaks the rules and goes to it. The Caller rarely fights; it splits the party and feeds the strays to the dark.

Vulnerable to. Fire; A true name spoken aloud

Traits

Voice of the Lost. The Caller perfectly mimics any voice it has heard a creature grieve. Checks to recognize it as false are made with disadvantage.

It Will Wait. The Caller takes no aggressive action against a target who stays behind a native ward. It simply calls, and lets the rules do its work.

Actions

Come Here. The Caller calls in a voice a creature has lost. Each creature within 120 feet that can hear it must succeed on a DC 14 Sense saving throw or move its full speed toward the Caller by the most direct safe-seeming path. A creature that takes damage may repeat the save at the end of its turn.

Open Throat. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target it has lured adjacent. Hit: 27 (6d6 + 6) necrotic damage.

The Wrong Shape

Medium · Hunter (Worn Dead) · Rank B, neutral evil

Armor Class 15 (preternatural quickness)

Hit Points 168 (16d8 + 96)

Speed 40 ft.

STR	AGI	VIT	INT	SEN	PRE
17 (+3)	18 (+4)	18 (+4)	11 (+0)	16 (+3)	16 (+3)

Saving Throws Agility +7, Sense +6

Skills Stealth +9, Deception +7

Damage Resistances necrotic, psychic, bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities poison

Condition Immunities charmed, frightened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 60 ft., passive Perception 14

Languages the voice of whoever it wears

Challenge 7 (2,900 XP) · **Proficiency Bonus** +3

When the Quiet wants to hunt rather than lure, it wears someone well and sends them in close — a teammate, a friend, a face the party trusts — and lets them be wrong only once it is too late. The Wrong Shape is fast, quiet, and patient enough to walk beside the party for a while first.

Vulnerable to. Fire; Being named for what it is

Traits

Wears a Trusted Face. The Wrong Shape flawlessly impersonates a specific person the party knows, living or dead. Until it acts against them, seeing the truth requires a DC 18 Sense check made with disadvantage; the party gets one free check only after it gets a single small detail wrong.

Sudden. Its first attack against a creature that still believes it is the person it wears scores a critical hit on a roll of 18-20.

Actions

Multiattack. The Wrong Shape makes two Rend attacks.

Rend. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 22 (4d8 + 4) necrotic damage.

Wear You Down. Recharge 5-6. The Wrong Shape speaks every cruel true thing in the voice of someone the target trusts. One creature within 30 feet must make a DC 15 Sense saving throw, taking 27 (6d8) psychic damage and gaining a point of Dread on a failure (see Running This Horror), or half as much damage on a success.

The Hollowed

Large · Apex Fragment (Worn Dead) · Rank A, neutral evil

Armor Class 17 (the dark clings to it)

Hit Points 228 (24d10 + 96)

Speed 40 ft., climb 30 ft.

STR	AGI	VIT	INT	SEN	PRE
20 (+5)	18 (+4)	18 (+4)	13 (+1)	20 (+5)	18 (+4)

Saving Throws Agility +8, Vitality +8, Sense +9

Skills Stealth +12, Perception +9

Damage Resistances necrotic, psychic, bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities poison

Condition Immunities blinded, charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 90 ft., tremorsense 60 ft., passive Perception 19

Languages the stolen voices of many dead

Challenge 11 (7,200 XP) · **Proficiency Bonus** +4

Deep in the Gloamreach, where the Quiet's attention pools, the worn dead stop being lures and become something closer to the thing that wears them — a hollowed apex-fragment that hunts like the Quiet in miniature. The Hollowed is the hardest thing the party can actually kill, and the surest sign they are nearing where the means to end the Quiet might be found.

Vulnerable to. Massed light and silence together; A true thing it cannot abide

Traits

Echo of the Quiet. The Hollowed is almost never seen until it strikes; it has advantage on Stealth and cannot be tracked by sound. The first time it appears in a scene, each creature that can sense it must succeed on a DC 16 Sense saving throw or gain a point of Dread.

Drawn to Power. The Hollowed has advantage on attacks against any creature that used an Awakened ability, Sigil, or technique since the Hollowed's last turn. Using Essence near it is, as ever, a mistake.

Legendary Resistance (1/Day). If the Hollowed fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead.

Actions

Multiattack. The Hollowed makes two Claim attacks.

Claim. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 27 (4d10 + 5) necrotic damage, and the target cannot regain hit points until the start of its next turn.

Into the Dark. Recharge 5-6. The light gutters out in a 20-foot radius around the Hollowed. Each creature in it must make a DC 17 Sense saving throw, taking 36 (8d8) psychic damage and being unable to see beyond 5 feet until the end of its next turn on a failure, or half as much damage on a success.

Reactions

Slip the Light. When a creature the Hollowed can see ends its turn in bright light, the Hollowed may move up to its speed toward the nearest darkness without provoking opportunity attacks.

The Quiet

Large · Apex Anomaly · Rank S, neutral evil

Armor Class 19 (it is never fully seen)

Hit Points 444 (36d10 + 246)

Speed 40 ft., climb 40 ft.

STR	AGI	VIT	INT	SEN	PRE
24 (+7)	22 (+6)	24 (+7)	19 (+4)	26 (+8)	22 (+6)

Saving Throws Agility +13, Vitality +14, Sense +15

Skills Stealth +20, Perception +15

Damage Resistances bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities necrotic, poison

Condition Immunities blinded, charmed, exhaustion, frightened, poisoned

Senses blindsight 60 ft., tremorsense 120 ft. (it hunts by sound and the use of power, not sight), passive Perception 25

Languages understands every tongue the dead it has worn once spoke; answers only in stolen voices

Challenge 21 (33,000 XP) · **Proficiency Bonus** +7

The apex predator of the Gloamreach, and the reason the Interior cannot be cleared. The Quiet is almost never seen; it is felt — a cold, a pressure, a silence where insect-sound should be. It hunts by noise, light, and the use of Essence, wears the faces and voices of the dead to lure prey into the dark, and cannot be put down by ordinary force. A stand-up fight with it is a party's last mistake — until, at high tier and with the right means assembled, it finally isn't. Use this block for the gated endgame attempt and for the rare moment the party must survive it directly; most of the campaign, the Quiet takes a character when the Hunt Clock peaks rather than rolling initiative.

Vulnerable to. Only truly killable once the party is 9th level or higher and has assembled the means to end it (see the Run Silent module)

Traits

Drawn to the Living. The Quiet always knows the direction and rough distance of the loudest source of noise, light, or Essence use within the Interior, and moves toward it. Whenever a creature within one mile makes a loud noise, lights a flame, or uses an Awakened ability, Sigil, or technique, the Warden advances the Hunt Clock (see Running This Horror).

Nothing Ordinary Can End It. Until the party has assembled the means to end the Quiet (a Warden-tracked campaign condition) AND is 9th level or higher, the Quiet cannot be reduced below 1 hit point. At the end of any turn on which it took damage, it withdraws into the dark and is gone, returning when the Hunt Clock next peaks. Once both conditions are met this trait ends, and the Quiet can be killed normally — though it fights to the last and takes someone with it if it can.

Wears the Dead. The Quiet can perfectly mimic the appearance and voice of any dead creature it has touched. Any check or effect to discern its true nature is made with disadvantage. It always gets one small detail deliberately wrong; a creature with cause to be suspicious may make a DC 20 Sense check to catch it.

Legendary Resistance (3/Day). If the Quiet fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead.

It Is Already Here. The Quiet cannot be surprised, ignores difficult terrain, and is not slowed by closed doors, walls, or darkness. It cannot cross a native wardline it has not been let past — but the living rarely keep perfect silence behind one.

Actions

Multiattack. The Quiet makes two Take attacks.

Take. Melee Weapon Attack: +11 to hit, reach 10 ft., one target. Hit: 39 (6d10 + 6) necrotic damage, and the target's hit point maximum is reduced by an amount equal to the damage taken until it finishes a long rest. A creature reduced to 0 hit points by this attack is taken — gone into the dark, to be worn later.

The Silence. Recharge 5–6. A 30-foot-radius sphere of absolute dark and silence centered on the Quiet. Each creature in the area must make a DC 20 Sense saving throw, taking 55 (10d10) psychic damage and becoming frightened of the Quiet until the end of its next turn on a failure, or half as much damage on a success. No sound or light can exist inside the sphere until the start of the Quiet's next turn.

Wear a Face. The Quiet takes the shape and voice of a dead creature one target loved or lost. That target must succeed on a DC 20 Sense saving throw or be unable to attack the Quiet, and unable to move away from it, until the end of its next turn.

Reactions

Never Quite There. When the Quiet is hit by an attack while Nothing Ordinary Can End It is active, it halves the damage and may immediately move up to half its speed without provoking opportunity attacks.

Lair Actions

The Lights Die. On initiative count 20 (losing ties), all nonmagical light within 120 feet of the Quiet gutters to darkness, and magical light of 3rd level or lower is suppressed until the next round.

It Heard That. A creature that made noise or used Essence since the last lair action has disadvantage on the next saving throw it makes against the Quiet, and the Hunt Clock advances by one.

Borrowed Voice. A voice one creature has lost calls from somewhere in the dark. That creature must succeed on a DC 18 Sense saving throw or move its speed toward the voice by the most direct route, taking the path that seems safest into the worst danger.

Legendary Actions

Drift. The Quiet moves up to its speed without a sound and without provoking opportunity attacks.

Listen. The Quiet learns the exact location of every creature that made noise or used Essence since the start of its last turn.

Take (Costs 2 Actions). The Quiet makes one Take attack.

Appendix J — Warden's Quick Reference

The Golden Rule. The Quiet is not a fight to win; it is a pressure to survive. Loud, bright, and powerful are dangerous. Silence, dark, restraint, and the natives' rules are the only safety. Make the quiet choice the smart one and the strong choice the loud one.

The Hunt Clock — 6 segments

Fill +1: a loud noise · open light in the dark · breaking a native ward or rule · lingering or resting in exposed ground. **Using Essence fills +1 (+2 for a large or sustained use)** — this is the big one.

Empty –1: reach a warded safe-hold, or spend a whole scene in silence, dark, and stillness. It never resets on its own.

At 6 — it strikes. Not the full stat block; a persecution beat. It **takes a character** (the most exposed, the loudest, the one who burned the most Essence), or forces a desperate hide-or-flee set-piece with a life on the line. Then reset the clock to **2** — it is closer now, and it knows where they are.

Drawn to Three Things

Noise — footfalls, voices, gunfire, a dropped pack, a scream.

Light — open flame, a torch, a flare, the glow of a screen.

Essence — every technique, Sigil, or Awakened ability rings through the Interior like a struck bell. Their greatest strength is the thing most likely to get them killed.

Essence Is Bait

Every use advances the Hunt Clock and, deep in the Gloamreach, draws the worn dead. Make spending power a real, costly choice. The natives never use it if they can help it — and resent outsiders who do.

Dread — each character, 0-6

Dread	Effect
1–2	Unsettled. No mechanical effect — describe the fraying.
3	Shaken — disadvantage on the first save each scene against fear or the uncanny.
4	Fraying — once per scene the Warden may have the character mis-see an ally as the Quiet, or hear a lure in a trusted voice.
5	Breaking — disadvantage on checks while any familiar face is present; may act on a hallucination once.
6	Unmade — at the worst moment the character does the thing that gets someone taken. Player keeps agency; Warden gains one hard complication.

Drops by 1 per full rest in a true safe-hold, or by a real moment of human connection, comfort, or native kindness.

The Gated Kill — both locks, late

Lock 1 · Tier: the party is **9th level or higher**. Below that no means matters; any attempt is a way to die.

Lock 2 · The Means (assembled in play, never handed over, never a checklist): **a truth** about what it is · **a way to hold it still** (a real Relic, weapon, or working) · **a way to make it stay dead** (the threshold, a one-time native ward-circle, a dawn).

When It Takes Someone

It rarely kills — it **takes**, dragging into the dark. Across the campaign use all three: **gone** for good (a real loss) · **recoverable** by a fast, desperate rescue · **returned later, worn** — walking, talking, almost right, and not theirs. Always a cost, always survivable for the rest, never a TPK.

Three Endings

Spent fully, the Means drags the Quiet down to something a level-10 party can kill — no lair actions, cannot simply *take* a character, pinned where the kill lands.

Kill = the way out. The Quiet holds the threshold shut; put it down for good and the seal fails — the party walk out free, the country's fate left open. **Escape is always the surer victory.**

Escape — flee; the Quiet lives and the country stays hunted. **Kill** — end it; the seal breaks, the party leave free, the future open. **Become** — a character takes the predator's path and is remade as a new apex of the Gloamreach.